

George Packer on
VC Populism

Soraya Nadia McDonald
on Denyce Graves

Adam Kirsch
on UFOs

Plus: New Fiction
by Stephen King



The Atlantic

EST. 1857

THE MEN WHO FEAR WOMEN

BY HELEN LEWIS

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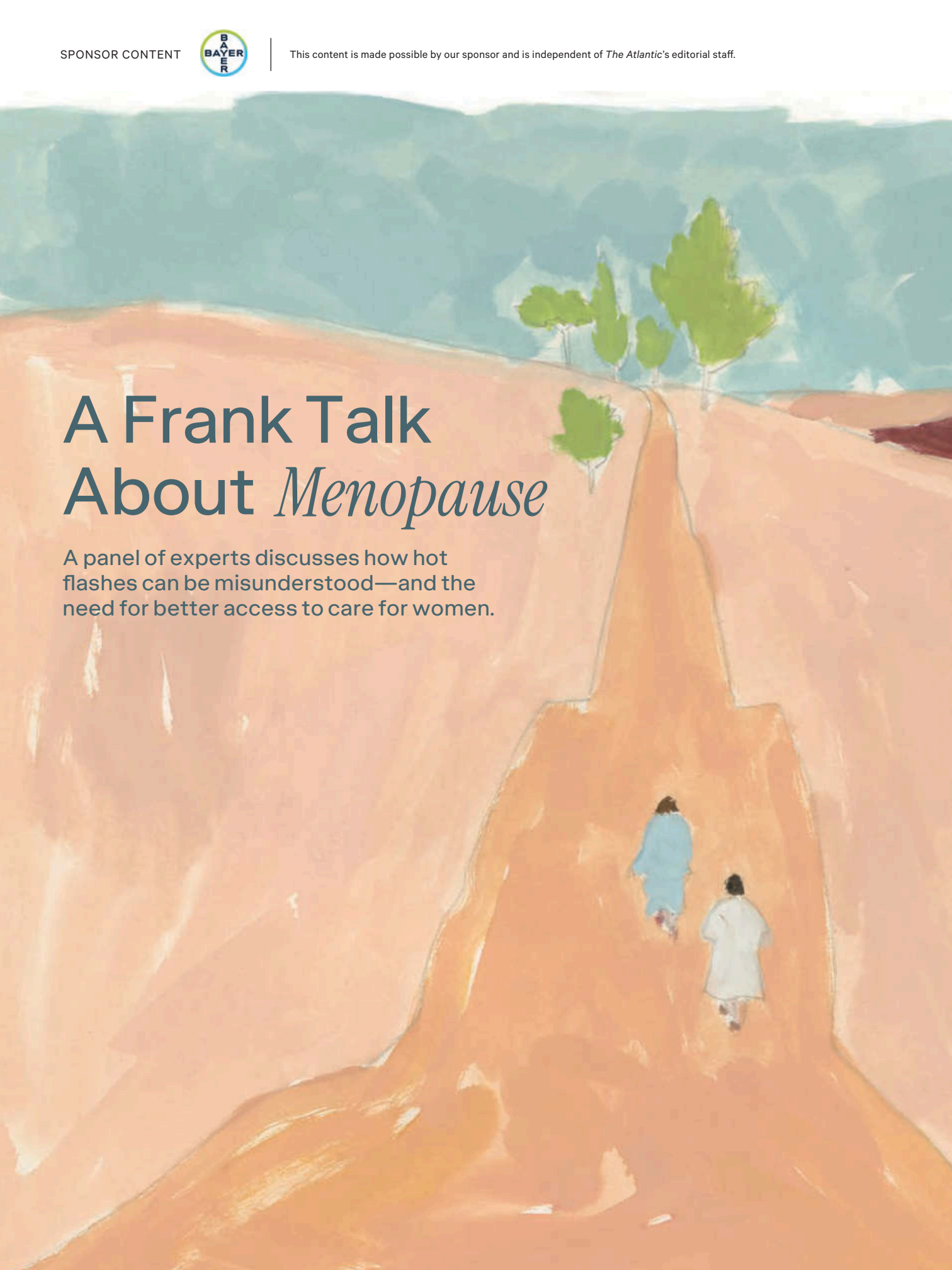


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A Frank Talk About *Menopause*

A panel of experts discusses how hot flashes can be misunderstood—and the need for better access to care for women.



“

Many women don't get enough education about what menopause is, even just the definition of it or when symptoms like hot flashes can begin.

We need to talk more about hot flashes—and, crucially, how women can get better access to care during a life stage they will inevitably experience.

That was the message from a group of menopause experts, healthcare providers, and women's health advocates at a roundtable discussion sponsored by Bayer and co-hosted by Atlantic Re:think in Orlando, Florida.

The event, “Why Hot Flashes Deserve the Spotlight,” offered a revealing glimpse into attitudes and education around hot flashes and menopause. The panelists agreed that transparent and thoughtful conversations between women and their healthcare providers is an important first step for women in menopause to get better care.

Dr. Sheryl Kingsberg, an event panelist and Division Chief, OB/GYN Behavioral Medicine at University Hospitals of Cleveland, has found in her experience that many women have been misinformed or underinformed about menopause and have been unlikely to talk about it openly. That's changing, she says, but there is still more work to be done to encourage women to talk openly.

“In my 30 years of experience, I've found that many women don't get enough education about what menopause is,” says Dr. Kingsberg, “even just the definition of it or when symptoms like hot flashes can begin.”

Every day, an estimated 6,000 women in the United States reach menopause.¹ The stereotypical symptom of menopause is hot

flashes. But menopause, a life stage marked by the permanent cessation of menstrual periods for 12 months, can cause a range of symptoms, and hot flashes can start several years before a woman actually enters menopause.²

Menopause marks a shift for millions of women, but women vary widely in their experience of symptom severity as well as management of these symptoms. According to panelist Michelle Minus Swittenberg, the Executive Vice President of Enterprise Operations at Black Women's Health Imperative, a national organization dedicated to improving the health and wellness of Black women and girls, it's not uncommon for Black women to feel less heard in medical settings.

“Not knowing what to expect from menopause is the same for Black women as it is for white women, except that it's complicated by the disparities that Black women experience in healthcare in general,” says Swittenberg. “Black women tend to be less seen, heard, and believed in medical settings, and this creates a barrier to meaningful dialogue, and therefore lessens the likelihood that Black women are receiving help in addressing menopause symptoms, like hot flashes.”

As menopause conversations expand in scope and visibility, open dialogue with friends and clinicians about symptoms like hot flashes can help women feel more supported while encouraging more inclusive, informed conversations about menopause care.

¹Whiteley J, DiBonaventura Md, Wagner JS, Alvir J, Shah S. The impact of menopausal symptoms on quality of life, productivity, and economic outcomes. J Womens Health (Larchmt). 2013 Nov;22(11):983-90. doi: 10.1089/jwh.2012.3719. Epub 2013 Oct 1. PMID: 24083674; PMCID: PMC3820128

²Peacock K, Carlson K, Ketvertis KM. Menopause. [Updated 2023 Dec 21]. In: StatPearls [Internet]. Treasure Island, FL: StatPearls Publishing; 2024 Jan-. Available from: <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/books/NBK507826/>. PP-UN-WHC-US-0248 4/26

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Even as an All-Star, Hill saw beyond the game. Inspired by parents who modeled excellence beyond athletics, he began preparing early for what came next. By his rookie season, franchise ownership was already the goal. He was playing for the end game.

Today, as a co-owner of professional sports franchises, investor, and broadcaster, Hill leads off the court much the way he did on it; with preparation, accountability, and vision. Often, that thinking

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OF NO PARTY OR CLIQUE

VOL. 337-NO. 6

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The Indianapolis Clowns before a March game at AutoZone Park, in Memphis

A photograph of an industrial building at dusk. In the foreground, a large, dark metal structure, possibly a sculpture or part of a building's framework, is visible. The background shows a light-colored, textured wall of a building with various pipes and utility lines. The sky is a mix of blue and orange, indicating sunset or sunrise.

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LIZ HART

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Behind the Cover: In this month's cover story, "The Men Who Don't Want Women to Vote" (p. 26), Helen Lewis argues that "masculinism"—a movement seeking to counter the advances of feminism and place men back at the center of public life—has become the most important uniting force on the American

right. Many men are drawn to masculinism, Lewis writes, because they feel that they have lost status to women. For the cover, we depicted the fear that undergirds their resentment: A rough silhouette of a man runs toward the viewer, looking over his shoulder at an imagined threat.

—Liz Hart, *Art Director*

THE



The Purged

*Donald Trump's destruction
of the civil service is a
tragedy not just for the
roughly 300,000 workers
who have been discarded,
but for an entire nation,
Franklin Foer wrote in the
February issue.*

Letters



I read Franklin Foer's "The Purged" in one held breath. This is how to weigh the stakes of our political moment—one life at a time. No statistic can adequately describe America's losses. Each of the 50 people profiled in Foer's essay is so gifted and generous, so essential to what the United States means—or at least to what it used to mean. I salute Foer's courage to tell the story head-on. His narrative journalism is letting us see one another whole.

Rita Charon
New York, N.Y.

There but for the grace of God go I. I never worked directly for the federal government, but I did research and consulting as a

contractor for the Department of Energy's National Laboratories, the Environmental Protection Agency, and the National Center for Atmospheric Research. I am a meteorologist, an atmospheric physicist, and an environmental economist, now retired. I worked on significant problems, including air quality, acid deposition, and the safety of liquefied gases. I developed simulation techniques for the accidental release of toxic chemicals. I don't know the people in the article personally, but I do *know* them—I know their value. Their individual loss is our national loss.

Daniel J. McNaughton
Newport, R.I.

I worked in state government for 29 years. Franklin Foer's 50 profiles are an important reminder that we'll feel the consequences of Donald Trump's purge for decades. I tend to think of government work as that of quiet competence. When we travel on interstate highways, we do not think about the work done to locate an appropriate site for a road, to build it, and then to maintain it. When we fly, we hope that the plane meets safety standards but spare little thought for the federal staff who developed those standards and enforce them for our benefit.

I was reminded of the importance of federal expertise last year, when the remnants



of Hurricane Helene roared through the mountains and left astounding damage to public and private infrastructure. The *Mitchell News-Journal*, the local paper in rural Mitchell County, North Carolina, has on multiple occasions reported on confusion among employees of the Federal Emergency Management Agency over how to follow the agency's own internal guidelines. I am sure that FEMA can and should be made more efficient. But destroying morale and stirring chaos with on-again, off-again layoffs is certainly not the way to do it.

John Dorney
Durham, N.C.

I am a retired federal civil servant and a disabled veteran. I worked for the U.S. Postal Service for many years. I always took great pride in my desire to go above and beyond to help others get what they wanted or needed. On behalf of the millions of current and former federal civil-service employees, I am truly grateful for Franklin Foer's research and reporting in this article.

In my 32-year career, the other civil-service employees and members of the military I worked alongside were dedicated, honest, and hardworking professionals. When I started to hear claims that federal employees were overpaid poor performers, or that they supported a particular political

agenda that undermined the administration's, or that they amounted to an unelected, overly partisan bureaucracy, I was shocked. These claims were so the opposite of my own experience that I thought surely anyone hearing them would disregard them as false.

Nyleen Mullally
Rapid City, S.D.

I was very moved by the depth of reporting in Franklin Foer's story on purged government employees. The profiles helped fill in the picture—that these are real people, and that their absence will be felt for a very long time. The damage to our culture and our progress as a nation is much larger than many people realize. Thank you for

helping us keep that fact front of mind, now and into the future. I hope some of this strength can be rebuilt—but first we'll need to rebuild the reputation of government.

Evelyn Luengas
Fort Worth, Texas

To respond to *Atlantic* articles or submit author questions to The Commons, please email letters@theatlantic.com. Include your full name, city, and state.

FROM THE ARCHIVES

"I was holding myself together, but just barely," Sherry Winfield confesses in "Dinah's Hat" (p. 94), a new short story by Stephen King. Sherry and her friend Morris have just ventured from their trailer park to a beach with Dinah, the mysterious child Morris cares for; there, they encounter a group of young bullies. "In time," Sherry recalls thinking of the events that follow, "I'll be able to convince myself that never happened."

"Dinah's Hat" isn't the first work of fiction King has written for *The Atlantic*.

In the magazine's May 2011 issue, he published "Herman Wouk Is Still Alive," a short story told from the perspective of two aging poets, Phil and Pauline, picnicking at a rest stop in Maine, and two mothers, Brenda and Jasmine, eager to take their children on a road trip up I-95. Compared with much of King's other work, the horrors of "Herman Wouk Is Still Alive" are fairly quotidian—dead-end jobs and deadbeat dads, aging, depression. The story, nevertheless, builds to a haunting conclusion.

In a 2011 interview with *The Atlantic's* James Parker, King explained that the story had emerged

from a bet with his son Owen on that year's NCAA basketball tournament: The winner would provide a title for a short story; the loser would have to write it. Owen, victorious, proffered the phrase "Herman Wouk Is Still Alive," inspired by news coverage he'd read that Wouk, the Pulitzer Prize-winning author of *War and Remembrance* and *The Caine Mutiny*, was still writing well into his 90s. In King's eventual story, Phil and Pauline read a fictionalized *New York Times* article testifying to Wouk's longevity. "The ideas don't stop just because one is old," Wouk tells his interviewer. "The body weakens,

but the words never do." His sentiment inspires the two poets, both in their 70s—until, moments later, tragedy renders language powerless.

Wouk himself was asked about King's story in a Q&A published with his 2012 novel, *The Lawgiver*. "I read Mr. King's short story and enjoyed it," Wouk said. "As for the longevity, I share his evident puzzlement, with boundless gratitude to my forebears and my Maker." He continued, "It helps to have work I love, with much work yet to do by His grace." Wouk died in 2019, just 10 days before his 104th birthday.

— Andrew Aoyama,
Deputy Managing Editor



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DISPATCHES

OPENING ARGUMENT

THE AMERICA I'VE KNOWN

*In my 93rd year, it's become
ever more clear that
patriotism requires sacrifice
and collective effort.*

BY FRAN
MORELAND JOHNS

Lately, I've come to notice that the strangest and most terrible pieces of my childhood are roaring back. I was born in 1933, and much of what I remember as a little girl was defined by either the war or what we called, simply, sickness.

I myself was blessed with exceptionally good health, but my friends, family, and community were regularly struck with childhood diseases. Neighborhoods were frozen in fear when maladies suddenly erupted: pool closures during polio epidemics, quarantines when mumps or measles raged. I remember one particularly galling time when my older sister Mimi and I were confined to the house, morosely watching our friends playing

on the construction site of a new house across the street. We were fine; they all had whooping cough. Whooping cough was often deadly for babies and toddlers but among the less debilitating of childhood diseases past for older children, thus the freedom to play while coughing. Neither Mimi nor I ever caught it—a fact I was grateful for 40 years later, when I met with a pulmonologist about my cigarette-compromised lungs and he remarked, “At least you never had whooping cough.”

We did, however, catch chicken pox simultaneously with our older sisters, Jane and Helen; we were then 5, 7, 11, and 13. Just thinking of it can resurrect the itch. (And lest I forget, some 70 years later, following a time of extended stress, that long-dormant varicella-zoster virus returned as a bout of shingles.) But that was nothing compared with the measles Jane contracted. Memories of those days, among the most vivid of my early life, still evoke tremors in the bottom of my stomach. There was widespread fear of measles causing blindness, which had indeed happened to a young family acquaintance. So for several days at the height of her illness, Jane was quarantined in one bedroom while Helen moved in with Mimi and me. The shades were drawn and curtains closed in Jane’s room, and the door was opened only after the hallway was darkened. She survived—and later went on to become a wife, mother, and well-regarded artist. But that was just the luck of the draw. Measles killed some 10,000 American children in the 1930s and ’40s—roughly 500 kids died every year. In my

generation, we were the guinea pigs for what science would soon discover: This pesky childhood sickness increases the risk of stroke, chronic lung problems, and impaired neurodevelopment.

Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. was not born yet when all of this took place. By the time he turned 13, in 1967, most of the diseases that ravaged my childhood had been eradicated by the vaccines he now disdains. The unfortunate thing about that disdain is that Kennedy has the power to impose his bizarre notions on the entire country. It’s too bad that we have no way to time-capsule him back several decades (or time-travel forward, for that matter) in hopes that he might understand the havoc he will wreak upon future generations.

RFK Jr. would have liked my friend Jack, a rambunctious child given to sudden mischief. Jack was part of a foursome, the others being Mary Sue and Tommy and me. We bonded days after I arrived in Ashland, Virginia, having just turned 6. For several years we were inseparable, even when Jack developed rheumatic fever and was bedridden for weeks. We simply detoured from climbing trees and playing ball into spending afternoons staging battles with toy soldiers on his bed or listening, enraptured, to his favorite radio serials, including *The Lone Ranger* and *Jack Armstrong, the All-American Boy*. Jack was isolated even from the three of us when whooping cough rampaged through the town, but he still managed to catch that too. He died of heart failure at age 19; how much of that good young heart’s failure was due to those earlier illnesses, we’ll never know. That

was more than half a century ago. I never forgot Jack. I wish I could tell Kennedy about him, and the pain his death caused everyone who loved him.

The other childhood friend I would most like our health secretary to know is Susan, who moved to our neighborhood in second grade and

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HE NOW
DISDAINS.

contracted polio when we were in our early teens. I remember being taken to visit her when she was in an iron lung. Though she was in a highly restricted part of the hospital, I was allowed to visit, largely because she was not expected to live and we were desperate to see each other. In those days of family doctors who made house calls for everything but major emergencies, I had been in a hospital once or twice at most. I knew all about the iron lung and was thoroughly familiar with Susan’s precarious state; still, I was not prepared for the sight of a giant monster of a machine on sturdy legs, with only my friend’s head protruding from one end.

There were six of them in all, I think, in a cold room smelling of ether and rubbing alcohol: six futuristic creatures with human heads. Nurses

in starched white uniforms and rubber-soled white shoes walked wordlessly among the machines, which kept up a steady thrum as they forced air in and out of failing lungs. Susan’s mother stood on one side, stroking her daughter’s hair, while Susan and I talked in voices just above a whisper, as if we were in church. She wanted to tell me about the boy who had been in the iron lung behind where I sat, who was there when she arrived but a few days ago had vanished. There was only one other visitor, another mother stroking another small head. Happy as I was to see Susan, I couldn’t help wondering if I would be able to summon the courage to endure such hardship just to survive. But survive she did, unexpectedly, to live to adulthood with some disabilities.

The disabilities resulting from those childhood diseases far exceeded the recorded life-and-death statistics: the compromised lungs, the weakened hearts, the bones and muscles and systems unable to develop as they might have. It’s impossible to calculate the awful toll. Vaccines, though, changed it all, essentially vanquishing those diseases in the United States and much of the rest of the world. The rejection of science is sending us back to those dark ages.

WHEN I WAS 12, Americans everywhere threw what can only be described as a two-day party. It was 1945, and Japan had surrendered. Euphoria swept across the country, including in small towns like Ashland, where my friends and I had pulled red wagons around to gather scrap for the war effort. There had been a slight exhaling of breath the

previous May, on what came to be known as V-E Day, and another one after the bombs were dropped on Hiroshima and Nagasaki in August. (Only later would I learn the grim moral complexity of such weapons.) But with the end of the war came a widespread belief that lasting peace was no longer just a dream. Flags went up on every front porch, the sounds of long-hoarded firecrackers pierced the air, perfect strangers hugged each other on sidewalks, and high-school bands paraded in the streets.

Those of us who are now in our 90s might be forgiven a twinge of nostalgia for that moment. But this is no plea to return to some imaginary good old days. Indelibly etched into my brain are memories from the decade leading up to our entry into the war. I was 4, at most, the night my father woke Mimi and me in what seemed the middle of the night and gently carried us downstairs into the living room. He deposited us on the floor in front of the Philco radio. We sat at the feet of our mother, who was on the sofa darning socks. There were crackling sounds coming from the radio, someone speaking over the noise of a crowd. My father explained that we were in no danger but that terrible things were happening in the world, largely because of one very bad man, and he wanted us to hear what this madman sounded like: Adolf Hitler on a shortwave-radio broadcast. We, of course, had no idea what Hitler was saying. But the angry shouts to a cheering crowd, sounds reinforced later in newsreel clips shown at movies we occasionally attended, carried a powerful message I have never forgotten. They were the sounds

of evil, the antithesis of “Love thy neighbor.”

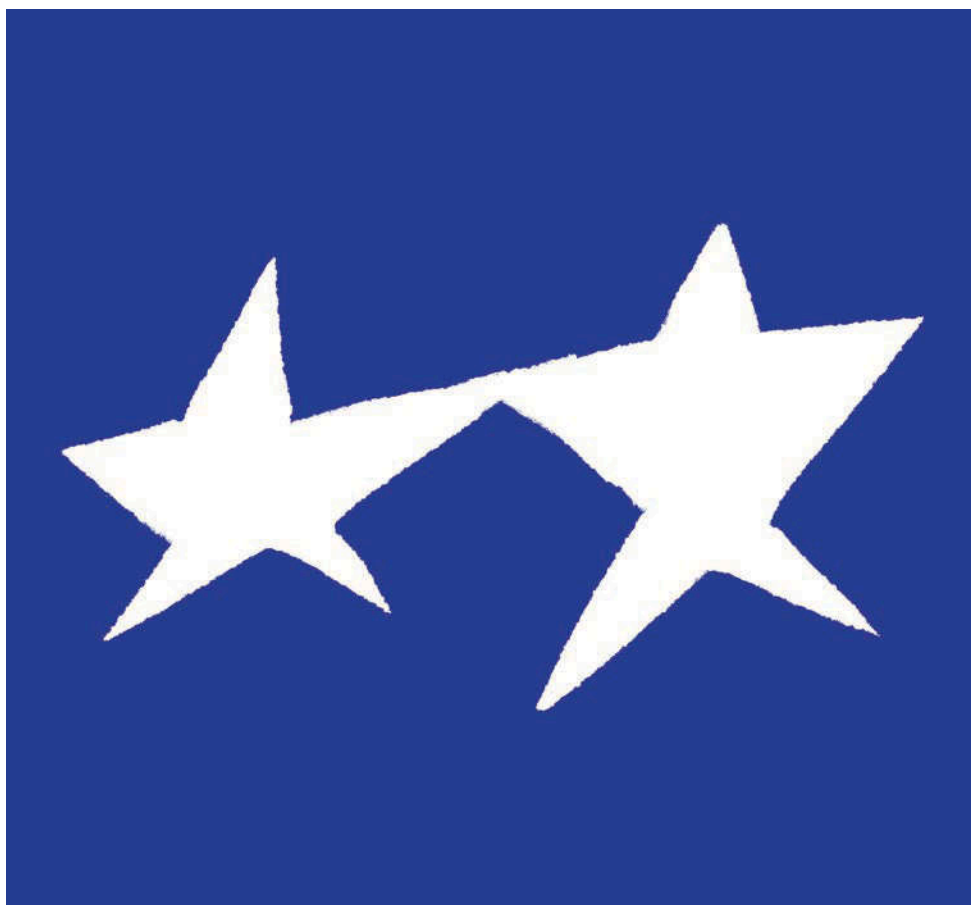
Americans survived those years on kindness and collective effort. In the 1930s, when hunger, poverty, and despair were at levels hard to imagine today, you could have nothing and still be kind. As a child who never went hungry,

of milk, and instruct me to be very polite to “our visitors.”

Throughout World War II, we knitted socks for soldiers and went with our mother to deliver hot cross buns to neighbors when a new Gold Star was hung in someone’s front window. We kids were also serious about collecting scrap and were

newly peaceful world, a world without the tragedies of war abroad and the curse of sickness at home.

It was a time of singular, optimistic patriotism. No one thought the road ahead would be easy; everyone believed that peace and shared prosperity were possible. For nearly a



I was spared the traumas suffered by many, but I witnessed hardship in the nation’s psyche. My father had a job that paid enough to feed four daughters and cover the mortgage on our tiny three-bedroom house, albeit just barely. Several times a week, men in worn coats and brown fedoras in search of food and work would knock on our back door. My mother would make peanut-butter-and-jelly sandwiches, hand them to me with glasses

occasionally enlisted to help watch the skies from a small rural hut for the rare passing airplane, whose description we would carefully record in a government logbook. My memories of these long-ago years are spotty; I was just a child. Far more clearly I recall the aftermath, when all of those men (and a few women) in uniform came home—Jane married one of them—and war stories were left behind. Everyone was in a hurry to move forward into a

century, I’ve been privileged to watch the fits, starts, and swings of that optimism: the forward leaps of science and technology, the backward falls into misguided ideologies. But the collective effort behind those hot cross buns and front-porch flags? That is still who we are, if we choose to be. *A*

Fran Moreland Johns is a writer based in California.



W

HOW TO WIN ON *JEOPARDY*

*You don't need to learn everything. You need
to learn one thing about everything.*

BY DREW GOINS

When you wake up on the day of your first appearance on America's favorite quiz show, you will have more knots in your stomach than a quipu, the tied-string recordkeeping device used during the Inca empire. You will take a nervous walk through beautiful, weatherless Culver City, California, where the title song of *Singin' in the Rain* was shot during a water shortage. Perhaps you will stop for a \$14 juice at the boutique grocery store Erewhon, telling yourself that you have to spend

money to make money. From the entrance of the Sony Pictures lot, you will be conveyed to the “check-in area” in the back of a dim parking garage; you will wonder whether this is actually some sort of hostage situation that is going to end with you at the bottom of a tar pit or, worse, on *Wheel of Fortune*.

And when you walk into the greenroom for contestants, you will see a door in the corner labeled *JEOPARDY! CHAMPION*, and you will be consumed by one thought, which I will phrase in the form of a question: *How do I get in there?*

IN 2024, I competed on *Jeopardy* for the first time. In 1653, Izaak Walton published *The Compleat Angler*, a treatise on fishing technique. These two events are related, actually.

No one loves *The Compleat Angler* more than *Jeopardy* does, and I am counting Izaak Walton himself; the show has asked about his book 35 times. If you want to appear on *Jeopardy*—and if you also want to win—it is important to know what *Jeopardy* likes.

The mild Mexican salsa whose name translates to “beak of the rooster” is pico de gallo. *Jeopardy* likes this.

Another popular fact is that Lucy Hayes, wife of Rutherford B., was the *first* first lady to host the Easter-egg roll on the White House lawn. You don’t know anything else about Lucy Hayes, and you don’t need to. Like Nebraska’s Platte River—44 mentions on the show—*Jeopardy* is a mile wide and an inch deep.

If *Jeopardy* asks about Norwegian playwrights, the answer is almost always Henrik Ibsen.

The Iowa painter is Grant Wood.

The European duchy is Luxembourg.

The Zoroastrian singer is Freddie Mercury.

To win on *Jeopardy*, you don’t need to learn everything. You just need to learn *one thing* about everything.

The best method for knowing one thing about everything is to have been a curious child. I grew up reading, except for at the dinner table, when *Jeopardy* was on; my younger brother and I would tally our correct responses on our fingers. I first took the show’s online contestant test in middle school, and when I was 18, my dad drove me to my first in-person audition in a hotel ballroom in Raleigh, North Carolina. (“Total success,” I wrote on Instagram, incorrectly.)

If you were not a curious child—this is difficult to change after the fact—the second-best method is to *act* like a curious child. When I was invited onto the show, I checked out children’s books from the public library down the street: kids’ atlases, kids’ encyclopedias, a kids’ paperback titled *What Is the Super Bowl?* They were for “my nephew.” Should your librarian look askance, your checkouts can also be for my nephew, or yours, whichever is easier.

These books have enormous stores of knowledge in them. Did you know that Buckminster Fuller developed the geodesic dome? (Thirty-seven mentions on *Jeopardy*.)

Or that the 1883 eruption of Krakatoa could be heard 3,000 miles away? (Forty-four mentions.)

Or that Thales, considered the world’s first true philosopher, thought all matter could eventually be subdivided into water? (Five mentions; we can’t all be Socrates.)

I didn’t know either, until reading children’s reference books. Given that these volumes prioritize breadth over depth, they are perfect for the ethos of *Jeopardy*. Most of them are illustrated, too, which helps with recall. I found it easier to remember the Battle of Crécy after seeing a cartoon 14th-century Frenchman take a longbow arrow to the chest.

Perhaps the best resource for learning the patterns of *Jeopardy* is the fabulous and disconcerting online database J! Archive, wherein fans have cataloged every question that has ever appeared on the show, as well as the frequency with which answers are repeated. Spend some time in the J! Archive and you will see that Australia, for instance, is historically the most common answer on the show. When in doubt: “What is Australia?”

You will see also that *Jeopardy* doesn’t actually ask about everything, but rather about what students of the show refer to as “the canon”—a set of knowledge that *masquerades* as “everything.” Shakespeare and U.S. presidents will recur, but the show doesn’t ask much about anime, or hedge funds, or risograph printing, which are all too specialized.

To determine whether a bit of knowledge falls within *Jeopardy*’s canon, imagine whether at least two people at a dinner party of a dozen well-read guests would be familiar with it. This may strike you as a silly standard, but I appreciate the show’s vision of a well-rounded society. The nerdy conviviality of the greenroom proves that a shared body of knowledge can unite would-be foes, even if that body contains more opera facts than it really ought

to. (The opera with the jester is *Rigoletto*; 20 mentions.)

Learning all this new material should be a delight. The arduous part is remembering it. To help, you can make flash cards, ideally using an app that employs “spaced repetition,” the evidence-backed idea that a person can retain information by reviewing material at progressively longer intervals. A good algorithm will present known information just before it is forgotten.

Izaak Walton is the author of *The Compleat Angler*.

I **LOST MY** first game. As the famous thinking music faded out during Final Jeopardy, I scribbled that Shakespeare wrote “Blood will have blood” in *Titus Andronicus* (38 mentions) rather than *Macbeth* (467—yeesh). Even if I’d gotten it right, I’d still have lost. A few clues before, David, in second place, had found the remaining Daily Double and wagered enough to leapfrog into first. Winning on *Jeopardy* takes luck, too.

For decades, contestants gallantly progressed through one category at a time. In the mid-2010s, when every other norm of civility was beginning to fall apart, *Jeopardy* strategy became a panicky knife fight for the Doubles, the most powerful clues on the board. You can, and should, hunt for them—they cluster toward the lower left—but fate determines whether you find one.

You’ve probably heard that the buzzer is fickle. This is true. You are instructed to watch for indicators on the game board to illuminate at the end of a clue, but if you wait to react to them—rather than anticipating the host’s final syllable—you will be on the back foot.

Even then, an opponent might be infinitesimally more precise. Buzzer Zen is elusive.

The stage lights are bright, and information will fly out of your brain at just the wrong moment. Frances Cleveland was the first first lady to host the Easter-egg roll at the White House. Wait! You meant Lucy Hayes, but it is too late and you are \$1,600 poorer.

Luck will desert you, and it will return. I was invited back to *Jeopardy* for 2024's "second chance" competition, on account of my narrow loss and—I have to imagine—toothy grin; *Jeopardy*, for all its meritocratic elements, is still a show on TV. I studied more, but what really changed was my fortune. I found back-to-back Daily Doubles, twice. I mentioned Taylor Swift in my mid-game anecdote and then came upon a question about her. During another game, I mentioned Celine Dion in my mid-game anecdote and then came upon a question about her (no, I did not know the answer; so sue me). One day, while I was being processed through the hostage garage, my tote of glass Erewhon bottles clanked to the ground. "My Fabergé eggs!" I yelled. Hours later: "St. Petersburg, Russia, has a museum devoted to these bejeweled objects given as Easter gifts by the czar." I'm not saying you can conjure friendly clues, but I do believe the Alex Trebek Stage is a kismet magnet.

I won my first game of *Jeopardy* in November 2024, and it was pure euphoria. Then I won again, and it was even better. I went on a terrifically fun tear all the way to the semifinals of the Tournament of Champions.

To some extent, the success brought the fun, but it

worked the other way around, too. Contestants say that they play better when they remember to enjoy themselves. One idea for some fun: Make Johnny Gilbert announce you as whatever profession you like. *Jeopardy* has had a "worldwide karaoke singer" and a "stay-at-home son." If you can determine that you are going up against an accountant, perhaps arrange to have yourself introduced as "a better accountant." Alas, there are limits. When I faced off against another Drew, I requested to sign in as "Baby."



The author during an invitational tournament in February; he won the quarterfinal round by \$1.

You have control of the board, Baby! This was not allowed.

By the time the Double Drew episode aired, 10 games deep, I was not really Drew anymore but "*Jeopardy* Drew," a meme of myself. At the little awards ceremony that *Jeopardy* puts on each season, I won the trophy for Breakthrough Performance, another reminder that the contest is a show. *Jeopardy*, by turning me into a winner, had created another Drew who was somehow smarter, funnier, and livelier than the guy not on TV. As one producer put it: "me, but more."

When you win, you might struggle with this. Is *Jeopardy*

You the real you, or the best version of you, or neither? Happily, these winner's worries will plague you for only so long, because eventually *Jeopardy* turns you into a loser.

I RETURNED AGAIN to *Jeopardy* this winter for an all-stars invitational, and I did... fine. One ugly win and one beautiful loss (*The Bridge of San Luis Rey*; 24 mentions; my fault). Everyone's luck runs out at some point.

The winnings stay yours, of course. If you are ever struggling to fall asleep, call a champ

they flew P-51 Mustangs will not stop anybody from kicking them off a curriculum.

What *Jeopardy* likes—what I love—is knowledge for the sake of knowledge. Izaak Walton wrote *The Compleat Angler* in the aftermath of Oliver Cromwell's overthrow of the English monarchy, which had forced Walton and other royalists to flee London for the countryside. There, he found peace through fishing. He wrote: "When the lawyer is swallowed up with business, and the statesman is preventing or contriving plots, then we sit on cowslip-banks, hear the birds sing, and possess ourselves in as much quietness as these silent silver streams, which we now see glide so quietly by us."

This is how I feel about playing with trivia. It is like standing on the banks of human knowledge, marveling at the volume rushing past, knowing I will never acquire more than the slightest share of it, yet contenting myself with plucking a remarkable specimen from below the surface.

The champion's room, by the way, isn't much. It's about six feet by six feet, and it contains a chair and a rack of shirts. The winner uses it to put on their outfit for the next game. The walls don't even go to the ceiling.

When you get in there, you will almost immediately want to get out, to rejoin the greenroom chatter. Everyone's discussing Slovakia, and you want to share the one thing you know about it: Bratislava is the only world capital that borders two other countries. *A*

Drew Goins is a senior editor at The Atlantic and a 12-time Jeopardy contestant.

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A Land of Artists

*Photographs by
Lee Friedlander*

By Hua Hsu

Few people have taught us to see America quite like Lee Friedlander. The 91-year-old photographer has been making pictures since the late 1940s, focusing largely on what critics and historians describe as the urban social landscape: all of these little jigsaw scenes of our built environment. He notices the everyday moments that go unseen by most, moments so inconsequential that we probably wouldn't even bother dismissing them as mundane. Friedlander once distilled his approach into a simple ethos: "I just walk and see something interesting."

Life Still, a monograph of Friedlander's work that Aperture published this spring, collects photos from the 1950s to the present, and it's in Friedlander's careful placement of pictures side by side that these puzzle pieces begin to depict a meaningful and at times delightful whole. Looking at them is like noticing that the song you're listening to catches the beat of a passing car, or seeing two strangers walk in symmetry on opposite sides of the street. You study Friedlander's pairs, recognizing the rhymes across time and space. The only clues that date his wanderings arrive in the shape of a mid-century refrigerator, or a certain hairstyle, or a peeling political bumper sticker.

What Friedlander finds "interesting" is often ironic and devilishly funny. An archway marked ENTRANCE provides entry to



Above:
Kentucky,
1977

Left:
New Orleans,
2016



no building, but rather to endless sky. You can imagine Friedlander's glee when he happened upon a sculpture with a busted phallus standing next to a painting of the comic-strip character Wimpy chomping on a slender baguette.

Plastic trinkets and graffiti, television sets and bumper stickers, road signs and wigs—many might describe these items as disposable culture, signs of America's crass habit of regarding anything as art. What of it? Everywhere in his work, we see reminders that this *is* a land of artists, even if they don't see themselves as such. In one picture, he focuses on a figurine of a tattoo artist inking a woman's breast; in another, a lamp fashioned from a tree sits on a book about "Tramp Art."

There aren't many people in these pictures, but there is presence. Is anything more intimate than the divot left by the owner of a well-worn armchair? A seemingly simple picture of a shop window reminded me of that John Coltrane quote about starting in the middle of a sentence

LEE FRIEDLANDER: *LIFE STILL* (APERTURE, 2026). © 2026 LEE FRIEDLANDER. COURTESY OF LEE FRIEDLANDER; FRAENKEL GALLERY, SAN FRANCISCO; AND LUHRING AUGUSTINE, NEW YORK.

Right:
Chicago,
1986

Below:
Buffalo,
New York,
1963



and moving both ways at once: We see what is in front of Friedlander, only the glass captures what is behind him too, and it's as though all of history has converged in this moment. These pictures can seem like accidents until you notice the unlikely beauty everywhere: the wondrously mathematical shadow of a chain-link fence, a patch of sky mirrored in a window, a bird in the distance that appears perched on a car door. Every now and then, you glimpse Friedlander's reflection—these are moments that feel slyly autobiographical. We see his shadow cast against a kitschy display that reads NOT ALL WHO WANDER ARE LOST. I like to imagine that he is smiling throughout, a reminder that the artist is at work. There are still more roads to walk, more things to see. *A*

Hua Hsu is a staff writer at The New Yorker and a winner of the Pulitzer Prize. This essay is adapted from his introduction to Lee Friedlander: Life Still.





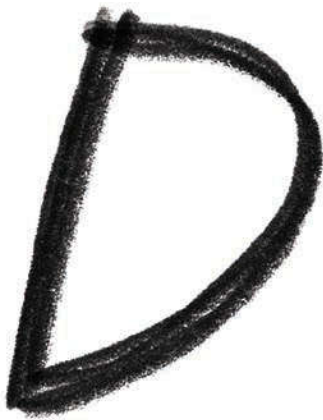
THE INFLUENTIAL
PASTOR DOUGLAS WILSON
HAS ADVOCATED FOR
THE REPEAL OF THE
NINETEENTH AMENDMENT.

THE MEN WHO
DON'T WANT
WOMEN TO VOTE

OR WORK.

OR HAVE OPINIONS.

By Helen Lewis



Douglas Wilson has a modest proposal to improve American life: He wants to repeal the Nineteenth Amendment, which gave women the vote. In his ideal system, “we would do it in our politics the same way we do it in our church structure,” he told me recently. “And that is, we vote by household.”

Wilson is a co-founder of the Communion of Reformed Evangelical Churches, based in Moscow, Idaho. Over the past five decades, he has built a small empire there, dedicated to disseminating his theocratic vision for the United States: a publishing house, a school, a liberal-arts college, and a video-streaming service. His denomination, which has about 170 affiliated churches, counts Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth as a member, and Wilson was invited to lead a prayer service at the Pentagon in February. So when the pastor casually suggests disenfranchising half of America, people listen.

When I asked him about this position, Wilson said it wasn’t his top priority—“We have bigger fish to fry”—but something he sees happening in perhaps 200 years’ time. I found this intellectual footsie maddening. “If I said to you, ‘I think all white men should be put in cages—but not *now*; it’s not my aspiration for *now*,’” I suggested, “then you wouldn’t be interested in a single other thing that I had to say at that point.”

Wilson chuckled. “Oh, I know you’d probably have *all* my attention.”

This is twinkly, avuncular Douglas Wilson, the guy who joined a hippie congregation fresh out of the Navy because he liked to play guitar, and ended up leading services once the regular pastor moved on.

The same guy who once went on a multi-city debating tour with the New Atheist Christopher Hitchens, and bonded with him over their shared love of P. G. Wodehouse. But the 72-year-old shows a different side on his website, Blog & Mablog. For more than two decades, Wilson has been airing piquant opinions on unruly women—or, as he calls them, “small-breasted biddies,” “harridans,” “lumberjack dykes,” and “Jezebels.” He once referred to Gloria Steinem and another feminist as “a couple of cunts.” And this is the polite version. Every year he celebrates “No Quarter November,” when he promises to tell readers what he *really* thinks.

Wilson believes that women should “not ordinarily” hold political office, and should never serve in combat roles in the military. Husbands should have dominion over misbehaving wives’ weight, spending habits, and choice of television programs. His uncompromising vision for America was once considered marginal, the conservative writer Karen Swallow Prior told me. Since his elevation by Hegseth, however, “no one can credibly say that Doug Wilson is fringe anymore.”

Wilson is a prominent voice in what is sometimes called “masculinism”: a movement to fight back against the advances of feminism and reassert the primacy of men. His version is religious, influenced by the notion of male “headship” of the family and Saint Paul’s belief that godly women should “be quiet.” There are also plenty of secular masculinists, as well as nominally Muslim ones, such as the streamer Sneako, the self-proclaimed pimp Andrew Tate, and the podcaster Myron Gaines. Woman-bashing plays well on social media and sells lots of ads for crypto, sports betting, and supplements. You can make good money telling men that they’re the truly oppressed sex.

But this isn’t just a movement of gifters exploiting a quirk of the algorithm. In the past decade, one of the New Right’s major challenges has been to retrofit a consistent ideology onto the electoral power of Donald Trump. Masculinism has been a great gift, because factions with different views on, say, protectionism or Israel or Big Tech can all agree on the overreach of feminism and the need for a return to traditional gender

roles. Far from being a fringe belief system, masculinism has become the single most important force uniting the American right, bringing together an unlikely constellation of pastors, posters, senators, preachers, influencers, podcasters, and fanboys.

The MAGA movement is often framed as a reaction to the first Black president, and to a growing Latino population. But the multiracial appeal of the manosphere and Trump’s 2024 inroads with young minority men point in a different direction. “People ask me what the New Right is furious about,” the author Laura Field, whose book, *Furious Minds*, describes the intellectual underpinnings of Trumpism, told me. “And I think a good shorthand for that is they’re furious about their own loss of status in society over the last few years and the elites who made that happen, and I think that the pithiest short version of that is that it’s the women. It’s the women who took their status.”

Wilson’s approach to public life clearly has an element of what professional wrestlers call kayfabe—the winking, performative trollishness that now characterizes the online right. He wants feminists like me to get angry with his most outlandish proposals, making ourselves look like scolds or Chicken Littles in the process. But Wilson and a growing number of powerful allies are sincere in these beliefs, and would want to enact them if given the chance.

ONE OF MASCULINISM’S central claims is that no one is talking about men. So true! Men’s issues are not being discussed in Senator Josh Hawley’s 2023 book, *Manhood: The Masculine Virtues America Needs*. They aren’t being discussed in Tucker Carlson’s documentary *The End of Men*. They aren’t being discussed in the panoply of Christian books available on Amazon with titles such as *Man for the Job*, *Masculine Christianity*, and *It’s Good to Be a Man*, or in their secular counterparts, such as *Why Women Deserve Less*. They aren’t being talked about on social-media feeds (which can be highly segregated by sex) or on some of America’s most popular independent podcasts, such as *Modern Wisdom*, *Huberman Lab*, and *The Diary of a CEO*.

For decades, each feminist advance in American public life has prompted an equally strong backlash. The first wave of women's-rights activists won suffrage for women, against ferocious and sometimes violent opposition. After the second wave secured Title IX and other legal victories against sex discrimination, Phyllis Schlafly successfully fought back against the full ratification of the Equal Rights Amendment. By the identity-obsessed 2010s, the full weight of corporate America had swung behind glib slogans such as "The future is female." This commercial blitzkrieg inevitably convinced some people that women's advancement had come at men's expense. A refrain I kept hearing over the past few years was that boys were being made to feel ashamed of themselves, as if they were stained by some kind of original sin. These years have seen a counterreaction, with the total abandonment of the #MeToo movement, conservative gloating over the fall of *Roe v. Wade*, and the return of straightforwardly sexist put-downs—"Quiet, piggy"—to public life.

Like most popular movements, masculinism has many entry points, and both defensible and alarming forms.

At one end of the spectrum are legitimate concerns about male loneliness, the declining share of men in higher education, stagnant wages for non-college-educated men, and the deadening effects of day-trading, gaming, and porn. At the other end of masculinism are a misogynist vocabulary about AWFULs and the longhouse (terms that we'll come back to) and a political agenda close to that in *The Handmaid's Tale*, whereby women are denied the right to work, vote, and control their own bodies.

On the internet, masculinism is presented as a rebellion—a transgressive middle finger to the liberal establishment, expressed in all the words a corporate HR department would order you not to say. In the past few years, leaked group chats have shown Young Republicans and college conservatives using sexism, infused with racism, as a bonding mechanism. "If your pilot is a she and she looks ten shades darker than someone from Sicily, just end it there. Scream the no no word," read a message in a Telegram thread used by the leaders of Young Republican chapters in New York, Kansas, Arizona, and Vermont. (Several members of the chat were women.) Richard Hanania, who describes

himself as a former white nationalist, calls this kind of in-group signaling "the Based Ritual," a way for younger MAGA enthusiasts to prove their bona fides to one another.

Among Gen Zers, Douglas Wilson's intellectual heir is Nick Fuentes, who leads a loose collection of trolls known as Groypers. A self-professed Christian nationalist, anti-Semite, and virgin, Fuentes has built a fan base in part by deploying vividly misogynistic language. "Our No. 1 political enemy is women, because women constrain everything, every conversation, every man—everything," Fuentes said on a livestream earlier this year. He added: "Just like Hitler imprisoned Gypsies, Jews, Communists—all of his political rivals—we have to do the same thing with women." He suggested that they be sent to "breeding gulags. The good ones will be liberated. The bad ones will toil in the mines forever."

Fuentes's rhetoric shows how this gendered view of the world can easily be interlaced with other prejudices. Gay men? Effeminate, uninterested in sports, therefore unmanly. Jews? Clever rather than athletic; also unmanly. University lecturers? Pencil-necked postmodernists; also



NICK FUENTES
HAS SUGGESTED
THAT WOMEN
BE SENT TO
"BREEDING
GULAGS."

unmanly. Trans people? Inevitably degenerate. Muslims? An invasion force of rapists. Black men? Thugs from whom white women should be protected (if only they would submit to patriarchy). Almost every facet of contemporary online rightism can be refracted through the prism of gender. Multiple people affiliated with the Heritage Foundation, perhaps the most influential MAGA policy organization, cut ties with the group after its president refused to condemn Fuentes's anti-Semitism last year. But his view that women belong in forced-breeding camps has produced no such fuss.

Wilson told me he considers this sort of rhetoric unforgivably gauche. "The Bible says that a godly woman is a husband's crown," he said. "I've never seen a king talk about his crown the way Fuentes talks about women. It's absurd." I wanted to ask whether "small-breasted biddies" came from the Gospel of Mark or Luke, but Wilson was on a roll. He thought Fuentes was so extreme that he might even be an undercover federal agent sent to discredit the movement. "He is, as far as I'm concerned, on the other team."

In theological terms, that might be true. But both men benefit from a shock-and-awe rhetorical strategy. In 2014, it

was a minor scandal when the megachurch pastor Mark Driscoll was revealed to be "William Wallace II," the author of dozens of pages of message-board rants about how America was a "pussified nation" where men are "raised by bitter penis envying burned feminist single mothers who make sure that Johnny grows up to be a very nice woman who sits down to pee." Now such language would barely raise an eyebrow.

WRITERS WHO USED to hide their masculinist impulses behind a pen name now write and say outrageous things under their real name. Take the manosphere provocateur known as Raw Egg Nationalist, whose handle on X, where he has more than 300,000 followers, is @Babygravy9. He combines lifestyle and nutritional advice—"slonking" raw egg yolks—with hard-right, anti-immigration politics. He writes for Infowars, the conspiracy theorist Alex Jones's media outlet. He posts about antiwhiteness and has his own line of microplastic-free herbal-tea bags, Kindred Harvest.

In 2024, a left-wing activist group outed him as Charles Cornish-Dale, a religious historian who has studied at both Oxford and Cambridge, and whose

Ph.D. thesis was titled *Migrations of the Holy: The Devotional Culture of Wimborne Minster, c.1400–1640*. When his name became public, Cornish-Dale, now 38, concluded that being doxxed has "only made me stronger and more committed to what I'm doing."

He did not use a pseudonym for his new book, *The Last Men*, in which he questions whether it is "possible to be men *fully* in a liberal democracy." His political prescriptions, like Wilson's, might be described as uncompromising. "Someone asked me the other day—I think it was a girl, actually—she was like: 'So would you take away the vote from women?'" he told me. "I was like, 'I would take away the vote from the vast majority of men as well.'"

His book, published by the venerable conservative imprint Regnery, suggests that men with high testosterone levels voted for Trump because high T is correlated with an acceptance of hierarchy, status, and inequality. Liberalism, by contrast, suppresses men's life force: "Leftists have now openly embraced emasculation and having low testosterone as part of their identity." He also revisits an argument he first made in an article titled "Ecce Homos," that the left had robbed straight men of their heroes by recasting them as gay. He wants to reclaim the male bonding of "Julius Caesar or Alexander the Great, the Spartan last stand at Thermopylae, cowboys, pirates, gang members."

The Last Men is a confounding book because it seems equally perturbed by falling birth rates and *Brokeback Mountain* winning three Oscars. Cornish-Dale identifies potentially worrisome phenomena, such as a reported decline in sperm counts around the world, and gestures toward genuine feelings of ennui experienced by many young American men, who are stuck in unrewarding jobs, searching for greater meaning in their lives. He lays the blame at the feet of the elites: *They* are keeping you fat; *they* are unhappy with risk taking and hierarchy; *they* are calling masculinity toxic.

In conversation, Cornish-Dale is cocky but likable, with a languorous way of speaking that reminded me of Simon Cowell.



CHARLES CORNISH-DALE, TRAINED AS A RELIGIOUS HISTORIAN, IS ALSO A MANOSPHERE PROVOCATEUR KNOWN AS RAW EGG NATIONALIST.



SCOTT YENOR HAS DECLARED THAT MODERN WOMEN ARE “MEDICATED, MEDDLESOME, AND QUARRELSOME,” BUT SAYS THAT DENYING THEM THE VOTE WOULD BE “UNCONGENIAL TO OUR CONDITIONS.”

Our Zoom took place at 6 a.m. his time, and he appeared to be talking to me from his bed, wearing striped pajamas. His current aesthetic is shaved head and swole, though back in 2012, he gave up doing fieldwork in a Buddhist monastery when he was asked to cut off his man bun. “I was going through a hipster phase,” he told me. “They wanted me to wear a robe instead of skinny jeans, and I just wouldn’t do it.”

Cornish-Dale is essentially an influencer—albeit one who knows a lot of \$10 words. But masculinism is not merely an outgrowth of the attention economy. Other figures with similar ideas have strong connections to conservative policy circles.

One of these is Scott Yenor, who has declared that modern women are “medicated, meddlesome, and quarrelsome.” Since 2000, Yenor has taught political philosophy at Boise State University, in Idaho, 300 miles south of Douglas Wilson’s stronghold in Moscow. He has also worked with Florida Governor Ron DeSantis on rolling back DEI programs, which conservatives see as a de facto racial and gender quota system that is harmful to white men. “The core of what we oppose is ‘anti-discrimination,’” Yenor wrote in a 2021 email, released to *The New York Times* under a public-records request.

Yenor now fancies doing a little discrimination of his own. As he wrote in an essay for the Claremont Institute last fall, he believes that the law should change to allow businesses “to support traditional family life by hiring only male heads of households, or by paying a family wage”—that is, compensating men more so that their wives do not need to work. (Currently, this would be straightforwardly unconstitutional sex-based discrimination.) In 2021, he argued that colleges should not try to recruit more women to become engineers, but instead should “recruit and demand more of men who become engineers. Ditto for med school and the law and every trade.”

Like J. D. Vance, he reserves particular scorn for women who do not have children. Heaven help the “childless media scold” or “barren bureaucratic apparatchik”—Yenor’s terms—who decides she would prefer having a career to having babies. His rhetoric is unpleasant and extreme enough that he could not get confirmed to a university board *in Florida*. As for repealing the Nineteenth Amendment, Yenor told me via email that “when America had household voting or some rough equivalent, it was not a tyranny, the country was well governed, and the family was supported. The country

is different today, and the same voting system would be uncongenial to our conditions.” (Although he responded to my question about the Nineteenth Amendment, Yenor did not make time for an interview with me.)

Yenor recently became the chair of the American Citizenship Initiative at the Heritage Foundation. A January report from the foundation called for a “culture-wide Manhattan Project” to promote family building through generous tax giveaways to married couples in which one parent is employed. At the same time, abortion, birth control, single-parent benefits, day care, dating apps, and no-fault divorce would be discouraged. The report contains one of the least romantic sentences I have ever read: “Marriage also opens unique retirement planning opportunities.”

All of this is a continuation of themes found in Project 2025, the Heritage Foundation’s blueprint for Trump’s second term. The document, in the words of my colleague David Graham, offers a vision of America where “men are breadwinners and women are mothers.”

Yenor’s suggestion that feminism—with its attendant horrors of work outside the home, birth control, and financial independence—has made women neurotic and dependent on pharmaceuticals

is now an article of faith on the right. Anonymous online posters frequently bring up data suggesting that liberal women are most likely to report suffering from anxiety. But to attribute female unhappiness to feminism seems wildly ahistorical. Have these people never read, say, *The Feminine Mystique*, which exhaustively cataloged the despair of mid-century stay-at-home mothers? (“Many suburban housewives were taking tranquilizers like cough drops,” the author, Betty Friedan, wrote.) Across the manosphere, however, young people are told that before feminism ruined everything, women used to be cherished and pampered by their husbands. Now women are supposedly subsidized by government handouts or earning six figures in pointless “email jobs.” In the masculinist paradigm, every woman does HR for cats and every man is a plumber or merchant seaman.

I asked Wilson about his allies’ nostalgic distortion of history. “Just a simple question,” he responded. “If you went back to 1850 and said: Out of all these women who had to get husbands’ permission to travel, to visit a sick cousin or whatever, how many—take 10,000 of those women—how many of them were on antidepressants? And how many of them today are on antidepressants?”

That wasn’t a fair comparison, I said, because today *everyone* is on antidepressants. Also, in the 1850s, SSRIs hadn’t been invented. You just got told to take some laudanum and go to the baths.

HOW POPULAR are masculinist ideas? Last year, research by King’s College London and Ipsos found that Gen Z men in 30 nations were far more likely than male Baby Boomers to say that the fight for women’s equality had gone so far that men were now disadvantaged. They were also more than twice as likely to say that a father who stayed home with his children was “less of a man.” Meanwhile, 83 percent of Republican men younger than 50 think society is too feminized, according to a survey by the conservative Manhattan Institute. Intriguingly, this survey did not replicate the usual trope of working-class men revolting against snooty female elites: It found that “college-educated Republicans are

more likely than their non-college counterparts to endorse the view that society has become too feminine.”

The most recent presidential election, pitting Trump against Kamala Harris, was a gift to masculinists. After all, the movement’s villains include female bosses, feminists, and women who don’t bear children—and Harris was the embodiment of all three. The male podcasters who got behind Trump in 2024 now host outright misogynists: Consider the career of the Christian debater Andrew Wilson, who in January appeared on arguably the most popular podcast in America, *The Joe Rogan Experience*—the manosphere-influencer equivalent of singing the national anthem at the Super Bowl.

Rogan’s choice of guests is a useful bellwether of the American political mood; he himself drifted from 2020 Bernie bro to 2024 Trump endorser via anti-wokeness, annoyance at COVID lockdowns, and a deep investment in conspiracy theories. He has lately begun to take an interest in Christianity, and has attended a non-denominational church.

Wilson, who appeared on Rogan’s show to promote his online debating courses, originally became famous for appearing repeatedly on *Whatever*, a dating podcast with 4.6 million YouTube subscribers. The show’s specialty is goading models and OnlyFans girls into delivering rage-bait, such as one recent guest’s suggestion that she deserves a millionaire husband. Women are never supposed to win in the *Whatever* bear pit, but sometimes they do, just by remaining calm while the men try to trip them up.

In one episode, Wilson told a female fellow guest that she was too stupid to understand him, so she raised the fact that Wilson’s wife, Rachel, has children with three different men. He went thermo-nuclear. “You lick snizz,” he barked. “You’re a fucking dyke. Don’t talk shit about my wife, you stupid bitch.” He added, “I’m better than you.” It was an extraordinary display of uncontrolled aggression. In another clip, he mocked a female guest for being unable to open a pickle jar. She handed it to him, and he failed too. “Your hand greased the whole top of it,” he complained. Wilson has one

of the most unpleasant internet personas I’ve ever encountered, and I’ve been on Bluesky. (He did not reply to my request for an interview, which was a relief.)

Unsurprisingly, Wilson treated Rogan, a high-status man, with far more respect than he showed the models of *Whatever*. In full bro-ing-out mode, he told Rogan that “feminists would immediately stop being feminist if they just had a taste of, like, well, you know, people actually did have to shut themselves up at night from wolves.” (How a chain-smoking middle-aged man who podcasts for a living would fare against a wolf is an open question.) The difference between this Andrew Wilson and the one from *Whatever* was remarkable—as was the fact that Rogan was prepared to host the benevolent version without any apparent concern for the malevolent one.

Wilson also took the opportunity to plug his wife’s book, *Occult Feminism*, which argues that feminism is “born of occult belief, because at its core, feminism seeks to make women gods over men, or at the very least to deify women.” I’ve read it (spoiler alert: The suffragists loved séances; Miley Cyrus’s tongue is pagan) and can say that the experience is eerily reminiscent of a friend recounting half a dozen Wikipedia pages that they read while drunk.

Wilson, however, promoted his wife so successfully that a few weeks later, Rachel Wilson made her own appearance on *The Joe Rogan Experience*. “I didn’t really have much of an opinion on feminism,” Rogan told her—except that he’d noticed that some feminists hated men. But listening to her book had made him realize that its origins were “bonkers.”

What followed was a greatest hits of anti-feminism—which, as Phyllis Schlafly learned, is the one subject where women’s contributions are always welcome. “Nobody wants to talk about this,” Rachel Wilson told Rogan. “This is the conversation no one’s ready for. Women’s access to higher education is the No. 1 correlate around the world—regardless of economics, race, culture, status, anything—to falling birth rates.”

In fact, observing a link between education and birth rates would be considered utterly banal in policy circles: The

United Nations was publishing research on the phenomenon back in the 1990s. But everything in the manosphere has to be presented as allegedly forbidden knowledge. A few weeks later, the podcaster Katie Miller—wife of the Trump White House adviser Stephen—was making the exact same point to Fox News’s Laura Ingraham, also with the air of someone breaking a taboo. Feminism was destroying the family, she told Ingraham, because it “pushed women into the workplace.” As the writer Jill Filipovic noted, “These two women are having this conversation at their jobs.”

In fact, the challenge of falling birth rates is so well-known that many countries have implemented pronatalist policies in response: Singapore offers \$11,000 “baby bonuses,” while Hungary exempts mothers of three or more children from income taxes. So far, though, none of the carrots has worked. The *actually* unspeakable bit is whether women’s access to education and the job market should be restricted, in the name of producing more babies and saving civilization. I wish people like Rachel Wilson would just come out and say that they favor this, so we can have a proper argument about it.

Instead they deploy a classic masculinist tactic: Tiptoe up to the edge of a policy that would poll as well as mandatory

A classic masculinist tactic is to tiptoe up to the edge of a policy that would poll as well as mandatory Ebola, then pirouette away at the last minute.

Ebola, then pirouette away at the last minute. Joel Webbon, a hard-right pastor based in Austin who has built a large social-media following by opposing feminism and the “LGBT Mafia,” is one of those prepared to say openly that he would like to restrict women’s participation in public life. “I know a lot of people, and I’m obviously not going to name them, but a lot of people and names that you would recognize are much further to the right than they are willing to publicly say,” he told me. However, he did not mind their bait-and-switch style, because the left has used it for decades. A small group of people argued that “love is love” to pass

gay marriage, “and then, you know, it’s like: *Oh, actually, Drag Queen Story Hour.*” Masculinists were only turning lefties’ own strategy against them.

Like Douglas Wilson, Webbon is regularly described as a hate preacher; he told me that his services in Austin attract protesters who photograph his congregation. And as with Wilson, and Cornish-Dale, there is an enormous gulf between Webbon’s combative online persona and the person I interviewed. On his podcast, he talks trollishly about “the fake sin of raaaycism,” but one-on-one, he was scrupulously polite, calling me “ma’am” and listening without interruption as I told him that the system he advocates for is closer to Saudi Arabian guardianship than anything from the Christian tradition. He sees his internet presence, he told me, “like the Apostle Paul arguing and lecturing in the hall of Tyrannus,” an important period of evangelism for the early Church. When I checked his X feed later, he was talking about “Jewish sodomites” and reposting an account called @IfindRetards.

THE PHYLLIS SCHLAFLY of today is the writer Helen Andrews, with whom I am sometimes confused by liberals with Helen blindness. In a viral 2025 essay for *Compact* magazine called “The Great Feminization,” Andrews asked whether



JOEL WEBBON, A HARD-RIGHT PASTOR WITH A LARGE SOCIAL-MEDIA FOLLOWING, SAYS OPENLY THAT HE WOULD LIKE TO RESTRICT WOMEN’S PARTICIPATION IN PUBLIC LIFE.

greater female participation in the workforce was “a threat to civilization.” (Honestly, women can be *so* overwrought.)

She was building on an influential thesis on the right known as “the longhouse,” which argues that modern, feminized society resembles the communal living halls of the past, which were dominated by “den mothers” who ruled by passive aggression, offense-taking, and ostracizing their enemies—all classically feminine modes of behavior. The most famous outlining of the longhouse thesis came from a writer calling himself L0m3z in the religious magazine *First Things*. He declined to cite any specific historical examples and added that one could not really define the longhouse, anyway, because “its definition must remain elastic, lest it lose its power to lampoon the vast constellation of social forces it reviles.” How convenient! Instead, the longhouse was “a metonym for the disequilibrium afflicting the contemporary social imaginary.” Let me shock you: L0m3z was eventually outed as a humanities academic.

Andrews took this thesis further, arguing that “everything you think of as ‘wokeness’ is simply an epiphenomenon of demographic feminization.” To translate that into English, the claim is that women don’t settle arguments like characters in a Guy Ritchie film, with fisticuffs outside the smoking shed and no hard feelings two hours later. Instead, Andrews writes, they “covertly undermine or ostracize their enemies.” Therefore, “all cancellations are feminine.” Again, a quick glance at the history books presents a few challenges: The backstabbing in the Roman Senate was both literal *and* figurative, and the Vatican has always been a nest of scheming cardinals. And who pressured ABC to take Jimmy Kimmel off the air after Charlie Kirk’s assassination? Brendan Carr, who is Trump’s Federal Communications Commission chair—and the possessor of a Y chromosome.

Later in the essay, Andrews offered a testable proposition: “If a business loses its swashbuckling spirit and becomes a feminized, inward-focused bureaucracy, will it not stagnate?” As it happens, the labor economist Revana Sharfuddin has crunched the data on factories in the Second World War—one of the greatest periods of “demographic feminization” in

American history—and found no evidence that they became paralyzed by cancel culture and petty HR disputes. When I asked Andrews about this, she noted that wartime automobile and electrical factories were still essentially segregated by sex, and that even so, some managers hired counselors to help them deal with their new workforce. “For what it’s worth, the counterargument that most landed with me was the example of communism,” she wrote in an email. “Women were well represented in medicine and science in the Soviet Bloc, and their society didn’t collapse—well, it did, but probably not because of the women.”

Andrews’s essay comes to the defense of former Harvard President Larry Summers, who resigned under pressure in 2006 after arguing that women might be underrepresented in the hard sciences because of their innate lack of interest in those fields and their inability to perform at the highest levels. It later emerged in the Epstein files that this was a sanitized version of his private view, which was that women have lower IQs than men. (Out of curiosity, I hunted down the diversity stats for 2006, the year Summers resigned. At the time, four-fifths of Harvard’s tenured professors were men.) In retrospect, Summers’s ouster doesn’t look like the product of feminist hysteria; rather, his colleagues may have seen him as an embarrassing liability and seized on the opportunity to offload him.

To my surprise, when I put this to Andrews, she partially agreed. “Saying Larry Summers was fired because of the controversy is like saying America entered World War II because of Pearl Harbor,” she said. “It’s a simplification: good enough for the one-sentence version, but definitely omitting important factors.” In our communication, she was wry and self-deprecating, apologizing for any inconvenience I’d experienced by being mistaken for her—“the bad Helen.” I reflected that this version of Andrews wouldn’t have gone viral in the way that the one warning that working women are a “threat to civilization” did.

On the right, creeping feminization has become an all-purpose explanation for many recent events: Women pity the underdog, pander to self-proclaimed victims, and care about hurt feelings more than the truth—all of which are exploited

by undocumented immigrants and violent criminals. In this analysis, Renee Good—the woman shot by an immigration-enforcement officer in Minneapolis—was killed because she’d adopted left-wing values. “An AWFUL (Affluent White Female Urban Liberal) is dead after running her car into an ICE agent who opened fire on her,” the right-wing pundit Erick Erickson posted immediately after her death. Women are childlike, naive, immature; they simply do not understand the real world.

Many MAGA figures have identified the surfeit of feminine empathy as a political issue. The first episode of Douglas Wilson’s *Man Rampant* podcast was called “The Sin of Empathy.” The Canadian marketing professor Gad Saad issues regular condemnations of “suicidal empathy” between posts complaining that women “no longer wear any real clothes and instead are always in athleisure.”

This disdain for empathy often leads to the conclusion that women’s political participation is a problem, because the little ladies will insist on voting for the wrong candidates and policies. “The 1920s were the last decade in American history during which one could be genuinely optimistic about politics,” Peter Thiel, an early advocate for Trump in Silicon Valley, wrote in a 2009 essay for a Cato Institute journal. “Since 1920, the vast increase in welfare beneficiaries and the extension of the franchise to women—two constituencies that are notoriously tough for libertarians—have rendered the notion of ‘capitalist democracy’ into an oxymoron.” In this view, the gender split in American politics—55 percent of men but only 46 percent of women voted for Trump in 2024—is not merely a reflection of differing priorities but a problem to be solved.

At the same time that people like Wilson are saying out loud that they want to repeal the Nineteenth Amendment, the suggestion that anyone seriously wants to end female suffrage is often dismissed by mainstream conservatives as lib hysteria. After all, changing the Constitution would require the assent of three-quarters of the 50 states. “I’ll be concerned about the 19th thing the day a single state—just one out of 38—passes a repeal,” Inez Stepman, a former fellow at the Claremont

Institute, posted in March. Liberals were “humorlessly chasing fumes of jokes and bar chatter, and dishonestly using it to silence real policy and cultural debate.” Personally, I would feel better about this line of argument had I not sat opposite the conservative intellectual Jordan Peterson in 2018 while he sneered at my suggestion that Trump-appointed justices would overturn *Roe v. Wade*. Or if the Trump administration had not taken the issue of birthright citizenship all the way to the Supreme Court. Or if Pete Hegseth had not already blocked the promotion of female (and Black) military officers, and frequently expressed his opposition to women serving in combat.

MASCULINISM IS NOW approaching its imperial-overreach phase, like the Roman empire that many of its leaders so admire. For some of its most ardent adherents, if someone on the left is doing anything, regardless of their sex, it’s feminized and bad. Meanwhile, when Trump sends out a bitchy Truth Social post about a petty grievance, that is a display of manly vigor. Tucker Carlson’s perfectly buoyant coiffure? Rugged—butch, even. Ben Shapiro’s heartwarming enjoyment of musical theater? In the best tradition of the Vikings

or Spartans, probably. This reductive view of the world—women things bad, men things good—is the mirror image of the worst excesses of 2010s Tumblr feminism, when introverted teenage girls posted hashtags like #KillAllMen and drank from mugs that read MALE TEARS.

In March, the anti-DEI activist Christopher Rufo had to fend off a horde of anonymous right-wing posters claiming, apparently seriously, that white men “are very easily the most oppressed group in history.” When he described this view as “brain damaged” and invoked a little-known American phenomenon called slavery, he was besieged with complaints.

For me, this episode gets to the core of MAGA masculinism. Which of its faces is the real one—the conservative think-tankers seeking to undo anti-discrimination laws, or the soap opera of influencers railing against “small-breasted biddies” and AWFULs, wallowing in self-pity, and labeling everything they dislike as feminine?

But of course, the sober thinkers and the shock troops feed off each other. Sometimes, as with Wilson, they coexist in a single person. This is a movement with real policy goals: the rollback of no-fault divorce. Tax breaks to reward male

The sober thinkers and the shock troops feed off each other.

breadwinners and female homemakers. An end to anything with a whiff of DEI, even leadership programs for women in the military, like one cut by Hegseth. A return to the workplace culture of the 1970s, where sexual harassment was normalized. An open preference for male employees in hiring, promotion, and pay awards—in other words, affirmative action *for men*.

Yet masculinism also functions as a perpetual-motion machine of grievance, an inarticulate howl of anguish at the status quo—whatever that currently is. Masculinism is both serious and silly, sometimes camp and sometimes chilling, an attention-grabbing performance and a genuine proposition. No wonder it has become the cornerstone of Trumpism. *A*

Helen Lewis is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



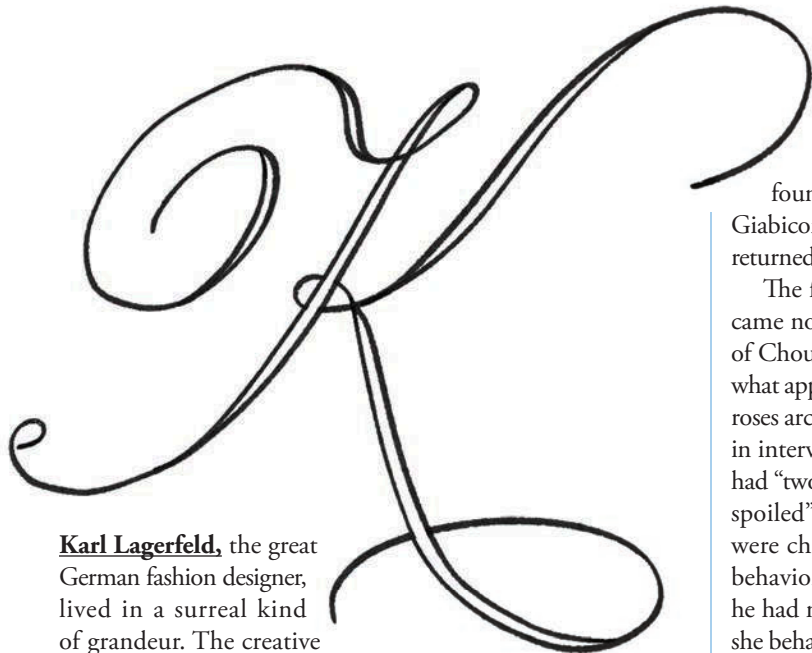
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Chouette

Did Karl Lagerfeld really
leave millions to Chouette?

BY CHRIS HEATH
Illustration by Arn0





Karl Lagerfeld, the great German fashion designer, lived in a surreal kind of grandeur. The creative director of both Chanel and Fendi, he owned apartments in Paris, Rome, and the Côte d'Azur, as well as villas in Biarritz and his native Hamburg; enormous collections of Art Deco furniture, antique jewelry, and couture garments; a personal library of some 300,000 books, by his own estimation; paintings and sculptures by Jeff Koons, Takashi Murakami, and John Baldessari; three Rolls-Royces; a curious assemblage of 509 iPods; and hundreds of pairs of his trademark wraparound sunglasses and fingerless biker gloves. According to a conversation that his biographer, William Middleton, had with the Parisian florist Lachaume, his annual flower budget appears to have been about 1.5 million euros. Lagerfeld never married or had children, and when he died of cancer, in 2019, the press quickly began to speculate about the immense fortune he'd supposedly left behind, which a number of outlets, including *Bloomberg*, *Forbes*, and *The Guardian*, ballparked at more than \$200 million. Speculation also swirled about where these riches would end up.

More than seven years later, here is what is known for certain about the details of Lagerfeld's will and estate: nothing. (Under French law, such matters are not made public.) But plenty has been rumored. Various figures close to Lagerfeld have been suggested as beneficiaries, including several male models and fashion executives, his bodyguard, his housekeeper, and the princess of Monaco. Even so, from the start, one improbable name has stood out: Choupette, Lagerfeld's blue-cream Birman cat.

In the years before he died, Lagerfeld often spoke in extraordinary ways about the role Choupette played in his life. Listen to just a fraction of his avowals: "I never thought that I could fall in love with an animal like this." "She is the center of the world. If you saw her, you would understand. She is kind of Greta Garbo." "She has lunch and dinner with me, on the table, with her own dishes. She never touches my food. She would never eat on the floor." "I have only one great love, my cat, Choupette." And, ruefully, "There is no marriage, yet, for human beings and animals."

Choupette came into Lagerfeld's life over the 2011 Christmas holiday. A young model with whom Lagerfeld had a close friendship, Baptiste Giabiconi, asked whether he might leave his four-month-old kitten at Lagerfeld's home while he visited family in

Marseille. Somewhat reluctantly, Lagerfeld, who had previously had little time or affection for cats, agreed and found himself besotted. When the kitten was reclaimed by Giabiconi, Lagerfeld moped, and beseeched that Choupette be returned to him for good, a wish soon granted.

The first public window into this change in Lagerfeld's life came not long afterward, when a friend of his posted a picture of Choupette sitting wistfully in Lagerfeld's apartment, next to what appears to be a full bathtub, an arrangement of several dozen roses arching over her. By that summer, Lagerfeld was explaining in interviews that Choupette was "like a kept woman"; that she had "two personal maids, for both night and day—she is beyond spoiled"; and that these maids, aside from their other duties, were charged with writing down every detail of Choupette's behavior when he wasn't around so that he might know what he had missed: "Everything she did, from what she ate, to how she behaved, if she was tired, and if she wasn't sleeping." Already, Lagerfeld declared, there were 600 pages of such documentation.

Choupette's fame swiftly grew, and Lagerfeld routinely extolled the extravagance of his cat's day-to-day life: how she ate chef-prepared meals off the best china, traveled by private jet, appeared with models on magazine covers, and starred in advertising campaigns. Lagerfeld proclaimed her the most famous cat in the world, and declared that her advertising work had made her independently wealthy. "She has her own fortune from things she did," he stated. "She's a rich girl!"

According to Lagerfeld, in 2014 alone, Choupette earned more than \$3 million from campaigns for Opel Corsa cars and Shu Uemura's Shupette makeup line. That same year came a book, *Choupette: The Private Life of a High-Flying Fashion Cat*, including photos, biographical tidbits, and details of Choupette's beauty regimen. A second book, *Choupette by Karl Lagerfeld*, 53 photos of Choupette taken by the designer on his iPhone, followed in 2018.

Once he adopted her, few Lagerfeld interviews failed to include testimony to Choupette's outsize role in his life, albeit clearly one that reflected his own particular tastes and needs. "She's peaceful, funny, fun, graceful, she's pretty to look at, and she has a great gait," he'd explain, "but her main quality is that she doesn't speak. It was love at first sight."

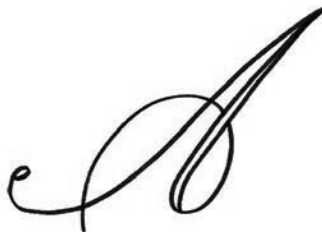
In his later years, Lagerfeld had intense attachments to select younger men he adopted as muses, but he is not believed to have had conventional romantic relationships. (As a younger man, he had a partner of nearly 20 years, Jacques de Bascher, who died from AIDS in 1989.) Lagerfeld often spoke as though his was a life that sidestepped sex entirely, though he once told *Vice* magazine: "I personally only like high-class escorts. I don't like sleeping with people I really love." Either way, if the manner in which he chose to live could be considered to have left a void, Choupette seems to have filled it. In a period when the designer was no longer close-shaven, he observed, "With this facial hair, I am really starting to look like Choupette. We are like an old couple. She even grooms the beard—we sleep on the same pillow and she spends her time licking it."

Then reality intervened. Lagerfeld had learned he had cancer several years before his death in a Paris hospital on February 19,

2019, but this was information he had shared with almost no one. To ensure that Choupette was properly taken care of after he was gone, he designated his housemaid Françoise Caçote, who had long been the cat's primary lady-in-waiting (and diarist), as her ongoing caretaker. During Lagerfeld's last days, she surreptitiously brought Choupette to his hospital room. Once, not long before Lagerfeld's death, Choupette caused great panic by disappearing, feared lost in the wider hospital, until her tail was spotted sticking out from her hiding place in Lagerfeld's en suite bathroom.

As the post-death arrangements were made (Lagerfeld would be cremated with a piece of aquamarine jewelry bearing Choupette's likeness), the media speculation about Lagerfeld's estate began. The narrative that this involved Choupette had been primed by Lagerfeld himself, who had referred to how, should he die first, Choupette would be lavishly provided for. Although some reports that week allowed that any bequest to Choupette was, as yet, unconfirmed, a fair few were more absolute—led, as many such narratives are, by the British press, even its supposedly more respectable sectors. Their cumulative message was clear: “A cat belonging to the fashion designer Karl Lagerfeld, who died on Tuesday, is reportedly in line to receive up to \$300m (£230m) of his estate” (*The Telegraph*); “Karl Lagerfeld's cat, Choupette, may be set to inherit some of his £150 million fortune” (the *Daily Express*); “Karl Lagerfeld's cat Choupette is reportedly set to inherit some of the formidable fashion designer's £150m fortune” (the *Independent*).

The swirl of scuttlebutt about other beneficiaries, totals, tax liabilities, and relative shares has continued ever since, and there are consistent reports that, even now, no one has received any money. Nonetheless, it has been printed as established fact that, separate from his will, Lagerfeld had arranged a sizable sum, generally said to be about \$1.5 million (though sometimes as much as \$4 million), to ensure that Choupette would live on in the style to which she had become accustomed. She was, it was sometimes claimed, the richest cat in the world.



A little over seven years after Lagerfeld's death, I'm sitting in an office building that towers above the Parisian suburb of Courbevoie with a man named Lucas Bérullier. Bérullier is Choupette's agent.

Bérullier never met Lagerfeld, but he is fluent in the lore. “There's a story,” he recalls, “when he adopted Choupette, at early stages and she was still young, everything was white in his apartment, and she was like a white fur ball. And he was so scared of someone or himself sitting on her or hurting her that he had every piece of furniture changed into black.”

Bérullier runs a company called My Pet Agency, one he started nearly a decade ago after seeing an unfilled opportunity for representing pets with potent social-media engagement. My Pet Agency's menagerie is dominated by dogs, which Bérullier says are generally more obliging than cats. One of the dogs he has represented is Messi, the French border collie prominently featured in the film *Anatomy of a Fall*, though Bérullier points out that the company handled only Messi's “social-media and special campaigns,” not his acting work. (Yes, this is a world where an animal might have more than one agent.) Most of the rest are cats, though along the way there has also been Buckley the cow, Cheepy the Australian cockatoo, Jiro the otter, Spike the beetle, and Mr. Pokee the smiling hedgehog.

As the business grew, Bérullier was aware that there was one megafamous pet living nearby in Paris that he would love to bring into his stable. While Lagerfeld was alive, Bérullier never found a way to make contact, but the summer after his death, an initial connection was

finally made. Bérullier's wife, a makeup artist, was doing a job in Lagerfeld's studio, and she got to talking with Lagerfeld's former bodyguard and confidant Sébastien Jondeau about Choupette. Bérullier soon went to visit Françoise Caçote and Choupette, and everything

A photo of a private-jet trip that Choupette took with Lagerfeld to New York, posted to her official Instagram account several months after the designer's death. “Always watching over daddy,” the caption read.



was agreed. “She needed someone to help harmonizing and structuring the communication,” he says. “Someone on her side defending what was best for her and what was best for Choupette.”

These days, Choupette lives in an apartment with Caçote somewhere in Paris, but I’m told that neither cat nor caregiver is receiving visitors right now. Bérullier says that a large part of his job, when it comes to matters relating to this particular client, involves turning people down.

He says that commercial opportunities are screened according to a number of criteria: Beyond financial considerations, there are questions as to whether such offers are suitable for Choupette and for Lagerfeld’s legacy. There are moral considerations, too. “We believe that Choupette only works with animal-cruelty-free brands,” he explains. “A brand that uses fur, we would have to decline a collaboration.”

Other practicalities must also be accommodated. Cats, in general, can be tricky, and Choupette sounds a little tricky even for a cat. Bérullier has to prepare clients for the possibility that Choupette won’t even turn up. “And people understand, because you call them, you’re like, ‘Sorry—for the cat welfare and well-being.’ And they all say, ‘Oh, it’s fine. Okay. You told me. I get it.’ Then we have to either reschedule or just not do the job.”

Jobs that are not rescheduled, and that require Choupette to leave her home, are generally done at a studio that Choupette is accustomed to, just a few minutes away. Clients are told that there is a two-hour maximum, that everything must be ready before Choupette’s arrival, and that she requires her own private room. There must be no noise on set, and no one may take photographs aside from the photographer. Also, Choupette must not be shot from above. Shooting from human height, Bérullier explains, is the classic amateur pet-owner blunder. “That’s not engaging. But if you start laying and going like this—” Bérullier mimes getting on the floor in front of an animal. “And even sometimes going under them, it makes the impression that they’re giants! And that will engage.”

Bérullier shares one more practical accommodation made for the most important shoots: Whenever prudent, there will be a cat double on set, ready to do whatever Choupette might not. They don’t use just one regular stand-in—it depends on what might be required that day: “We know the one that is very human-friendly, the other one that is playful, the one that has the eyes that look the same or the tail that looks the same.” It’s clear that he does not consider this duplicity, more the reality of dealing with animal actors—and one, he points out, that is routine in moviemaking. He notes that the Choupette camp doesn’t go out of its way to disguise footage from a double, and that eagle-eyed Choupette fans can often tell.

Bérullier also demystifies some other assumptions that lie at the very core of how Choupette is commonly perceived. The



multimillion-dollar fees that Lagerfeld alluded to Choupette commanding were for campaigns where the clients were largely paying for Lagerfeld’s name, and also for Lagerfeld being the photographer, designer, and art director. Bérullier doesn’t share Choupette’s current rate card but suggests that the numbers involved are substantially more modest. “Let’s be honest, we can’t ask millions for a post or a shoot,” he says.

Likewise, he punctures the notion—one that Lagerfeld sometimes explicitly stated—that Choupette has her own seven-figure bank account. “The law is the law,” he says. “A cat can’t own a bank account.” (When I ask whether there couldn’t be some kind of corporation holding the money, he says that if this were so, it would be a matter of public

record.) Furthermore, he suggests that we should be skeptical of stories that Caçote has already received a million-plus sum on Choupette’s behalf. The one printed story of this kind that Bérullier verifies is that Lagerfeld did, before his death, give Caçote the apartment in which she and Choupette live, but he notes that even this came with substantial unaddressed French tax liabilities.

There is no suggestion at all, in what he is saying, that Choupette wants for anything. Revenue is clearly coming in, though maybe not as much as one might assume. “It’s really hard for me because on one hand, you do want to keep the myth up,” Bérullier says. “But it’s not what I want people to be interested in. I mean, for me, she’s the most beautiful cat in the world; she’s the most fascinating—and culture and iconic and heritage. But not in a money way.”



As for the will itself, here are some more details of what has been rumored. The will was apparently written in April 2016, and there are commonly said to be a number of beneficiaries. Many accounts suggest

the former bodyguard Sébastien Jondeau and two of Lagerfeld’s male-model muses, Baptiste Giabiconi and Brad Kroenig. It is generally agreed that the Lagerfeld executive Caroline Lebar is also named. Sometimes, but not always, mentioned are the former Chanel creative director Virginie Viard; the writer and style consultant Amanda Harlech; a second Lagerfeld executive, Sophie de Langlade; Kroenig’s son Hudson (Lagerfeld’s godson, who started modeling for Lagerfeld on the runway at age 2); another model friend and protégé, Jake Davies; Princess Caroline of Monaco; and Caçote. (Animals may not inherit directly under French law.)

It is said that a key reason for the delay in settling Lagerfeld’s estate is a long-standing legal fight with the French tax authorities. One area of dispute may stem from the repercussions of the belated discovery that Lagerfeld’s home in Monaco, where the tax

regime is famously gentler, was technically in France. But there may well be more than that. There is talk of a complicated web of international corporations potentially structured to reduce tax liability, and it was reported several years before Lagerfeld's death that he was under investigation for tax evasion. An added layer of intrigue was the apparent disappearance of Lucien Frydlender, Lagerfeld's accountant of 30 years and the estate's putative executor, who reportedly died in Israel in 2024.

The closest anyone has come to capturing what those supposedly involved say about any of this is Michael Waldman, who made a remarkable documentary, *The Mysterious Mr Lagerfeld*, for British TV in 2023, in which he interviews a range of Lagerfeld associates, including all three men—Giabiconi, Kroenig, and Jondeau—who are most often identified as the principal beneficiaries. Jondeau describes Lagerfeld handwriting the will and confirms that he was one of the beneficiaries, and appears to confirm that Kroenig and Giabiconi are included too. And Giabiconi says this: "He named me top of the list. Well, I got a big percentage."

But a percentage of what, exactly? Although the Lagerfeld estate's value was widely assumed to be in the low hundreds of

millions, there seems to be no solid basis for this number. And although Lagerfeld was evidently very rich, he was also famously generous and profligate: In the documentary, the manager of Lagerfeld's favorite bookshop says that he was the store's best client, spending 500,000 to 700,000 euros each year. Various sales have liquefied assets in the years since—a Paris apartment was sold for \$10.8 million, a villa outside the city for about \$5 million—but nothing yet approaching the totals that have been widely touted.

In Waldman's film, one interviewee, Lagerfeld's estranged friend Patrick Hourcade, raises another rumor, the most dramatic of all—that the remaining money will go to the French finance ministry. Waldman tells me he got the sense from other interviews that expectations had certainly been lowered—that, for instance, Jondeau "thinks and hopes that something will come, but he doesn't know how much, and he knows that it's possible that there'll be very little or nothing."

Waldman also spent time with Choupette at Caçote's home, which he reports is a nice-enough apartment, where she lives with her husband and teenage son. "The husband was quite funny," Waldman says. "He was like a salt-of-the-earth plumber—he

might even have been a plumber, I can't even now remember. But he was a working man. And he was obviously bemused by this mad world that his wife had got herself into and more than tolerant of this extraordinarily beautiful cat."

Filming Choupette, Waldman says, required patience. "She didn't like strangers," he says. "That was understood." But, he adds, "there was also something in the way that Choupette moved that said, *I am more important than you. I am more important than anybody or anything.* And I sort of saw that. And in terms of trying to seduce Choupette into my lens and, as it were, communicate in an unprecedentedly intimate way, she refused."

The latest rumored turn in the seemingly never-ending drama of the Lagerfeld estate came earlier this year. It had been reported in 2024 that the beneficiaries had agreed on terms to settle with the tax



Opposite page: Lagerfeld's former housekeeper Françoise Caçote, Choupette's caretaker after the designer's death

This page: Choupette's agent, Lucas Bérullier

authorities. According to the German magazine *Bunte*, in December 2025 the will had at last been finalized, but then had apparently been challenged by an unknown party. This had come to light, *Bunte* asserted, because Lagerfeld's surviving blood relatives had received a letter informing them of this development. These relatives, who are not believed to be in the will, had apparently been notified because, should it be ruled that Lagerfeld had no valid will, his estate would then be divided among them.

Lagerfeld was born in Hamburg in 1933. (For many years, he would claim to have been born in 1938, something he would later attribute to his discomfort at having been born in the year of the Nazis' rise to power.) Lagerfeld's father—who, incidentally, was a member of the Nazi party—had been married before, and Lagerfeld had an older half-sister, Thea. It is from that line of the family that his surviving German niece, Thoma Theodora Friederike, the countess von der Schulenburg, comes. She is quoted in the *Bunte* article as saying that she would “emphatically reject” any inheritance.

But Lagerfeld also had a full sister, Martha Christiane, who was two years older than him. When she was in her mid-20s, she took a job in Seattle as an au pair. There she met a tax inspector named Robert Johnson; they married and moved back to his hometown of Portland, Connecticut, where they raised three boys and one girl.



I reach Caroline Wilcox in the records department of a municipal agency in rural Connecticut, where she has worked for more than 40 years. She is Karl Lagerfeld's niece.

She first met Lagerfeld when she was a baby, when her mother took a ship back to Germany for a visit in 1961, about a year after her birth. Later, Caroline and her younger brother Karl—named after his uncle—would wear the clothes that Lagerfeld and Lagerfeld's mother sent them; her brother Karl was the only kid in the neighborhood in lederhosen. (Two more boys, Roger and Paul, would follow later.) Still, she notes, her mother's world and her uncle's were far apart. “I was raised a little feral with three brothers,” she says. “I had a pet goose.”

In the fall of 1974, Lagerfeld, who was in New York, drove up to see his sister for the first time in years, and invited Caroline and her brother Karl to visit him in Paris the following summer. “We had a wonderful time,” she says. “He took me to a salon for a full day. I came out not even looking like myself. Took us shopping for clothes, reoutfitted us. I had never been to a restaurant.”

Lagerfeld met up with his sister one final time, in the 1980s, and after that, none of Lagerfeld's American family ever saw him again, but they never fell out of touch. “We weren't close,” Wilcox says, “but we had contact.” Lagerfeld would send presents, and sometimes money, to his sister, and also a Fendi fur for her 50th birthday, and he and his sister would talk by phone. In 1992, when he found out that Wilcox was getting married, he told her to forget about the dress she had already picked out. *He*, Karl Lagerfeld, would be making his niece's dress. Faxes went back and forth, Lagerfeld sending his hand-drawn sketches and handwritten thoughts. The day before the wedding, a courier arrived in

the snow carrying Lagerfeld's creation, flown in that same day with its own seat on the Concorde.

In 2015, Wilcox's mother died after a short illness. Lagerfeld had been getting updates, and once she was gone, Wilcox let her uncle know. “I texted with him throughout the day,” she says. “He was upset and talked about how different their lives were. I recall he was on an elevator to take a moment of privacy because he was at a show or working. That day was very busy for him, but he did take the time out to make me feel better.”

Wilcox says that her close friends know of this family connection, but few people beyond that. “If you said ‘Lagerfeld’ to most people here,” she points out, “they would not know who that was.” Her brother Roger lives nearby, and drives heavy vehicles. Her other brother Paul moved to Texas, where he is a government contractor. (Her oldest brother, Karl, died in a motorcycle accident when he was 18.) “We're just ordinary people,” she says. “He has American relatives that live quite, quite differently than what his world was like. We're very proud, but also unassuming.”

She declines to say whether she has recently received a letter regarding the will, but emphasizes that she certainly has laid no claim to it. “He was a generous, kind person to us,” she says. “My uncle was so unique. A once-in-a-century person.”

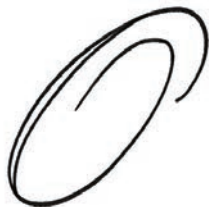
She mentions that in his later years, Lagerfeld would text her pictures of Choupette. “He loved that cat,” she says. Sometimes



“She is the center of the world,” Lagerfeld once said of Choupette. “If you saw her, you would understand. She is kind of Greta Garbo.”

she would send back photos of her dog, a Chihuahua-corgi mix: distant relatives finding common ground.

"A picture of my dog, Poppy, on my couch," she says, "is a lot different than a picture of Choupette on a pillow."



One more strange wrinkle in the Choupette story relates to her online history. The Instagram page @choupetteofficiel was launched on August 15, 2019, Choupette's eighth birthday, nearly six months after Lagerfeld's death.

But, as I've previously alluded, by then Choupette's virtual celebrity was already long established. Lagerfeld often referred approvingly to her online popularity; the 2014 Choupette book boasted of "her own Twitter account and a vast following" and reprinted the first tweet, on June 6, 2012, from the account @ChoupettesDiary, posted less than six months after Lagerfeld had taken Choupette as his own: "Baptiste may think he is a muse but only I, Choupette, am Lagerfeld's true muse. Everything from my whiskers 2 my meows inspire."

Given the way that these social-media accounts were regularly referenced in the conversation surrounding Lagerfeld, it was natural to assume that they were part of Lagerfeld's wider conception of Choupette. But the odd truth is this: They had nothing to do with Lagerfeld, or with anyone around him. On that day in June 2012 when the very first tweet appeared, Ashley Tschudin, a 23-year-old who held a low-level job at a New York company that managed booking software for modeling agencies but who had no inside track to the world of fashion or of Lagerfeld, had just read an interview with the designer published that morning in *Women's Wear Daily*, in which he rhapsodized about Choupette and her obsessively documented two-maid luxury life. A character popped into Tschudin's head—"a sassy, satirical, high-fashion feline," she tells me, "who had a lot of opinions about humans, about her lifestyle, the fashion industry, pop culture, and the beauty industry"—and, right there and then, she opened a Twitter account with the name @ChoupettesDiary, composed a bio ("I'm a famous beauty who refuses to eat on the floor & my maids pamper my every need. I am Choupette Lagerfeld and I am a spoiled pussy"), and started tweeting.

By the end of the same day, @ChoupettesDiary had gathered so much attention that Tschudin had done two anonymous interviews as Choupette by direct message—one with *WWD*, whose Lagerfeld interview had inspired all of this just hours before, and a second with *Fashionista* ("I felt it was time to show the fashion world the REAL Choupette," the cat pronounced).

After that, Tschudin says that Lagerfeld's team soon reached out to ask who she was. She told them her name and that was that. "It was never that they would step in and say, 'Oh, no, you can't say this,'" she says. "There was no control or approvals or communication as to overseeing the brand that I was building, except for that first introduction." In the Twitter feed, and on the Instagram account and the more discursive blog that shortly appeared in tandem, she would freely use whatever photos were out there, including anything available from Lagerfeld and those around him. "Never once

did I receive an email that said, 'Hey, you can't use these anymore.' Why would they do that? I was building a brand for them for free."

Meanwhile, Tschudin was able to monetize the social-media accounts for herself, though she says only to modest effect: "Not in a consistent-paycheck way," she notes. "Not enough to pay for my groceries." She most benefited, she acknowledges, in more indirect ways: "Choupette became my voice and opened a lot of doors in my career for me within digital marketing, within the fashion industry, the beauty industry."

Though Tschudin always had full-time jobs unrelated to impersonating a cat, she would typically spend hours each day on Choupette-related posting. "I loved it," she says. "It was my creative outlet. It was my voice. I could say things that I, a human, couldn't say, because it was humorous coming from a high-fashion feline." When Lagerfeld died, at first she simply carried on. "Thank you everyone for your words of condolence," Choupette swiftly announced. "With a once cold but now simply broken heart, I am going into mourning."

She knew that there was going to be a problem when she saw Caçote's first @choupetteofficiel post that August. Bérullier had touched on this situation when I met with him, mentioning that when he first came on board, "there was a bit of a dispute—we can call it that—with the person who had fans' accounts. We had a conversation with the people behind, but we didn't find an agreement that was okay." Tschudin's version is rather more blunt. She says that her lawyer made contact offering "a variety of options": Choupette's representatives could buy the brand and its audience; they could collaborate with her; they could hire her. "They were not interested in any of those," she says. "They did not come in a collaborative way to the table." It became clear that they preferred a fourth option. Tschudin was never formally shut down, but she could no longer easily use photos, and all of the fashion-world invitations she'd become accustomed to simply evaporated. She took the hint. "It was heartbreaking," she says. "It was as if my voice was taken away."

Not all of her memories of her time as Choupette are sour ones: "The brand as a whole is something I'm extremely proud of. I'm proud of a voice that I gave to an animal that did not have a voice. I'm proud to have gotten the opportunity to be one of the world's first pet influencers when that was not a career path."

During all of those years when she was assuming Choupette's voice, Tschudin and her subject never met. Truth is, she's not an evangelical cat person. Back then, she did have a pet, but it was a Chihuahua called Roscoe. Now, living in California, where she works for a company that does hiring for Google, she has seven rescue dogs and a rescue pig.



In 2023, it was decided that the theme of the year's Met Gala, to be held on May 1, would be a tribute to Karl Lagerfeld. The first that Choupette's people knew of this was when a request came to participate in an Annie Leibovitz *Vogue* photo shoot that would feature a dozen supermodels. Choupette's part in this went well enough. Bérullier says that when the cat and her team turned up on the

day, all of the models gathered at Paris's Grand Palais were cooing, "Choupette! Choupette!" The cat's designated model was Naomi Campbell, and Leibovitz duly photographed the two of them together on Pont Alexandre III, Choupette in Campbell's arms.

That, though, was just the prequel. As news of the Met Gala theme became public, My Pet Agency was bombarded with endless versions of the same question: Would Choupette be attending the Met Gala? There are two stories to tell here. One is the story that was told at the time. The second is the one that appears to be closer to the truth.

This is the first narrative: Choupette's people were besieged with requests for her to attend the Met Gala, but were stretching out a *will she or won't she?* dynamic. A little over a week before the event, Choupette was photographed on Instagram lazing on a bed, paws over her face: "Me while everyone is wondering whether I'm going to the Met Gala." A few days later, Kim Kardashian posted a photo of herself, lips pouting, next to Choupette on a bed: "Had a date with @choupetteofficiel in Paris. We then spent some time at @karllagerfeld's office to get a little inspiration for the Met." The implication seemed to be that because Choupette wouldn't be mingling with the famous and beautiful in New York, one of their representatives had paid a visit beforehand.

The day of the Met Gala, when the cat's nonattendance was revealed in a @choupetteofficiel post, it was presented as how things were always going to be: "Many people invited me to walk the red carpet of the #METGALA2023 in tribute to Daddy, but we preferred to stay peacefully & cozy at home." Attention instead pivoted to the way Choupette was represented in New York on the night—Jared Leto walking down the red carpet in a full-body Choupette costume. This, presumably, had been the plan all along.

Except that a second narrative, significantly different, became apparent later that year, during an episode of *The Kardashians*. It turned out that Kim Kardashian's meeting with Choupette had actually happened in the middle of March, about six weeks before her Instagram post. Ahead of the meeting, Kardashian explained to her show's cameras exactly why she was there. "I am going to the Met with Karl Lagerfeld's cat as my date," she said, "and I'm so excited." Later she further spelled out the mindset she was bringing to that day's meeting: "Choupette is really key to my whole vibe for the Met this year."

When I ask Bérullier, he concedes that this was provisionally the case. "We received about half a dozen requests of people who wanted to take her," he says. "And first you're like, *Oh, yeah, cool. Of course. We'll be there.*" Then they started thinking about the reality of traveling there, and of taking Choupette down "the busiest, loudest, craziest carpet," and wondering whether it was a good idea after all. Still, once Kardashian emerged as a likely escort, plans began to form. "It made the most sense: the most famous cat with the most famous person on the planet."

That was why it had been arranged that Choupette and Kardashian would meet in a suite at the Paris Ritz. "I'm nervous," Kardashian said beforehand. "I literally feel like I'm going on a blind date." I'm pretty sure, watching this, that Kardashian is just mugging for the camera, creating a frothy reality-show narrative. But genuine trepidation might have been wise.

The cat and the Kardashian met for the first time when Caçote placed Choupette next to Kardashian on a plush hotel sofa. (Bérullier was there, too, taking a video on his phone.) Choupette initially appeared somewhat tolerant of Kardashian's close presence, but not for long. Kardashian was wearing a black jacket—"some sort of plastic leather," says Bérullier, who believes that Choupette was scared of the sound that this outfit made. Soon Choupette hissed, then jerked toward Kardashian, snarling. Kardashian swiftly withdrew her hand.

"Don't worry, she pretends—she won't do anything," Bérullier reassured her.

"Oh, it's okay—I act like that sometimes too," Kardashian replied. "She is feisty."

But then there was more hissing. Bérullier says that the two of them were together on the sofa for nearly an hour. At one point, when Kardashian tried to hold Choupette, Choupette lashed toward her face, and Caçote quickly stepped in to take the cat.

Later on, Kardashian and Choupette did successfully pose for photos together on a bed. By then, Kardashian had removed her jacket, and Bérullier says that this part of the encounter went much better. But the conclusion had become obvious. As she would summarize it on *The Kardashians*: "I think I realized really quickly that Choupette, we're not a match. So I am not bringing her to the Met."

"It would have been just not right for the cat," Bérullier says. "You know, sometimes you need a bit of distance to understand that."



Most of Choupette's public life in the years since Lagerfeld's death has been rather more low-key. Her most regular client is a high-end German cat-accessories-and-toys brand called LucyBalu. Just before Christmas,

she did a shoot for a Maisons du Monde home-decor range. Last year, she was announced as the French voice of the mischievous cat Azraël in the French version of the *Smurfs* movie (*Les Schtroumpfs*), though that was more clever marketing than anything else. She filmed some promotional footage but, cat being a universal language, no French-cat noises were overdubbed in place of the original sounds.

One more unusual recent collaboration was with a German painter, Max Renneisen, who has a particular interest in the great French 18th-century animal portraitists Jean-Baptiste Oudry and Alexandre-François Desportes.

"There are so many depictions of the favorite dogs of Louis XV, Louis XIV, and I thought that Choupette is a perfect match," he explains to me. "It's the equivalent of today to these royal pets. I want to present Choupette in the same way as these royal pets in the 18th century were presented." Initially, he sourced some photos of Choupette and got to work. The first painting he did, of Choupette in a spectrally lit forest clearing, was directly styled after Oudry's 1726 portrait of Polydore, one of Louis XV's hunting dogs. But Renneisen felt dissatisfied with what he had created.

“It is not really Choupette,” he adjudges, “but more an invention of a white cat supposed to be Choupette.”

To do better, he felt like he needed Choupette herself, so in 2024, he tracked down Bérullier and secured permission from Bérullier and Caçote to photograph her, in order to capture images he could use for paintings.

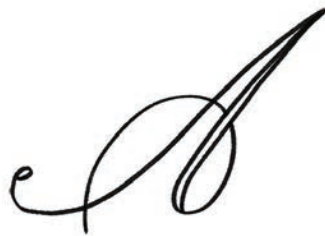
In truth, Renneisen tells me, the ensuing photo session wasn’t that successful. He would like to have seen Choupette in certain poses, but it became apparent that his expectations were unrealistic. “When she realizes that you want something,” he says, “she doesn’t want to do it.”

No matter. He was also given lots of photos he hadn’t seen, and these guided him. Choupette was difficult to paint—“because of the texture, this fur, all the shades of her color”—but bit by bit, a portfolio came together.

Renneisen returned to Paris this February to photograph Choupette a second time, now alongside some of the paintings he had made. I ask him whether he got the sense that Choupette recognized herself in his paintings.

“No, I don’t think so,” he replies. “All the fuss we do about her, all this concept of celebrity, giving a meaning to her, everything—this is us, for the humans.” He further notes: “Choupette is not a diva. She’s a cat, and we want to see the diva in her.” I point out that a lot of people fixate on Choupette’s character, and on what she’s thinking. I ask him whether he does that too.

“No,” he says. “No, no, no. I accept her as a cat. She’s a cat.”



And that is where I believed

my grand Choupette quest—often surreal and delightfully absurd—had reached its natural end. But I was wrong.

Long after my return from Paris, as this article is going to press, I receive a message that Caçote might answer some questions in writing. I send some, and wait. Eventually, answers arrive.

One thing I ask Caçote about are those day-to-day diaries of Choupette’s life written between 2012 and 2019, of which she was the primary author. Most of the 100 or so volumes that she believes exist are no longer in her possession. “I miss them,” she writes. “I’d like to pick one at random and reread it. Karl loved to do that too.” And, she adds, “It’s very frustrating, especially since I asked for them after Monsieur’s death and was told they were part of the estate, so they weren’t given to me. I was told they might be given to me later, but I’m still waiting. I’d like to know what happened to them!!”



The German painter Max Renneisen depicted Choupette in the style of the great French 18th-century animal portraitists, with a very 21st-century Lagerfeld floating above her.

But of all Caçote’s answers to my questions, the following three are the ones that tell me the most about what I want to know:

Is taking care of Choupette—with everything that entails—a heavy responsibility for you?

“Yes, of course!! I’m always afraid of being judged. What I do know is that Choupette is happy at home, and that’s the main thing.”

Choupette is often called “the richest cat in the world,” and newspapers frequently report that you’ve received huge sums of money to take care of her. I understand that this isn’t true. What do you think of this misconception, and what would you like people to know about it?

“I want to be completely transparent: today, we have received absolutely nothing. Given the situation’s complexity, I have had to hire expensive lawyers to claim the inheritance in my name and ensure that Karl’s wishes are properly respected.

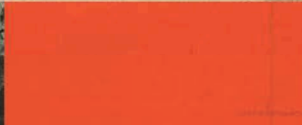
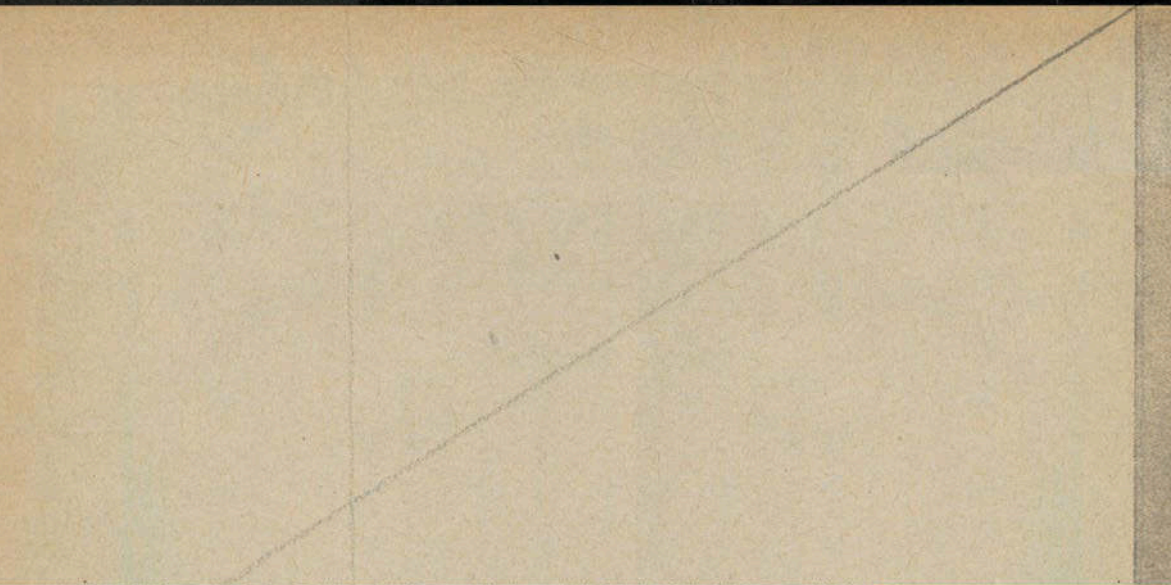
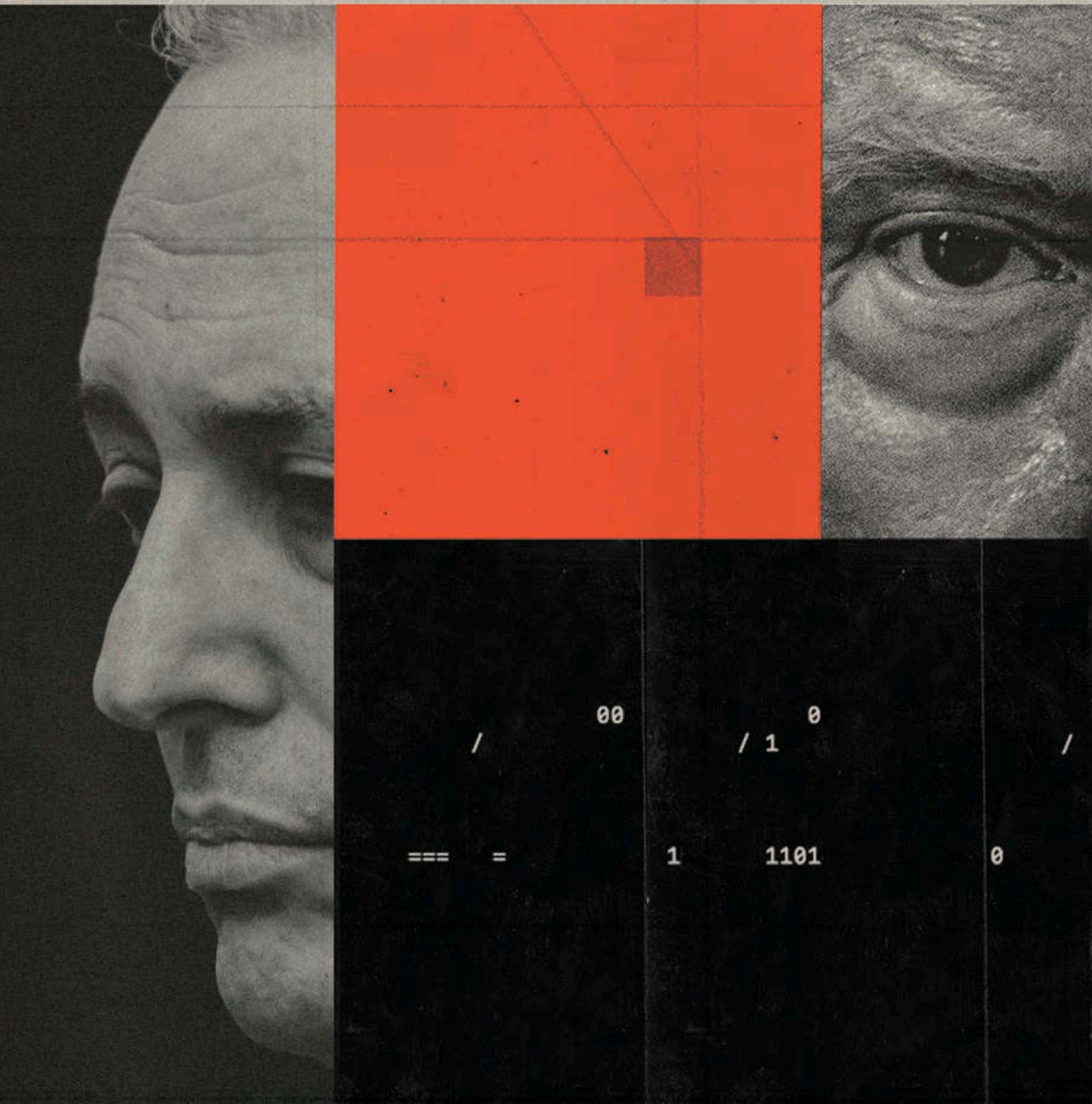
“While things are being sorted out, I’m doing my best to honor his wishes, especially that Choupette wants for nothing. That’s my top priority. In addition to caring for her, I work part-time to support her. She receives all the love, attention, and care she needs.

“The most important thing is that she’s happy, surrounded by love and affection, and protected as Karl would have wanted. We remain hopeful that the situation will one day be resolved peacefully.”

What is Choupette doing right now?

“She’s taking a quiet nap.” *A*

Chris Heath is a contributing writer at The Atlantic. He is the author of No Road Leading Back—An Improbable Escape From the Nazis and the Tangled Way We Tell the Story of the Holocaust.



THE VENTURE-CAPITAL POPULIST

How David Sacks
and the new tech
right went full
MAGA and captured
Washington

BY GEORGE PACKER

Illustrations by
Mike McQuade

T

he courtship between Silicon Valley and MAGA was consummated on June 6, 2024, in San Francisco's Pacific Heights neighborhood, on a street known as "Billionaires' Row," at the 22,000-square-foot, \$45 million French-limestone mansion of a venture capitalist named David Sacks. Along with Chamath Palihapitiya, a fellow venture capitalist and a colleague on the *All-In* podcast, Sacks hosted a fundraiser for Donald Trump. He knew that other technology titans were coming around to the ex-president but remained in the closet. "And I think that this event is going to break the ice on that," Sacks said on the podcast the week before the fundraiser. "And maybe it'll create a preference cascade, where all of a sudden it becomes acceptable to acknowledge the truth."

A few years earlier, Sacks had described the January 6, 2021, riot at the U.S. Capitol as an "insurrection" and pronounced Trump "disqualified" from ever again holding national office. "What Trump did was absolutely outrageous, and I think it brought him to an ignominious end in American politics," he said on the podcast a few days after the event. "He will pay for it in the history books,

if not in a court of law." Palihapitiya was more colloquial, calling Trump "a complete piece-of-shit fucking scumbag." These might seem like tricky positions to climb down from—but the path that leads from scathing denunciation through gradual accommodation to sycophantic embrace of Trump is a well-worn pilgrimage trail. The journey is less wearisome for self-mortifiers who never considered democracy (a word seldom spoken on the podcast) all that important in the first place. One prominent traveler who had already shown the way was a guest at the fundraiser—Senator J. D. Vance, whose attendance helped close the deal on his selection as Trump's running mate. Any lingering awkwardness between the hosts and their guest of honor was dispelled by the fundraiser's \$12 million haul, much of it from cryptocurrency moguls.

Opportunist doesn't really describe Sacks. He doesn't come across as slippery or two-faced. There's no evasive glance or roguish smile. He can argue at great length, in a steady sibilant drone, with an aggressive debater's ability to make an evidence-based case for any position he holds—but the position always happens to coincide with his benefit. The only consistent principle of his career is a ruthless devotion to self-interest. Sacks has identified as a "libertarian conservative" all of his adult life, but he has sought government intervention on behalf of his investments when it's suited him. In 2023, when Silicon Valley Bank collapsed, Sacks demanded that the federal government bail out the uninsured deposits of start-up companies, much of the money from crypto firms. "Some libertarians care about the freedom of only one person," Peter Thiel, the entrepreneur, investor, and right-wing provocateur, once said of his friend Sacks.

In this sense, though Trump is impulsive and narcissistic while Sacks is cold-eyed and logical, they are well matched. "Sacks is a spirit animal for part of the president's brain," a former Biden-administration official told me. "The plutocratic part." After the election, the new president appointed Sacks as his special adviser, or "czar," for AI and crypto. After decades of keeping as far from Washington as possible, Silicon Valley would finally have its own man in the White House.

But Sacks has always taken a dim view of politics. At 25, appearing on a C-SPAN talk show while still in law school, he expressed a preference for "the ethos of Wall Street" over "the ethos of Washington" and quoted Calvin Coolidge on the business of America being business, avowing: "I'd probably rather live in a greedy country where people don't share than in an envious country where people are stealing from each other."

Sacks went to Washington on behalf of business, including his own. But business and politics demand different, sometimes opposing talents. "Sacks's policies are misaligned with his own party," a congressional aide with a close view of how Sacks operates in Washington told me. "He doesn't really understand how D.C. works." His efforts in government on behalf of the tech industry have exposed the president to the charge that Trump is selling out his populist base on behalf of the country's richest men, driving a wedge through the MAGA coalition.

SACKS ONCE CALLED a rare victory over Thiel in a game of chess one of the greatest moments of his life. In a photo, his arms are raised skyward, ecstatic disbelief on his face. He spent

OPENING SPREAD: SAMUEL CORUM / SIPA / BLOOMBERG / GETTY; AL DRAGO / BLOOMBERG / GETTY; STOCKBYTE / GETTY

the early years of his career as a kind of junior partner in Thiel's shadow. Sacks was born in 1972 in South Africa, and moved to the United States at age 5. He grew up in Memphis and attended an elite boys' prep school before going on to Stanford University. As a sophomore with right-wing views he inevitably gravitated toward Thiel, who was by then in law school, and joined *The Stanford Review*, the conservative campus publication that Thiel had started as an undergrad. It took aim at the politically correct orthodoxy and anti-Western ideology that swept over American higher education in the late '80s and early '90s and never really left. But the outnumbered young conservatives' mockery almost always overshot the target. An entire issue was devoted to making light of rape, including a contribution from Sacks that challenged whether statutory rape should be a crime. (He has since expressed regret for some of his youthful writings.)

Thiel was determined to be a public intellectual like his hero William F. Buckley, so he began writing a book on left-wing campus extremism. When he found the work too onerous, he turned the research over to Sacks, and they co-authored *The Diversity Myth: Multiculturalism and Political Intolerance on Campus*, published in 1995 by a libertarian think tank. Sacks attended the University of Chicago Law School, but law was too much like the detested public sector, and in 1999, when Thiel co-founded an online-payments company in Palo Alto that was soon to be called PayPal, Sacks left a consulting job to lead the company's product team. He made important contributions to PayPal's success; by various accounts, including Sacks's own, he was also known for telling co-workers in blunt terms that they were wrong. A former colleague told me that with Sacks, "there's masters and there's slaves. He doesn't have partners: 'You do what I tell you to do, or you're one of the few people that tell me what you want me to do.'" The former colleague added, "Part

of his drive is that he believes he is one of the small number of elite people who really get it and are capable." (The former colleague and some other Silicon Valley sources requested anonymity to discuss a figure who has power over their businesses; some government officials requested anonymity to speak about White House conversations, because they were not authorized to talk about them. Sacks declined to be interviewed.)

PayPal became famous for surviving the dot-com crash in 2000, and for producing a spawn of Silicon Valley stars known as the PayPal Mafia, including Sacks. Roger McNamee, a longtime tech investor, watched its success with admiration and apprehension. The PayPal Mafia saw before anyone else that the cost of starting an internet company was going to drop significantly. "They realized that the limits on processing power were going to go away," McNamee told me. But these 20- and

30-somethings were not inspired in the same way that the founders of earlier Silicon Valley companies were: "They didn't follow the vision of Steve Jobs, that tech can democratize power. They came to get rich." McNamee added, "If their value system had been different, we would have a completely different country today."

I met Sacks in 2011, at a dinner at Thiel's house in San Francisco with a small group of entrepreneurs and investors, most of them PayPal alumni. They despised higher education, worshipped the creators of tech companies, wanted to found libertarian colonies on the high seas and be cryogenically frozen for future resurrection—eccentric outliers then, but forerunners of a broader political trend in the Valley. One guest was an AI expert named Eliezer Yudkowsky. Last year, he co-authored *If Anyone Builds It, Everyone Dies*, which concludes that artificial superintelligence will kill literally every human being on Earth—thereby causing Thiel to label him "a legionnaire of the Antichrist."

Sacks seemed the most normal of the group. He was a businessman with conventional libertarian views, more optimistic than Thiel about the economic power of the internet, less apocalyptic about the decline and fall of "Western civilization," a key term in *The Diversity Myth* that Sacks seldom used after publication, showing no consistent ideological attachment other than to capitalism. His distaste for politics remained strong. "This is the battle," Sacks told me. "Can the web disrupt the rest of the economy, or does the old economy fight back using politics to keep the new economy from taking over?" At the time we spoke, he was trying to disrupt the car-wash business. He had invested in an app that allowed you to send your car's location to a person who would come wash it while you were off getting sushi or founding a company or taking a meeting in Hong Kong. The app, called Cherry, lasted only a year, but Sacks did better with another early-stage investment in a

David Sacks and Elon Musk attend a party after a screening of the 2005 film *Thank You for Smoking*, which they co-produced, at Elaine's in New York City.



company that sent a town car to pick you up. “It’s totally disrupted the taxi business,” Sacks said of Uber, with undisguised pleasure.

He did extremely well, with a movie he co-produced in 2005 (*Thank You for Smoking*), with a company he co-founded in 2008 (a Slack-like social network for businesses called Yammer), and with his investments: in Facebook, Palantir, and SpaceX after PayPal was sold to eBay for \$1.5 billion in 2002; in bitcoin and other cryptocurrencies after he sold Yammer to Microsoft for \$1.2 billion in 2012. That year, he threw himself a Marie Antoinette-themed 40th birthday party in a rented ancien régime-style Los Angeles mansion, with special guest Snoop Dogg. “Part of believing in capitalism is you don’t have to feel guilty,” Sacks told me.

He conducted himself in the usual way of an aristocrat of the second Gilded Age: buying lavish properties, contributing to mainstream politicians (Mitt Romney in 2012, Hillary Clinton in 2016), and guarding his family’s privacy. He deplored the deterioration of urban life and funded the recall of San Francisco’s ultraprogressive district attorney, Chesa Boudin. Unlike Thiel, he didn’t publish writings on reactionary philosophers and the virtues of monopolistic capitalism.

The politics of the Valley was always a liberal sort of libertarianism: pro-choice, pro-immigration, idealistic, even utopian, arrogant about its mission of empowering individuals and connecting humanity, but indifferent to and ignorant of government, with an engineer’s contempt for the creaky workings of bureaucracy and the cluelessness of elected officials. *Leave us alone to do our magic, which you can’t possibly understand, and everyone will benefit.*

But about a decade ago, tech’s free ride ran into trouble. In 2013 Marc Andreessen, an inventor of the first popular web browser in the ’90s and now one of the Valley’s most successful venture capitalists, predicted to me a public backlash against technology companies over privacy rights, intellectual property, and monopoly power. With more foresight he would have included the addictive and corrosive effects of social media. Three years later, in 2016, Facebook enabled Russian meddling in an election that inflamed American divisions and sent Trump to the White House.

Trump and his populist followers made Big Tech a favorite target; so did progressives such as Senator Elizabeth Warren. Under bipartisan pressure, Silicon Valley had to search for ways to keep the government out of its business. Executives and investors spent fortunes on lobbying and campaign contributions. Mark Zuckerberg showed up in Washington to stand before Congress with his hand raised—eyes wide, as if stunned by the reality of representative government—and explain in tortured sentences why Facebook’s platforms weren’t driving America’s children to anxiety and depression while shredding the country’s civic ligature.

“Concern with tech monopoly was big in the first Trump administration,” Tim Wu, an antitrust expert and a professor at Columbia Law School who served in the White House under President Biden, told me. “This has been largely forgotten, but the first Trump administration brought the first cases against Facebook, which are under appeal, and against Google, which we won under Biden.” Biden’s Federal Trade Commission and the antitrust division of his Justice Department pushed anti-monopoly policies even harder. The tech giants “wanted to be able to get in and tell us what to do about everything,” Wu said.

Still, the confrontation between Washington and Silicon Valley under Biden was more rhetorical than substantive. His administration failed to push through any meaningful regulation of the industry, and its legislative achievements in infrastructure, semiconductor manufacturing, and clean energy directly benefited the technology sector. Yet during Biden’s presidency a highly visible element of Silicon Valley turned against the Democrats. It became known as the tech right.

Its most famous figure was Thiel, who had kept a lonely vigil for Trump in Silicon Valley since 2016. But by the early 2020s its most vocal spokesperson was Andreessen. For the tech right, technology is Promethean fire. The founders of the most successful companies in the Valley play a godlike role, for they alone can save America and “Western civilization” from Europe’s hyper-regulated stagnation and from communist and Islamist totalitarianism. Fred Turner, a Stanford professor who studies the culture of technology, told me that deep within Silicon Valley’s libertarianism lies “the idea of a community of saints, of special people, entrepreneurs, philosopher kings.”

In 2023 Andreessen published a litany of pseudo-Nietzschean credos called “The Techno-Optimist Manifesto.” On AI: “We believe Artificial Intelligence is our alchemy, our Philosopher’s Stone—we are literally making sand think.” The AI revolution is coming, just as electricity did; it will exalt mankind, and any attempt at regulation would be tantamount to mass slaughter: “We believe any deceleration of AI will cost lives. Deaths that

For the tech right, technology is Promethean fire. The founders of the most successful companies in Silicon Valley play a godlike role, for they alone can save America and “Western civilization.”

were preventable by the AI that was prevented from existing is a form of murder.” Among the “Patron Saints” of this cult of the entrepreneur, Andreessen included John Galt, the hero of every libertarian teen who reads Ayn Rand’s novel *Atlas Shrugged*, and the 20th-century philosopher James Burnham, best known for predicting that the modern world would be run by an amoral class of “managers,” with the talented few ruling over a mass of semi-slaves. Elsewhere, Andreessen has said that oligarchy is inevitable.

The nearly hysterical voice of “The Techno-Optimist Manifesto” is that of a man who has freed himself from a deeply uncomfortable position. Andreessen was a longtime contributor to Democratic candidates. The political change of Silicon Valley figures like him was less a conversion to Trumpism than a deconversion from liberalism, caused by pressure from below and above. In 2025 Andreessen told *The New York Times*’ Ross Douthat that the new progressivism of the 2010s had “radicalized” young tech workers, turning them into spiteful and, once COVID hit, indolent rebels who intimidated their white, male, for-profit bosses into bowing to the Great Awakening. Andreessen was willing to pay high taxes and support liberal causes and candidates as long as he was regarded as a hero. But during the past decade, what he called “the Deal”—admiration and a free hand for Silicon Valley in exchange for building great companies, making the world better, and supporting Democrats—was broken, when first young people and then the Biden administration turned against the tech industry.

According to Andreessen, the administration wanted to kill the entire cryptocurrency sector by keeping the regulatory rules vague while threatening companies with devastating enforcement actions. He also described a meeting that he and his partner were given with senior officials at the Biden White House in May 2024 that, from the point of view of early-stage venture capitalists, was apocalyptic. Regarding AI, Andreessen claimed, the Biden people declared that the whole industry would be limited to a few heavily regulated large companies, with no place for start-ups: Because social media had turned out to be a disaster for democracy, Silicon Valley had to be nationalized or destroyed. Out in the West Wing parking lot, Andreessen and his partner decided to support Trump in that year’s election.

(I spoke with former Biden officials who disputed what Andreessen claimed he and his partner were told about AI; if anything, the officials said, those present had simply predicted how the capital-intensive technology would play out in the next few years. They pointed to several administration efforts on AI and start-ups that directly contradicted Andreessen’s nightmare account of Biden’s policies. “He needed a conversion story,” one former official told me.)

In 2020, during the pandemic lockdowns, Sacks and three other venture capitalists started *All-In*; the weekly podcast would offer market analysis, political argument, and tech-bro banter about poker and cars. It made them famous online, with Sacks (nickname: “The Rainman”) the smartest, most conservative, and least funny of the four. Shortly after January 6, when Facebook and Twitter banned the soon-to-be-former president and other MAGA figures, Sacks stopped talking about Trump as a threat to democracy. Instead, he denounced the “Big Tech oligarchs” who were threatening free speech in “the biggest power grab in history.”

Free speech—at least as it concerned right-wing political figures—was Sacks’s entry point into MAGA, and he never let it go. Anytime one of the “besties” on *All-In* mentioned January 6, Sacks countered with claims of censorship. His rhetoric became more polemical, a return to his anti-PC youth, but now in the spirit of Trump, not William F. Buckley, as if he was talking himself into a new political identity. At times his enemies were woke oligarchs, at times mid-level technocrats, at times entry-level radicals, but always “elites.” He criticized the elite’s forever wars and trade giveaways to China, and “the collusion between Big Tech and our security state.” He called himself a “populist” and identified with the two-thirds of Americans who are working-class. In 2022, on the *Honestly With Bari Weiss* podcast, he said, “I think that the next Republican who’s going to be successful has to take a page out of TR’s”—Teddy Roosevelt’s—“playbook here, which is: ‘We do not represent the interests of these oligarchs and these big, powerful companies. We represent the interests of the working man and woman to have the right to free speech, to make a living, to conduct payments. And it should not be up to tech oligarchs to decide who has those rights.’”

If venture-capital populism seems like a stretch, Sacks resolved it this way: End mass immigration of the mentally average, and you’d lay to rest the heartland’s suspicion of Silicon Valley. The solution to inequality is a smaller, less intrusive government, combined with unbridled technological innovation, which would inevitably increase productivity and wages. (Sacks was unaware or unconcerned that decades of unregulated tech and deregulated finance had coincided with growing economic inequality.) “If the Biden administration had only been letting in people with 150 IQs, we wouldn’t have this debate” about immigration, Sacks said on *All-In*. “If they were just letting in the Elons and the Jensens”—referring to Musk and Jensen Huang, the CEO of the chipmaker Nvidia—“we wouldn’t be having the same conversation today.”

After the Russian invasion of Ukraine in 2022, Sacks voiced alarm about the dangers of American involvement in the conflict. Soon he adopted whole hog the “realist” line (which was also the Russian line) that NATO’s eastward expansion had provoked Vladimir Putin into a defensive war. No matter how often Putin claimed Ukraine as a historic part of imperial Russia, how many times he refused to negotiate seriously, how many provinces he annexed, how many Ukrainian civilians the Russian military killed and cities it destroyed, Sacks stuck by his theory. Eventually, it sank him into conspiratorial waters.

“This is basically a manufactured conflict that I think really started with Russiagate,” Sacks said in a 2024 speech, “where somehow this fantasy was created that somehow Putin was controlling our elections.” The American left, the “neocons,” and Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky managed to fool the U.S. and Europe into risking what Sacks called “Woke War III.” “Somehow, this Russiagate hoax has metastasized into a new cold war with Russia.”

It’s worth asking how someone so committed to facts and logic could end up spouting such nonsense. If Sacks made investment decisions on this basis, he would go bankrupt. An obvious explanation is that a successful businessman might not know much about history and politics. But an intellectual deficiency

can be compounded by a moral one. It's striking that the ordeal of a fragile democracy fighting for its life while under assault by an aggressive empire leaves Sacks so cold that he ends up sympathizing with the perpetrator. If you neutralize any sentiment of right and wrong, Ukraine just looks like a risky bet.

In the 2024 Republican presidential primary, Sacks supported Ron DeSantis—not because Trump had disqualified himself, but because he “just gives his political enemies so much to work with.” A moral objection had become a practical one—so when Trump blew away the Republican field, the final step to complete support was easy. Two weeks after the fundraiser, Trump was invited onto *All-In* and raved about the splendor of Sacks's house. Sacks returned the compliment. That July, he delivered a six-and-a-half-minute speech for Trump at the Republican National Convention. By August, he had downgraded January 6 to a long-past event that admittedly “wasn't great” but had been hyped by Democrats into a “fake coup.”

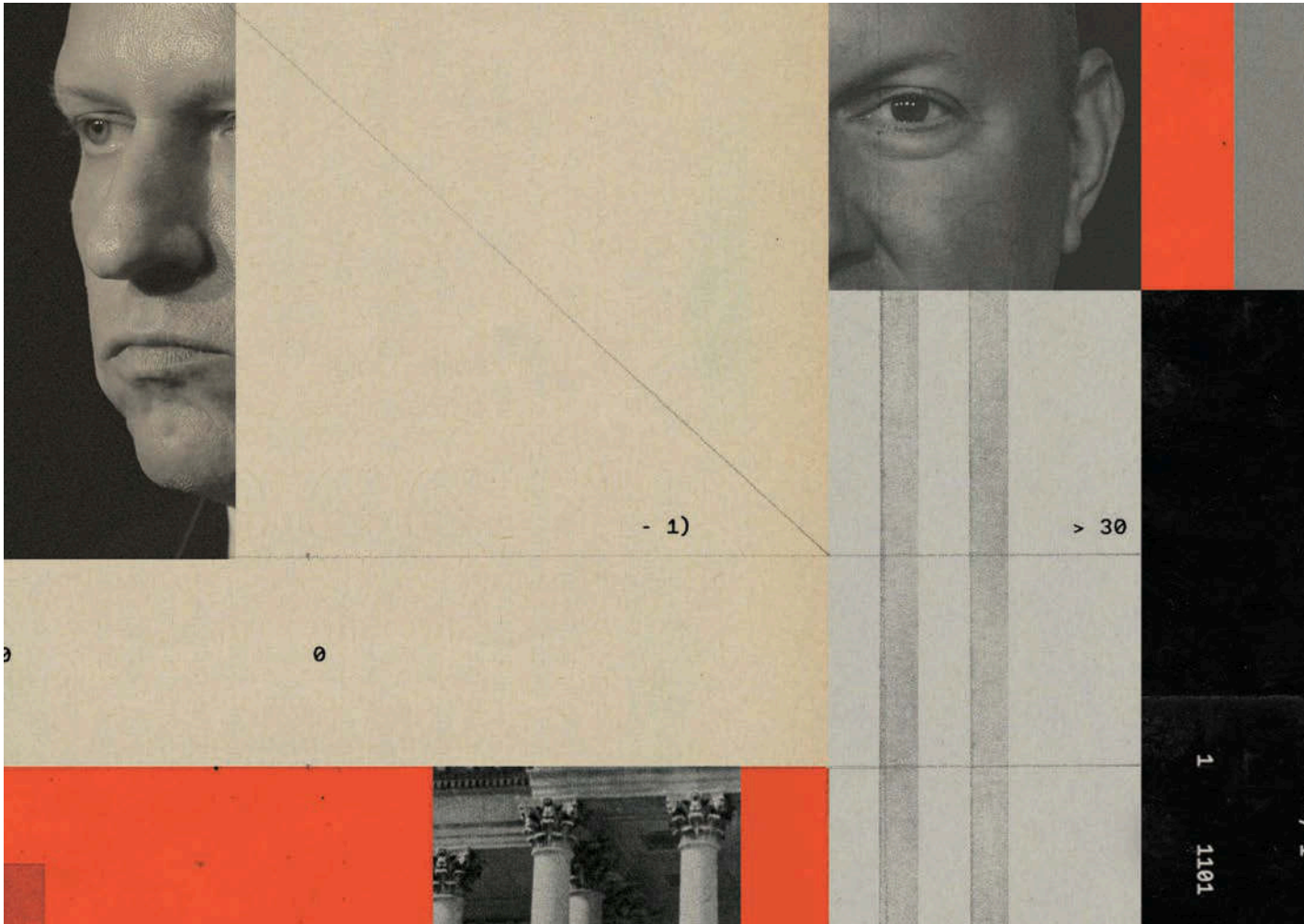
Jeff Giese, a fellow *Stanford Review* alum and entrepreneur who had been a Trump supporter in 2016 before turning against MAGA, gave me a sympathetic account of the calculus made by Sacks and the tech right. “The story Sacks told himself, I imagine, is that, regardless of Trump's flaws, the benefits to society from pro-tech policies would be a great improvement over an administration that was mired in safetyism and identity politics,” he said.

Sacks had taken the measure of Trump and found a kindred spirit. After getting to know the ex-president at the fundraiser and on the podcast, he reported his findings: “All of his instincts are *Let's empower the private sector; let's cut regulations; let's make taxes reasonable; let's get the smartest people in the country; let's have peace deals; let's have growth.*”

In December 2024 Sacks was named the White House special adviser for AI and crypto, with a venture capitalist from Andreessen's firm installed as his deputy. Sacks's status as a “special government employee” allowed him to stay on as a partner at his company Craft Ventures, while working no more than 130 days over the course of a year at his government job. He also continued as a co-host of his *All-In* podcast, analyzing technology, influencing market perceptions, making predictions—all while playing a central role in shaping public policy on AI and crypto.

Because special government employees are subject to most of the conflict-of-interest rules for regular government employees, the Office of Government Ethics (whose head had been fired at the start of Trump's second term) required two waivers to allow Sacks to keep a foot in both the public and private sectors. They were written by the White House counsel, David Warrington, a Republican operative who had acted as Trump's personal lawyer after his first term. A spokesperson for Sacks told *The Atlantic*,

MIKE MCCUADE. SOURCES: KIYOSHI OTA / BLOOMBERG / GETTY; CONSOLIDATED NEWS PICTURES / GETTY; SHANLEE B. MIRADOR / SIPA USA / GETTY; FAIRCHILD PICTURES / PICTURE ALLIANCE / GETTY.



“Mr. Sacks and Craft Ventures had to refrain from investing in companies directly affected by his duties as a government adviser and furthermore had to seek approval from the White House Counsel Office for all potential investments.” In essence, the waivers argued that Sacks’s holdings were so large that keeping dozens of small investments in companies related to crypto and AI would pose no conflict of interest for him, because they made up such a tiny fraction of his overall portfolio. But the waivers give only percentages, and their language is so opaque that it’s impossible to know the actual value of these investments. “They try to finesse the issue by saying, ‘Oh, it’s a relatively small percentage of his portfolio, and he’s so rich, it couldn’t possibly affect him,’” Kathleen Clark, an ethics lawyer who teaches at Washington University’s law school, told me, adding that this stance beggars belief.

In November, the *Times* published a lengthy investigation of Sacks, finding that, despite large divestments, he continued to hold stakes in hundreds of companies that advertised themselves as AI-related, and that key policy decisions benefited both Sacks and his Silicon Valley associates. A chorus of them, including Andreessen, rushed to his defense. Sacks called the *Times* article a “hoax,” hired a defamation-law firm to write a threatening letter, and argued that he had cost himself and his company a lot of money—\$200 million in crypto holdings alone—to work in government voluntarily

without pay. Clark waved aside the question of whether there’s personal corruption on Sacks’s part. “I urge you to limit your use of the term *conflict of interest*,” she told me, “because it doesn’t begin to capture what’s going on.”

What’s going on is that Sacks joined the most corrupt administration in American history. Throughout his year in the White House, his work on tech policy brushed up against the spectacular grift of his boss at almost every turn. Giese, the former *Stanford Review* colleague, who remains an admirer of Sacks, said, “He is an asset to the Trump administration on AI policy. But now he’s trapped in a corrupt clown show.” The pervasive rot makes it almost impossible to distinguish public policy from private venality. The Trump administration’s corruption requires a taxonomy of its own.

At the most blatant level are the gifts the president accepts from abroad: the \$130,000 gold bar and the gold Rolex desk clock from Swiss billionaires, followed by a lowering of U.S. tariffs on Switzerland; the \$400 million jet from the

Qatari royal family that might cost another half a billion or so to be outfitted as Air Force One, followed by a presidential visit (Trump’s first major foreign trip in his second term) to a country accused of sponsoring terrorism; the Trump-family memecoins sold to wealthy favor seekers. Clark called such brazen bribes “power corruption”: displays intended to show that Trump can get away with anything—“the equivalent of shooting somebody on Fifth Avenue.”

A slightly less glaring kind of corruption abuses government power for private gain: presidential pardons handed out to past and future benefactors; investment deals floated by Trump’s two favorite diplomats, his real-estate buddy Steve Witkoff and his son-in-law Jared Kushner, during the most sensitive peace talks in Russia and the Middle East; major investments in Trump-family crypto and real-estate businesses by foreign governments with extensive U.S. interests; stock trades and prediction bets likely based on insider access to official information, including about war.

Criminal anti-corruption statutes are still on the books. But these embarrassing shows of personal turpitude go uninvestigated and unpunished because the mechanisms for holding public officials accountable have been destroyed. When whistleblowers go unprotected, inspectors general are fired, incompetent loyalists replace nonpartisan civil servants, the Department of Justice is turned into the president’s own law firm and police force, and Congress abandons any oversight function, nothing is left to prevent the rot from spreading into every cell of government. (When Senator Warren wrote to Sacks asking for information on potential conflicts of interest in his role as a special government employee, the answer was silence.) The effect is to demoralize the public, to instill a sense of powerlessness. “We’re living in an era when the corruption is occurring on an unprecedented scale, orders of magnitude larger than anything we’ve seen in the history of this country,” Clark said. “And yet the more important story is what Trump has done to enable that corruption, which is dismantling the rule of law.”

Finally, there’s what Lawrence Lessig, of Harvard Law School, calls “institutional corruption,” which may be perfectly legal: the warping of public trust toward private ends, the replacement of the country’s priorities with those of a special-interest group. This brings us back to Sacks.

IN HIS 2025 INAUGURAL ADDRESS, Trump declared America to be at the start of a “golden age.” His administration put crypto and AI at its center.

Cryptocurrency is a long-standing libertarian project—the dream of a privatized financial system. The founders of PayPal originally aspired to create a tool that gave people around the world access to finance, including in poor and corrupt countries without reliable banking institutions. But in practice, crypto’s anonymity and volatility have made it extremely prone to criminal activity and risky speculation. As a candidate in 2024, Trump, a former crypto skeptic and a latecomer to investing in it, won the industry’s lucrative backing on a promise to put the federal government to work on its behalf and turn the U.S. into “the crypto capital of the planet.” Back in office, he pardoned convicted crypto executives, neutered consumer protections, ended investigations by the Securities and Exchange Commission into crypto firms with



ties to Trump's businesses, and disbanded the Justice Department's crypto-enforcement team. In May 2025, investors paid up to \$400 million to buy \$TRUMP memecoins in exchange for access to the president at a private crypto gala. Since 2024, Trump's crypto wealth has grown by at least \$7.5 billion.

Sacks's main item of business was to push through Congress a bill that would create a regulatory structure for cryptocurrency—something that the Biden administration hadn't done, to the frustration of the industry and venture capitalists. The GENIUS Act required issuers of a type of crypto called stablecoin to back their digital currency on a one-to-one basis with assets such as dollars and short-term U.S. Treasury bills. According to Sacks and other supporters, the GENIUS Act would position the dollar as the default currency of the digital economy, while providing guardrails against fraud and other abuses. Critics argued that the guardrails were inadequate, and that crypto issued by private firms with government backing could undermine the entire financial system because of weak regulations and nonexistent enforcement actions. The law also does nothing to prevent government officials from profiting off crypto. When the GENIUS Act passed on a bipartisan vote in July, Silicon Valley and Sacks won the first big return on their investment in Trump.

IF SACKS'S PURPOSE with crypto was to bring it under a federal regulatory regime in order to make the industry more viable to buyers and valuable to investors, his goal with AI was to keep it unregulated, and to align administration policy with the industry's wishes. His motto became "Let the private sector cook."

At the start of his term, Trump revoked a Biden executive order that, among other measures, required AI labs to share the results of safety testing with the government. Though one company found that complying with the order required just one day of work for a single employee per year, Trump pronounced it onerous. *Safetyism* became a dirty word on the tech right, almost as contemptible as the phrase *woke AI*—an all-purpose indictment of Biden-era attempts to limit harm from AI to the public, especially children. Yet in the early weeks of the new administration, its policies reflected more continuity than rupture. Not only did Trump keep Biden's restrictions on licensing the export of advanced AI technology to adversaries such as China; he even strengthened them.

Sacks's influence increased when Elon Musk, his old friend and fellow PayPal mafioso, who was running the Department of Government Efficiency near the czar's office in the Eisenhower Executive Office Building, walked away from his work of stripping the executive branch. "You see a more conciliatory approach to China emerging only after Musk has his falling-out with the White House," Oren Cass, the founder of the conservative think tank American Compass, told me. "With Musk out of the picture, I think Sacks certainly became more prominent." In April 2025, David Feith, a China hawk who was a senior director for technology and national security on the National



Sacks, with J. D. Vance in the foreground, at the Republican National Convention in 2024. A month earlier, Sacks had hosted the fundraiser that helped close the deal on Vance's selection as Donald Trump's running mate.

Security Council, was fired in a larger purge after the right-wing influencer Laura Loomer warned Trump that Feith was disloyal. Soon after, the NSC's whole technology directorate was eliminated, clearing the way for Sacks to become the loudest voice on tech policy. His goal was to keep AI free of regulation and let the private sector sell the most advanced American technology to the world—even to China.

On May 13, Trump scrapped a Biden rule, about to take effect, that would have restricted the global spread of advanced AI technology by dividing countries into three categories of trust, with China fully denied access. (A former White House official called it "the most 'America First' rule the Biden administration ever had.") That same day the president traveled to the Middle East to consummate a deal, which Sacks had helped negotiate, to sell 500,000 AI chips to the United Arab Emirates. This astonishing figure alarmed national-security officials: Some of the chips were likely to end up in China, where strict export controls still applied, and the sale would make it easier for the Emiratis to acquire enough computing power to build their own AI capabilities.

The smell of corruption hung in the air before Air Force One took off for Abu Dhabi. At the beginning of May, one of Witkoff's sons had announced that the Emirates' AI-investment firm would put \$2 billion into the crypto exchange Binance, using a stablecoin issued by World Liberty Financial, the crypto company founded by the Trump and Witkoff families. A co-founder of Binance, Changpeng Zhao, was pardoned by Trump after serving four months in a U.S. prison in 2024 for failing to comply with anti-money-laundering measures. In January of this year, *The Wall Street Journal* reported an even more blatant scandal: A few days before Trump's inauguration, a powerful Emirati politician known as the "spy sheikh" (almost always photographed wearing sunglasses, even in the Oval Office) had bought a 49 percent share of World Liberty Financial. These deals made the UAE chip sale look like a giant payoff from the administration.

No one is allowed to be more corrupt than the president, but Sacks may well benefit from Emirati goodwill. The nearly \$3 trillion UAE sovereign-wealth fund, of which more than half is controlled by the spy sheikh, offers an immense pot of money for venture capital. Although Sacks had no financial interest in the chip deal that he helped broker, it could put Craft Ventures in a sweet spot for a future round of funding. Is it unfair to point this out? Sacks's position makes it naive not to. Remaining an investor while serving in an administration rife with graft and shaping policies that could significantly affect present and future deals blurs the line between public and private into indistinction. "It's hard to disentangle his ideology from his personal interests," the congressional aide who has followed Sacks closely said. "Maybe they're one and the same: 'Let the private sector cook,' and it just so happens he benefits handsomely from that." (Sacks's spokesperson told *The Atlantic* that future investments "would not be a violation of government-ethics rules. Qualified people would not want to serve in government if it meant permanently giving up their careers.")

On July 23, the White House released its "AI action plan" at an event in Washington co-hosted by the *All-In* podcast. Trump called out each of Sacks's "besties" from the show, and they shared the stage with Vice President Vance and other administration leaders. (Susie Wiles, Trump's chief of staff, had nixed the original idea for *All-In* to be the sole sponsor, perhaps out of a sense of propriety.) The 28-page plan, "Winning the Race," called for rapid development of AI technology and construction of data centers so the U.S. can achieve global dominance. It was co-signed by Sacks, but its main author was Dean Ball, a technology researcher who served as a White House adviser for four months last year. Ball pointed out to me that the plan didn't pose a choice between innovation and safety, nor did it take a position on changes in export controls: "What it does say is we should enforce the chip-export controls that we have more robustly than we currently do."

But Sacks had already undermined this key aspect of the plan. A week before it was released, Jensen Huang, the CEO of Nvidia, the world's leader in AI-chip production, had announced the resumption of the sale of Nvidia's H20 chips to China, which the Trump administration had banned in April, before Sacks became the dominant official in tech policy. AI is an industry in which the U.S. has a significant advantage over its main rival. China is able to produce less than 3 percent of U.S. computing power—200,000 chips a year to America's 12 million or so. Hardly anyone except Sacks was able to explain how the decision to lift the ban on selling chips to China fit with "winning the race" for global dominance, or with an "America First" administration.

"I would define *winning* as the whole world consolidates around

the American tech stack," he said on *All-In*. "If we have 80 to 90 percent market share, that's winning." In other words, sell advanced American AI everywhere, including China, to make U.S. technologies and companies dominant. The counter-argument, made to me by former Biden-administration officials as well as conservative critics of the Trump-Sacks policy, is that China will never allow itself to become dependent on U.S. technology. Instead, the People's Republic will do what it's done in other sectors: steal U.S. technology and innovate its own—the long-term "indigenization" strategy of Xi Jinping, and the reason the regime has prevented Chinese AI companies, which are hungry for American chips, from importing anywhere close to the numbers the Trump administration has made available for sale.

"Folks on the pro-export side have a story about how actually selling more of these advanced chips to China will addict them to our technology stack and slow their progress," Oren Cass said of the Trump-Sacks policy. "I find it a ridiculously inadequate story that never holds up to 10 seconds of scrutiny." Cass distinguished between an ideological view of U.S.-China competition ("two incompatible systems that can coexist but can't be integrated in any meaningful way") and the commercial view that has always been Trump's, and seems to be Sacks's. The key figure in moving American tech policy on China to the commercial view was Huang, who was eager to gain greater access to the Chinese market. Sacks now had the clout to accompany the CEO of the world's richest firm into the Oval Office. "When Jensen comes to town, it elevates Sacks's stature," the congressional aide said.

I asked a former White House official with knowledge of the discussions if Sacks had achieved his goal of lifting the ban on selling chips to China simply by sitting down with Huang and a president with a well-known weakness for plutocrats. "Yes. That is exactly what happened," the former official said. As for Sacks's motive, "there is not a rational explanation. I think doing favors for Nvidia is the only real explanation, or else he believes Nvidia's talking points that no one else buys." (In a letter to *The New York Times* in November, Sacks's lawyers wrote that the policies Sacks

"This is why the person who's regulating AI for the U.S. government shouldn't also be running a venture-capital firm that has money all throughout the tech industry. *Of course* he's picking the winners that in some way benefit him."

had advocated for benefited “all American chip companies” and that “Mr. Sacks has independently arrived at his views on chip policy by consulting and reading hundreds of experts in the space.”)

Even if Sacks is solely motivated by a sincere belief in free-market capitalism, his portfolio companies could now have privileged access to the world’s most coveted computer chips in a market where demand is stronger than supply. “This is why the person who’s regulating AI for the U.S. government shouldn’t also be running a venture-capital firm that has money all throughout the tech industry,” the former White House official said. “Of course he’s picking the winners that in some way benefit him.”

IN DECEMBER, Huang secured an even more valuable victory when the White House allowed Nvidia to begin selling to China one of its most advanced AI chips, the H200. This was too much for some conservative Republicans on Capitol Hill. Jim Banks, a MAGA-aligned senator from Indiana, had already introduced bipartisan legislation, called GAIN AI, that required Nvidia to put American customers, such as start-up companies and universities, ahead of Chinese companies for its limited supply of AI chips. Sacks, determined to prevent government from limiting tech’s commercial potential, began lobbying hard to keep GAIN AI out of the annual defense-appropriation bill. His efforts to get Republican senators to strip it from their version failed, but when the White House declared its opposition, House Republican leadership killed GAIN AI just before the final vote in December. “What ultimately happened is Jensen talked to the president about this, the dam broke, and Sacks got his way,” the congressional aide told me.

Sacks had less success when the administration tried to get Congress to pass a 10-year moratorium on state AI regulations. The measure lost in the Senate in July, 99–1, but its unpopularity didn’t deter Sacks from trying again. In December, Trump signed an executive order, written by Sacks, that banned states from passing laws to regulate AI. By then, state legislatures had introduced hundreds of bills—chiefly in blue states such as California and New York, but also in Florida, Utah, and Texas—and enacted dozens.

Sacks’s heavy-handed interventions in Congress on behalf of tech companies did not sit well with some of Trump’s MAGA allies. Stopping the spread of sexual material, protecting children from harmful chatbots, preserving individual privacy, heading off catastrophic threats such as bio-terrorism, preventing large-scale unemployment—these things turn out to matter to Americans across the partisan divide. Polls consistently show that a majority fear AI will do more harm than good. Citizens of the world’s AI leader have a more negative view of the technology than those of almost any other country. Appearing on

All-In in December, Tucker Carlson gently pointed out to Sacks and his co-hosts that Americans already feel powerless—“and all of a sudden you have a technology that promises to concentrate power still further in the hands of people other than them, and so they’re touchy about it.”

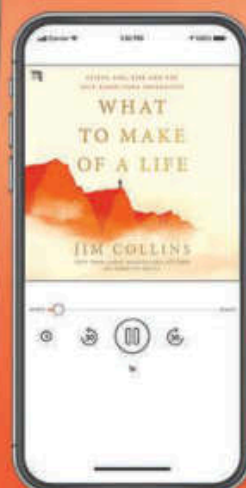
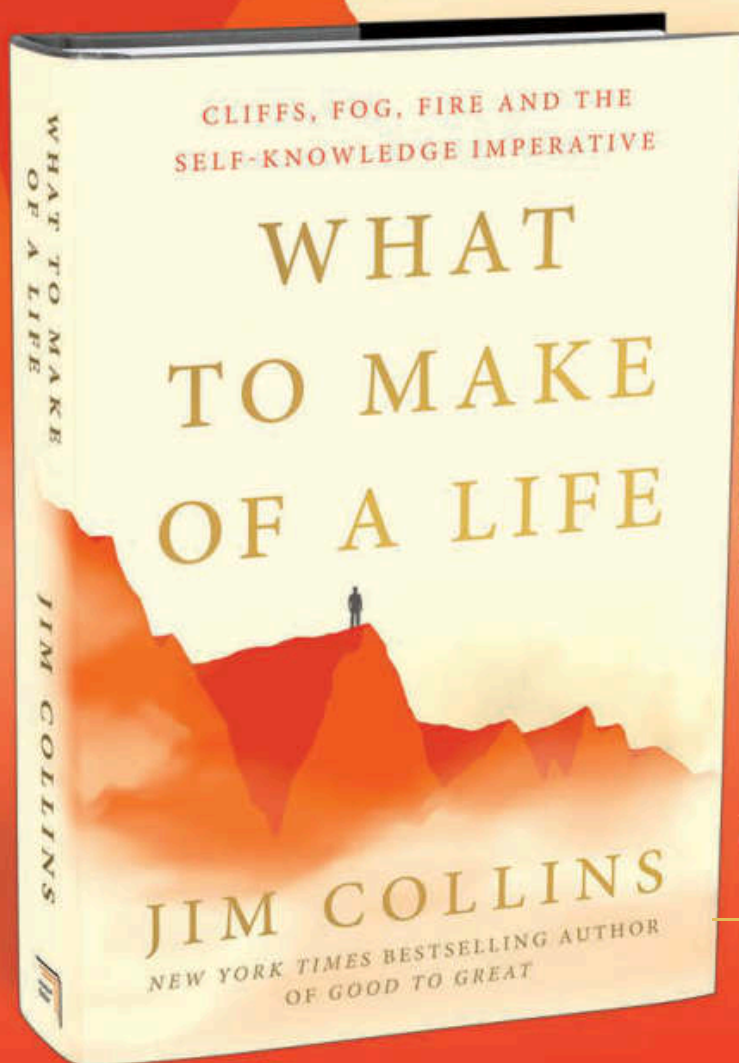
Oren Cass told me, “One of the challenges of the tech right is they are—what’s the opposite of *adept*?” I offered *clumsy*. “They are very politically clumsy and don’t have a very good feel for the realities of the American electorate, how politics is conducted, what it takes to be successful.” Steve Bannon, a leader of the populist wing of the MAGA movement, recently told me that Sacks’s efforts on behalf of Silicon Valley are blowing up in his face. “Sacks is the best thing to ever happen to the populist revolt against the oligarchs. His unique blend of arrogance and incompetence has single-handedly delivered humiliating defeat to the AI supremacists.”

Meanwhile, AI’s capability is doubling about every four months. It is already changing work and life for millions of people, with the potential to transform fields such as medicine and war. Its inventors spend hundreds of billions of dollars to develop the technology even as they issue dire warnings of its dangers: *It might kill us, but we have to make it as powerful as possible as fast as possible*. Sacks dismisses or minimizes the potential for harm. In public comments he has claimed that AI isn’t addictive like social media, that productivity gains will more than make up for lost jobs, and that the number of teenage suicides caused by chatbots is small. Because China doesn’t care about things like copyright protection, compensated journalism, and restrictions on export licenses, we can’t afford to either. He accuses skeptics of belonging to the cult of effective altruists—“doomers,” funded by a few anti-AI Big Tech billionaires, who peddle lies to invite global control of the technology for their own financial gain.

One of the doomers, Nate Soares, a co-author of *If Anyone Builds It, Everyone Dies*, told me: “The lab leaders say this is horribly dangerous, the employees say this is horribly dangerous, the eminent scientists and researchers who developed AI decades ago say this is horribly dangerous. The only people who say ‘Don’t worry’

“Sacks is the best thing to ever happen to the populist revolt against the oligarchs. His unique blend of arrogance and incompetence has single-handedly delivered humiliating defeat to the AI supremacists.”

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are the venture capitalists. They're the ones who stand to profit from it but aren't close enough to understand it."

Unlike Andreessen, Sacks doesn't equate regulating AI with mass murder. But for every concern, he has the same answer: AI is coming, just like the tide. If America doesn't win the race, China will.

ONCE IN GOVERNMENT, Sacks learned to adopt his boss's language and defend the indefensible. He derided "fake news" and called climate change a "hoax," January 6 prosecutions "lawfare," the notion of White House corruption "nonsense," and the killing of two protesters by federal immigration agents in Minneapolis a consequence of "antifa-style operations" intent on thwarting the president's deportation of "criminal aliens." He liked Trump's idea of seizing Greenland and predicted that the war in Iran, which he blamed on "that whole neocon establishment," would probably be short and decisive because the markets wanted it over and Trump's political instincts were "impeccable." But on the threats of censorship, politicized justice, state surveillance, and monopoly power, which had once animated his outrage, and which now came from the Trump administration, he had nothing to say. Sacks had become what he always despised—political.

In March, he left his position as AI-and-crypto czar, saying that he had completed his 130 days of service, and returned full-time to Craft Ventures. In December he had moved from San Francisco to Austin, just in time to escape a proposed tax on billionaires that may appear before California voters this November.

Silicon Valley will still have a valuable line to the White House. When Sacks stepped down, he was named co-chair of the President's Council of Advisors on Science and Technology. Its members include Andreessen, Zuckerberg, Huang, Sergey Brin, Larry Ellison, Michael Dell, a co-founder of a cryptocurrency exchange, the CEO of a semiconductor manufacturer, and a billionaire investor who co-hosts *All-In* with Sacks. (Among the 15 there is one academic scientist.) This lineup, almost a parody of crony capitalism, signals the final union of America's interests with those of its wealthiest citizens—tech power fused with state power. The private sector is cooking in Washington.

In his year there, Sacks achieved his two central goals: putting the government's seal of approval on crypto and keeping its hands off artificial intelligence. He was also a founding member of an exclusive MAGA-aligned club in Georgetown, with a fee of \$500,000, called the Executive Branch, and he midwived the creation of an AI-industry lobby, Innovation Council, that plans to spend at least \$100 million in support of the Trump administration's technology policy in this year's midterm elections.

In winning his policy battles, though, Sacks might have lost the war. What Tim Wu calls "the turn away from populism to



Sacks and the Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg at a private White House dinner for technology and business leaders in September

corruption in tech policy" has alienated important parts of the MAGA coalition from Trump and his rich backers. Steve Bannon says that he and his anti-Big Tech allies are going to make the Innovation Council "the moral equivalent of AIPAC: You take that money and you're dead." At some point, an unlikely left-right alliance could unite against the tech oligarchs. "Donald Trump and his administration are using the presidency to make themselves and their billionaire friends richer," Senator Warren told me, listing Sacks's policy achievements in crypto and AI. "We are at an inflection point where very powerful AI systems threaten to displace jobs and transform our economy—and we will be living with the consequences for years if Sacks gets his way."

AI could well be the most important issue in the 2028 presidential election. Sacks has moved Trump into the camp of the Silicon Valley saints, selling a world few people actually want to live in, where the state is the handmaiden of industry, wealth accumulates to insider elites tainted by grift, and ordinary people find that they're losing the last power they have left, over their own minds.

Every so often, the hosts of *All-In* remember that staggering quantities of money are pooling upward in America, while discontent roils down below. Suddenly sounding earnest, almost chastened, one of them will call on the group to "fix this inequality gap," end "ostentatious displays of wealth," do more in the mode of Carnegie and Rockefeller to benefit the public, maybe even support a wealth tax to stave off the coming class war. But Sacks will have none of it. He alone remains committed to the principle of self-interest. He still believes that capitalism means never having to say you're sorry. *A*

George Packer is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

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THE CLOWN SHOW

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The Savannah Bananas are reviving one of the most entertaining—and controversial—teams in Negro Leagues history.

BY JOSH LEVIN

“M

y dad was a big Lakers fan,” Kobe Shaquille Robinson told me, indulging an admittedly obvious question. Robinson was born in 2001, in the middle of Kobe Bryant and Shaquille O’Neal’s three-NBA-championship run. But he discovered early on that his name couldn’t help him shoot a basketball. As an athlete, he stood out on the pitcher’s mound.

Robinson is 6 foot 2 and lanky; when we met, he was wearing his hair in two-strand twists. We were talking on a Saturday afternoon in Memphis, in a retro-style downtown stadium named after an auto-

parts chain. It was, in a way, the perfect venue for a conversation with an up-and-coming ballplayer—a minor-league park with all the trimmings of a major-league one. It was also, objectively speaking, an unusual workplace for a Black athlete in 2026.

Back in the mid-1980s, during the prime of Ozzie Smith, Rickey Henderson, Tony Gwynn, and Dwight Gooden, more than 18 percent of Major League Baseball players were Black. Now that figure is just below 7 percent—right around where it was in 1956, less than a decade after Jackie Robinson broke the color line.

No single reason explains Black Americans’ diminished footprint in the sport; the high cost of equipment and travel ball, dwindling municipal funding for youth leagues, the rise of the NFL and the NBA, and a parallel surge of Latino talent have all contributed. Despite these factors, Kobe Robinson still dreamed of a life in baseball. “I just felt like the man out there,” he said. “So I stuck with it.”

Robinson’s fastball, which earned him the nickname “Hot Sauce,” carried him from a Tennessee community college to the 2021 MLB draft, where he was selected by the San Diego Padres. Injuries, however, stymied his early career: He had issues with his elbow, then his shoulder. In 2024, the Padres released him. The closest he ever got to the big show was A-ball, three rungs below the majors.

At 23, Robinson was out of baseball and, he said, “in a dark space.” He took overnight caregiving shifts at a group home, delivered packages for Amazon, and searched for a way to get back on the field. Last fall, after a year on the sidelines, he found a potential opening: The Savannah Bananas were hiring.

Over the past three-plus years, the Bananas have gone from a baseball curiosity to a cultural juggernaut. The team tours the country playing what it calls Banana Ball: a family-friendly, souped-up, TikTok-ready version of the national pastime. Games feature singing and dancing and celebrity cameos, plus backflipping outfielders, stilt-walking batters, and the occasional double to the gap. Last year, according to the organization’s own data, the Bananas and their affiliated teams sold 2.2 million tickets—more than 11 different MLB franchises.

The Bananas are frequently compared to the Harlem Globetrotters. But unlike their basketball counterparts, who ritually

defeat the rival Washington Generals, the Bananas don’t script the outcomes of their games. They play against—and sometimes lose to—a rotating band of teams with their own personalities and followings. Among their opponents are the denim-clad Texas Tailgaters, the often-shirtless Party Animals, and the Firefighters, who make their entrance in full firefighting uniforms, as if to douse an inferno in right field.

Robinson filled out a Prospective Banana Ball Player form and got invited to audition for a roster spot. He knew from a former teammate who played for the Firefighters that this would not be a traditional tryout. “I didn’t want to go dressed as just a baseball player, because that’s not what they look for,” he said. Instead, he went as Frozone, the *Incredibles* character voiced by Samuel L. Jackson. “It looked kind of goofy,” he said of his blue-and-white bodysuit. “But I said, *I don’t care. I’m going out there, and I’m pitching.*” In this context, pitching meant doing a synchronized twirl with his infielders, then firing a fastball across home plate.

The scouts liked what they saw. A month later, Robinson was drafted by one of two expansion teams making their Banana Ball debut in 2026: the Indianapolis Clowns.

Unlike the other teams in the extended Bananas universe, the Clowns are not an original creation. They were a real baseball franchise that competed in the Negro Leagues; in 1952, they signed a teenage prospect named Hank Aaron. Like the Bananas, they were also an entertainment act. The Clowns traveled with acrobats, a “one-man jazz band” called Boogie Woogie Paul, and an actual circus clown. Some of the only existing footage of the original Clowns shows the long-limbed first baseman Reece “Goose” Tatum, who also played for the Globetrotters, dropping to his knees as if to pray for a base hit and getting awakened from a fainting spell by a smelly foot.

Jesse Cole, the 42-year-old impresario behind the Bananas, has said that relaunching the Clowns is a way to honor one of Banana Ball’s forebears and preserve the legacy of the Negro Leagues. Robinson was thrilled. The Clowns “paved this way for us,” he told me. “Now we have to bring it back to this day and age and make it even better.” The Clowns also provide an opportunity to increase Black representation in baseball. Robinson, who feared that his career was over, now has another shot.

But the decision to revive the Indianapolis Clowns isn’t as straightforward as it may seem. Although the team’s antics were widely popular, they could also descend into racial caricature. The Clowns rankled both their Negro Leagues peers and Black sportswriters, chief among them Wendell Smith. The influential *Pittsburgh Courier* columnist called the team a “fourth-rate ‘Uncle Tom’ minstrel show.” He also accused the team’s white owner—who promoted one of his star pitchers as baseball’s version of the shuffling, feeble-minded minstrel character Stepin Fetchit—of profiting from “the kind of nonsense which many white people like to believe is typical and characteristic of all Negroes.”

The Savannah Bananas have risen to prominence by ostentatiously breaking the rules. Cole, who is white, often talks of his admiration for P. T. Barnum, the brash showman who would do anything to attract an audience. The Bananas’ owner rightly intuited that baseball, the most hidebound of American sports, didn’t

know how to market itself to a new, social-media-enabled generation. Cole makes all of his public appearances in a banana-yellow tuxedo and banana-yellow top hat; he has made swaggering non-conformity part of the brand. “If you’re not getting criticized,” he has said, “you’re playing it too safe.”

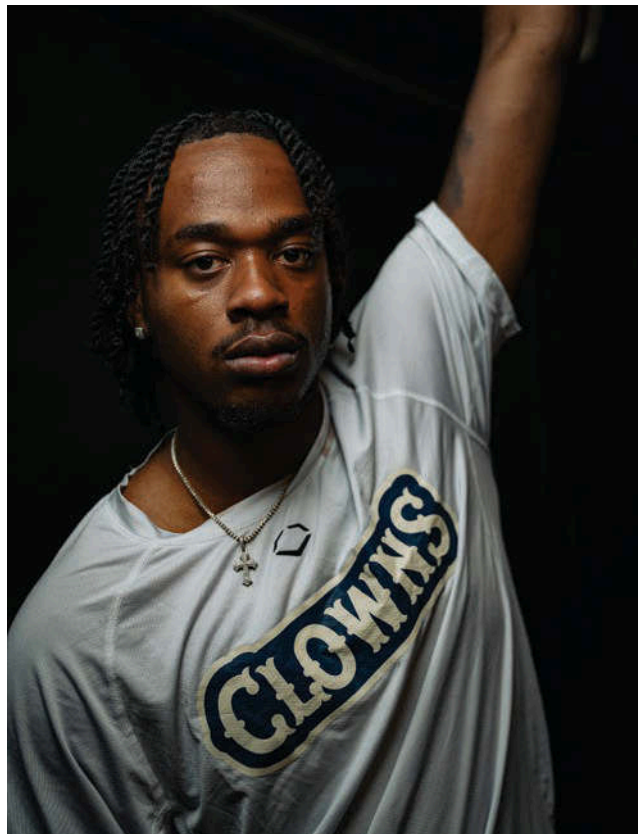
Resurrecting the Clowns definitely isn’t playing it safe.

WHEN BOB KENDRICK saw Banana Ball for the first time, in 2022, he felt like he was watching something at once new and very familiar. The action on the field was fast-paced and bold, and the fans were rapt. For Kendrick, the president of the Negro Leagues Baseball Museum, in Kansas City, Missouri, the scene evoked the audacity of preintegration Black baseball—the daring to build something new in opposition to the mainstream.

That May, Kendrick gave Cole and his players a private tour of the museum as part of an ESPN documentary series on the Bananas. Kendrick took the team to the section that featured the Clowns and told Cole that he saw them as an ancestor of the Bananas. “I think that’s when he had the epiphany that someday he would bring back the Indianapolis Clowns,” Kendrick told me.

The Clowns’ revival is a business arrangement: The Negro Leagues museum, which owns the Clowns’ intellectual property, received a fee from the Bananas for the rights to use the team’s

Kobe Robinson was drafted by the San Diego Padres, but never made it past A-ball. The Indianapolis Clowns are a second chance at professional baseball.



name and develop a set of new logos. The partnership, Kendrick said, “comes along at a perfect time,” as he’s raising \$50 million to build a 35,000-square-foot museum campus in Kansas City. Beyond the cash infusion, the Bananas will bring attention to the Negro Leagues, putting Black baseball history in front of a potentially huge audience.

In a video announcing the Clowns’ return, Kendrick offered a brief lesson on why the team mattered. He name-checked the luminaries who wore a Clowns uniform: an 18-year-old Hank Aaron, a 60-something Satchel Paige, and the pathbreaking Toni Stone, who became the first woman to get consistent playing time for a professional baseball club when she joined the Clowns in 1953. Kendrick explained that the team helped popularize “shadow ball,” an elaborate routine in which real and invisible baseballs are tossed around the infield. And he said that, until the Clowns folded in the late 1980s, they were the last team standing from the Negro Leagues.

Everything Kendrick said in the video is true. But that introduction to the Clowns is incomplete. Their full story is one of ingenuity and endurance, but also exploitation.

The history of racial caricature in baseball goes back nearly as far as the organized game itself. As early as the 1870s, blackface performers began, in the words of the historian James E. Brunson III, to “exploit the game’s lucrative possibilities.” Many decades later, a team called the Zulu Cannibal Giants pushed this minstrel tradition to a dreadful extreme, taking the field in bare feet and grass skirts with “war paint” slathered on their bodies.

The man who created the Cannibal Giants in the 1930s was a former Negro Leagues pitcher. The team’s Northeast booking agent was a New Yorker with a background in vaudeville. His name was Syd Pollock, and he would become best known for owning another barnstorming team: the Ethiopian Clowns. Pollock’s Clowns wore wigs and pancake makeup and played under faux-African pseudonyms such as Abbadaba and Tarzan. They also trafficked in humor that was, at best, minstrel-adjacent.

Richard “King Tut” King, who’d previously had a stint with the Cannibal Giants, was the team’s most prominent comedian. He would emerge from the dugout looking like an escaped prisoner, or pantomime shooting craps before dropping his pants. His main collaborator on the Clowns was a dwarf known as Spec Bebop. (His real name was Ralph Bell.) In one recurring skit, a dentist gag, Tut would place a lit firecracker in Bebop’s mouth.

In the early 1940s, Negro Leagues owners banded together to try to prohibit their teams from playing Pollock’s franchise. The ban proved impossible to enforce, though, because the Clowns were so popular—with both white and Black fans—that cash-poor Black-owned clubs felt they had no choice but to book them.

The Negro American League eventually eased up on its Clowns ban, admitting them to the league in 1943. The Clowns, for their part, promised to lose the makeup and stop calling themselves Ethiopian. The team, which had been nominally based in Miami, rebranded itself, becoming the Cincinnati Clowns before moving to Indianapolis. They got rid of the paint, too, though not right away. At Howard University’s Moorland-Spingarn Research Center, I found a 1945 program touting



the Clowns as the “Most Sensational Ball Club in the World.” Next to that caption was a photo of 15 men with white clown makeup slathered on their faces.

The Clowns were at times competitive in their new league, but the NAL—and Black baseball as a whole—was soon decimated by integration. When Major League Baseball plucked away the likes of Jackie Robinson, Larry Doby, and Roy Campanella in the late 1940s, Black fans abandoned the Negro Leagues en masse.

The Clowns were better positioned than their peers to navigate the Negro Leagues’ collapse. That was largely because Pollock had a knack for making his team the center of attention. In 1953, the Clowns’ owner signed Toni Stone, declaring that baseball was the “latest masculine enterprise to fall before the advance of wearers of skirts and panties.” The team’s new female second baseman was a media and box-office sensation, reviving interest in the entire Negro American League. “Give the fans something they want to see,” a triumphant Pollock said, “and they’ll come out.”

The boom didn’t last. In his book *Negro League Baseball: The Rise and Ruin of a Black Institution*, the historian Neil Lanctot writes that crowds dwindled the next season despite the Clowns’ addition of two new women, Connie Morgan and Mamie “Peanut” Johnson. After the 1954 season, the Clowns left the Negro American League, and a year later, all three female pioneers were out of baseball. As an independent barnstorming team, the Clowns returned to their slapstick roots and played to smaller audiences. One game in 1964—estimated attendance: 400 people—featured the 4-foot-5 Billy Vaughn playing third base in a dress and the first baseman James “Natureboy” Williams pulling an oar, a golf club, a mannequin leg, and four baseball bats out of his pants.

In 1968, the Clowns reverse-integrated, adding their first white player. By the 1980s, the decade when the Clowns finally petered out, the team’s roster was entirely white.

A LITTLE AFTER 9:30 A.M., three and a half hours before the first pitch of the new Indianapolis Clowns’ Sunday matinee in Memphis, Jackie Bradley Jr. was already on the field. His task that morning in early March was to lock down his part

in a mid-game song-and-dance routine. When Outkast’s “Hey Ya!” started booming from the stadium PA, though, he seemed uncertain of his moves. My scouting report: For a dancer, he’s a great center fielder.

The former Red Sox star, now 36, was the first ex-major leaguer to move to Banana Ball full-time. In his Clowns debut, he caught a fly ball behind his back. “I’ve had to rewire my brain to not just catch the ball,” he told me. “Any ball that’s hit to me, I almost have to do a trick play, because they just see me catch it normal, it’s like, *Oh, whatever. Do something cool.*”

Mastery of trick-play theory and technique is a job requirement in Banana Ball. “These guys are baseball players,” Errick Fox, the team’s head coach, told me. “You also have to flip that switch and be like, *Hey guys, you’re performers.*”

Fox grew up in Atlanta in the ’90s, when the Braves’ lineup featured Black superstars such as Fred McGriff, David Justice, and Deion Sanders. “At that time, it was exciting,” he recalled. “All of us kind of gravitated to really want to be like those guys.” One of his first responsibilities as the Clowns’ coach, he said, was to “get some Black ballplayers.”

Bradley, who’d made a cameo appearance with the Bananas in 2025 at the urging of his oldest daughter, was the team’s top recruit. The Clowns’ partnership with the Negro Leagues museum played a role in his decision to sign on, as did the potential to sway more Black athletes to get into baseball. As a young prospect in Virginia, he’d gotten used to being the only Black player on the field. “I enjoyed the people that I was around,” he said, “but I definitely wanted there to be more people to look like me.”

Top Left: The Indianapolis Clowns manager Buster Haywood and the player Toni Stone circa 1953.

Below: Richard “King Tut” King, the team’s most prominent comic act, and his main collaborator, Ralph Bell, known as Spec Bebob.



Some of Bradley's new teammates are Banana Ball veterans. Malachi Mitchell told me that his baseball philosophy is to "play loud"—to run hard, display his emotions, and try to put on a show. That approach didn't always go over well in Florida's youth-baseball scene. He ran across "a lot of racist people," he said, and "the words they would use are *arrogant* or *he's doing too much*." For the Savannah Bananas, too much was the perfect amount. Mitchell adopted the persona of "Flash Tha Kid," the Bananas' designated runner, delighting fans with his speed on the basepaths, simulated banjo playing, and willingness to eat a disgusting amount of fettuccine Alfredo in service of a comedy bit. But as one of the organization's few Black players, Mitchell told me he sometimes "felt a little separated." When Jesse Cole asked him if he wanted to switch to the Clowns, he said yes right away. "Now I feel at home," he said.

Another group of Clowns got pulled from baseball's discard pile. When Nick Wilson threw his final pitch in college, he marked what he thought was the end of his career by tossing his cleats over a telephone wire. Last fall, he was selling computer equipment when he heard about a Banana Ball tryout in Nashville. It was the same audition where Kobe Robinson showed up in a Frozone costume. Wilson went as a Ninja Turtle.

Wilson told me his mother hadn't been sure about the whole Clowns thing—she worried that the team's name might put him in a bad light. But the franchise's connection to the Negro Leagues was meaningful to him. Wilson's grandfather James, who died in 2017, played pro baseball in Houston in the early '50s, when sports were still segregated in the city. Now he had the chance to carry that legacy forward. "This is history," he told me. "Why would I not want to be a part of a team called the Clowns?"

The team I saw in March wasn't quite complete. A month later, the Clowns brought on Mo'ne Davis, who in 2014 became the first girl to throw a shutout in the Little League World Series. Twelve years later, she's joined the Clowns' lineage of pioneering Black female athletes. In Davis's inaugural Clowns appearance, she retired her first batter on a routine grounder to third.

The new Clowns aren't all Black. Among the team's white players are the two most clownish guys on the roster: 20-year-old Fisher Polydoroff, a multi-instrumentalist magician who's adopted the persona of a 1950s pitcher named "Ole Knuckles," and 38-year-old Mat Wolf, a second-generation rodeo clown with a deep repertoire of trick pitches and methods for dropping his pants. ("You can do it quickly, you can do it slowly, you can do it with a spin," he explained to me.)

Saturday night's game began with a ceremonial weigh-in. Wilson, the Clowns' contestant, faced off against the Party Animals' Jake Lialios, a man who (judging by his social-media presence) spends most of his waking hours covered in baby oil. Both players stood atop a pink scale, then flexed and danced bare-chested. Around the time when an on-field announcer described Wilson as "over six feet of meat," it dawned on me that AutoZone Park would not be hosting a nuanced colloquy on Black representation in baseball.

This weekend series was really about the Party Animals. They were the "home team" in Memphis, which meant the Clowns mostly got subsumed within their opponent's hot-pink-and-glistening-pecs aesthetic. "As the away team, we just don't have



Jackie Bradley Jr. was the first former major leaguer to play Banana Ball full-time. He was a star center fielder for the Red Sox; now he's honing his juggling skills.

the same number of opportunities to share and kind of story-tell," Joe Meyer told me.

Meyer is the Clowns' 24-year-old show coordinator—the man responsible for developing the team's look and feel. "In my role, I'll say quite frankly, I think in some ways we had expected—or seriously considered—a person of color for it, and it's something that's important to us, and it is something to talk about," he said. Nevertheless, Meyer, who is white, has the assignment, and he feels the significance of what he's being asked to do: "Ultimately, how we build this brand is going to be how a lot of people remember not just the Clowns, but remember the Negro Leagues."

Day to day, Meyer produces and directs the Clowns' in-game entertainment. I first spotted him prowling the field with a clipboard, watching over the team's "Hey Ya!" dance routine. That kind of choreographed sequence—what's known in Bananaland as an "over-the-top moment," designed to pop live in the stadium and later on social media—tends to be a relatively small-scale production. The project that's really consuming Meyer is the Clowns' home-team show, which is scheduled to debut in Indianapolis in May. That will be the time, he said, when "the full brand kind of comes to life."

Traditionally, Banana Ball branding hasn't been difficult to parse. The Party Animals are party animals. The Firefighters fight fires. The Loco Beach Coconuts, this season's other new team, are represented by a coconut wearing sunglasses.

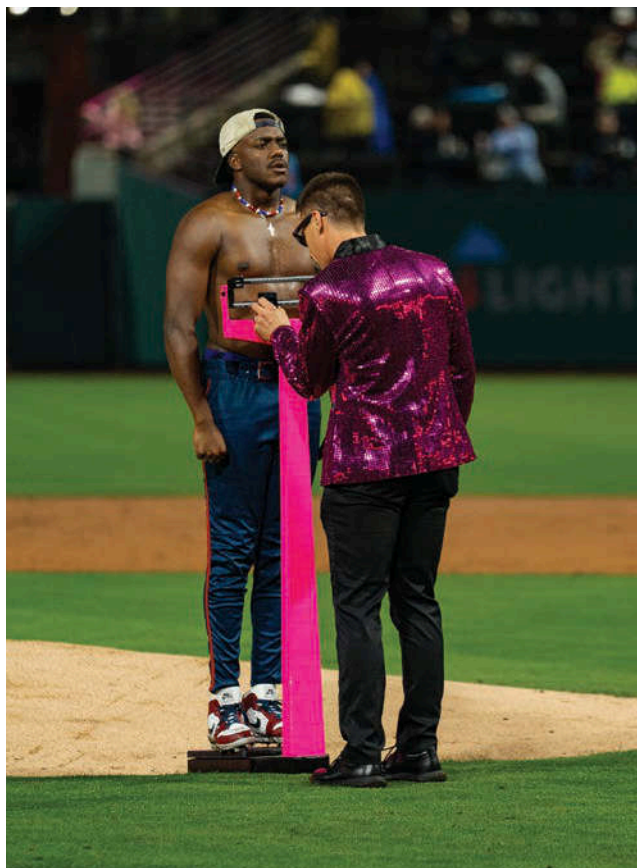
The Clowns are more complicated. When Meyer started diving into the franchise's past, he discovered a photo of the Ethiopian Clowns from their 1930s face-painting era. "You're like, *Whoa*," he said. "The Clowns name represented something a lot different than we think it did."

Early on, when Meyer and his colleagues were kicking around concepts for the team, he worried that they might be veering into *whoa* territory. He told me that he wrote up a five-page memo, essentially laying out the difference between a "minstrel show and the brand of today." His takeaway: "If we're super heavy in making these guys look like clowns, then we're really playing into this just negative part of the history."

The Clowns' logo, a pair of big red shoes, nods to the circus without approaching the realm of wigs and face paint. Still, a team known as the Clowns that can't look too clownish presents a marketing challenge. So does the mandate to educate as well as entertain. "Fans come to Banana Ball games expecting the greatest show in sports, and a show that is more than just a Negro Leagues history night," Meyer said.

In Memphis, the best preview of a fully realized Indianapolis Clowns experience came during pregame introductions. That segment began with some musical theater: a song, "Here Come the Clowns," that borrows its tune and pop-history approach

The Indianapolis Clown Nick Wilson during a weigh-in before a game against the Party Animals in March



from *Hamilton's* "My Shot." Written and performed by the team's hosts, Brandon Bomer and Jarius Jones—both young Black men—it provides some useful background for fans who don't know the team's history ("We started in the Negro League, when it was hard, sweat, tears, and blood we bleed").

When that musical number was over, more than a dozen players picked up baseballs and started juggling—for a juggler, Jackie Bradley Jr. is also a great center fielder—while Fisher Polydoroff and Mat Wolf threw pitches back and forth between their legs. The team then started playing shadow ball, with choreography inspired by the original Clowns' routine. There was a dive for an invisible grounder, an invisible throw from deep in the hole, and an invisible pop-up that bonked someone on the head. At one point, everyone started moving in extreme slow motion, before speeding up again. Then the finale: Malachi Mitchell did a backflip, caught an invisible ball at home plate, and—like magic—pulled a real ball from his glove.

BEFORE THE CLOWNS' Sunday game in Memphis, I started hearing rumors about a special guest—a figure from the team's past. Around 11:30 a.m., he showed up at the ballpark: a small, thin man with a slight smile, dressed in a navy Notre Dame hoodie and a vintage baseball cap embroidered with a red C.

Reginald Howard first crossed paths with the Clowns in the late 1940s, when he worked for the team as a batboy near his hometown of South Bend, Indiana. A decade later, he became their second baseman. Now, at 91 years old, he sat in the dugout at AutoZone Park as the modern-day Clowns leaned in close.

Howard told them that he was a "disciple" of Rube Foster, the Black baseball legend who founded the first sustained Negro League. He talked about long bus rides and asked if they'd heard of the two-way star Martín Dihigo. (Kobe Robinson said yes—Dihigo is a playable character in the video game *MLB: The Show*.) Then Nick Wilson, the pitcher whose grandfather played in segregated Texas, asked Howard a question: *How can we get Black kids to come back to baseball?* His answer: You've got to get them while they're young.

Howard had recently published a book about how baseball lost Black children in the first place. When he stepped onto the field to get saluted by the sold-out crowd, the PA announcer read the title in a cheery vibrato: *Baseball's Silent Genocide*. I don't have comprehensive records, but I believe this was the first time the word *genocide* was uttered over a loudspeaker at a Banana Ball game.

At a Starbucks the next day, Howard handed me a copy of his book and laid out his thesis. He believes there was a "sordid conspiracy" to preserve baseball as a predominantly white sport. As far back as his childhood, Black kids were told—and many came to believe—"this malarkey" that they were better equipped for sports other than baseball. He also watched resources shift toward all-white suburbs while they vanished in America's inner cities. Many of the Black players who did stick with baseball ended up profoundly isolated. In the worst case, he wrote, "you begin to think there's something wrong with you" just for liking the game.

The number of Black players in Major League Baseball rose for decades after integration. But that growth eventually stalled, then reversed. The historian Louis Moore has shown that at baseball's lower levels, Black talent was dwindling as far back as the early

1970s. Moore doesn't call this a conspiracy, but he does attribute the decline in part to informal racial quotas.

Major League Baseball now has a variety of initiatives to make the sport more accessible to Black athletes: youth academies, inner-city programs, showcases for players from historically Black colleges. The league has seen some positive returns; nine of the first 21 picks in the 2024 MLB draft were Black, and the overall percentage of Black Americans in the majors has increased slightly in the past two years. An MLB spokesperson told me that nearly a third of the 64 Black players on Opening Day rosters in 2026 emerged from the league's development pipeline.

Jesse Cole and Bob Kendrick are, in their way, contributing to the mission to revive Black baseball. But the problem with bringing back the Clowns is the same problem the team posed in its heyday. For as long as the Negro Leagues existed, Black ballplayers and their champions were battling for recognition and respect. What they were fighting against was the idea that their version of the game was nothing but a clown show.

It started with *The Pittsburgh Courier's* Wendell Smith, a forceful advocate for integration in the 1940s, who believed that the Ethiopian Clowns risked discrediting the entire Negro Leagues. It continued with Piper Davis, who mentored Willie Mays as a player and manager for the Birmingham Black Barons. "If you were Black, you was a clown. Because in the movies, the only time you saw a Black man, he was a comedian or a butler," Davis once said, reflecting on life and baseball under Jim Crow. "But didn't nobody clown in our league but the Indianapolis Clowns. We played baseball."

Historians of Black baseball have long struggled with how to tell the story of the Clowns. Larry Lester, one of the co-founders of the Negro Leagues Baseball Museum, told me he saw the old Clowns play as a child in the 1960s. "The skits were hilarious," he said. "But as a kid, I didn't realize the negative stereotypes that were being portrayed." Now, when he recounts the history of the Negro Leagues, he focuses on the greatest Black baseball teams ever assembled, such as the Homestead Grays and the Pittsburgh Crawfords.

Another of the museum's co-founders, Phil Dixon, told me that he intentionally omitted King Tut and Spec Bebob from his acclaimed photographic history of the Negro Leagues: They weren't the image of Black baseball that he wanted to portray.

Lester and Dixon have, through their research and advocacy, helped get Black baseball legends enshrined in Cooperstown and have their statistics acknowledged in the sport's official record books. But despite their best efforts, the Clowns still play an outsize role in public memory.

Kendrick, who presides over the Negro Leagues museum today, told me that he does not want to hide the uglier elements of the Clowns' history. At the museum, a display featuring the Clowns



Reginald Howard, who is 91, played for the original Indianapolis Clowns in the 1950s. In March, he visited with the new Clowns.

notes that they "strengthened common black stereotypes and were frowned upon by league management and the black press." Below the sign: a photo of King Tut in a billowing clown suit.

How do you append that kind of caveat to the show that the new Clowns are putting on? I wanted to ask Jesse Cole this and other questions. But the Banana Ball PR team, which made the Clowns' players available to me in Memphis, stopped replying to my inquiries and never granted my requests to speak with Cole. Meyer, the show coordinator, also didn't respond after initially promising to share his five-page memo on what separates the modern-day Clowns from the minstrelsy of their ancestors.

In our conversation, Meyer had emphasized that the larger story he wants to tell about the Clowns is one of triumph and unity—how a group of Negro Leagues players overcame adversity on the way to success. "This is all about us coming together, and it doesn't matter who you are, doesn't matter what you look like; you can be part of this team," he said. The uplifting narrative he was laying out didn't much resemble the scholarship of Lester and Dixon, to say nothing of Reginald Howard's jeremiad.

"Yes, race is a part of it," Meyer said. "But how do we make the story about the individual players and who the Negro Leagues and the original Indianapolis Clowns actually were?" He added, "I think that that story is so, so much bigger than the story of segregation."

Who were the original Indianapolis Clowns? Some of them were history makers, like Hank Aaron and Toni Stone. Others, like King Tut and Spec Bebob, were entertainers. But most were just ordinary baseball players, men like Howard.

In Memphis, Howard was introduced on the field as a man who'd suited up for the Clowns "as they barnstormed across the country, bringing joy and world-class baseball to fans of all backgrounds." But that wasn't the baseball life he'd actually lived. In his day, the late '50s, the Clowns didn't typically draw big crowds, and they weren't playing at a world-class level. "I would like to say that



Above: The Clowns do a pregame dance.
Below: Malachi “Flash Tha Kid” Mitchell. His baseball philosophy is to “play loud”—which didn’t always go over well in Florida’s youth-baseball scene.

I played in the same league as Larry Doby and Jackie Robinson, but it wasn’t,” he told me. “The caliber of ball was not the same.”

Howard said it’s always bothered him that so much storytelling about Black baseball is “rhetoric and lies.” Given the relative dearth of information about the game’s preintegration stars, the history of the Negro Leagues has long been full of tall tales—Josh Gibson hitting a home run so prodigious that the ball didn’t come down until the next day. In the midst of all this mythology, Howard believes, telling a true story can be a radical act.

When I asked Howard to describe himself as a player, he said that he was only “fair,” with quick feet, quick hands, and a good mind, but also a weak arm and warning-track power. I couldn’t help but think of Kobe Robinson and Nick Wilson, talented young players who didn’t quite have what it takes to make it all the way to the majors. Now they have the chance to keep playing the game they love.

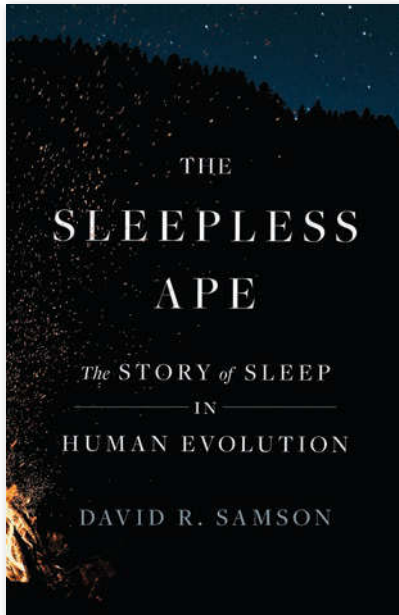
Whether the new Indianapolis Clowns succeed in bringing Black fans and athletes back to baseball may come down more to players like Robinson and Wilson than to Bob Kendrick and Jesse Cole. In Memphis, I watched the Clowns sign autographs for a predominantly white crowd. I also saw Wilson lean down to speak with a group of Black children, giving them time and attention and a different image of what a baseball player could look like. He was getting them while they’re young. *A*

Josh Levin is the author of The Queen: The Forgotten Life Behind an American Myth.



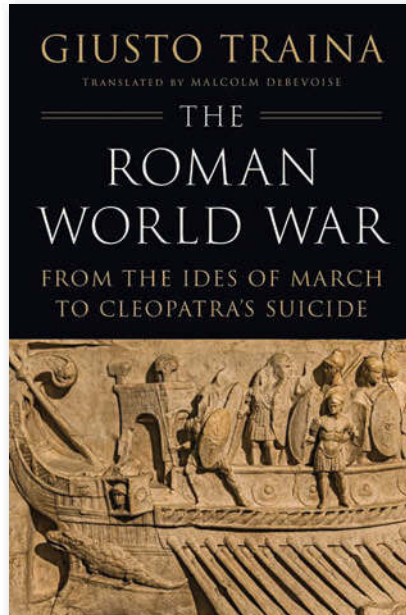
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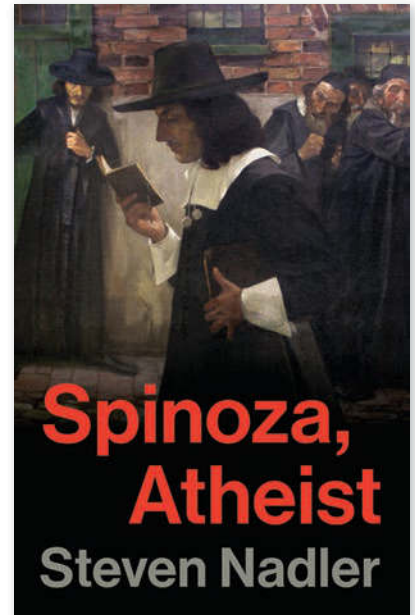
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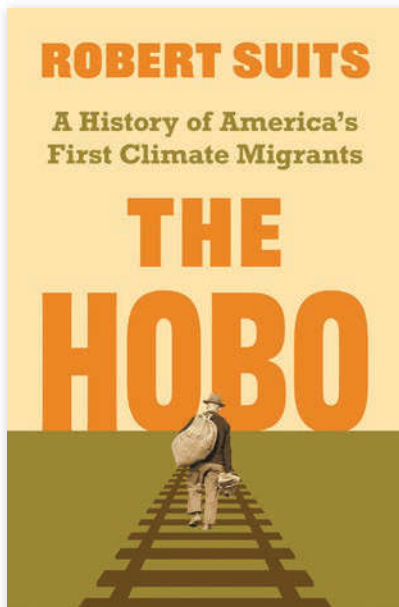
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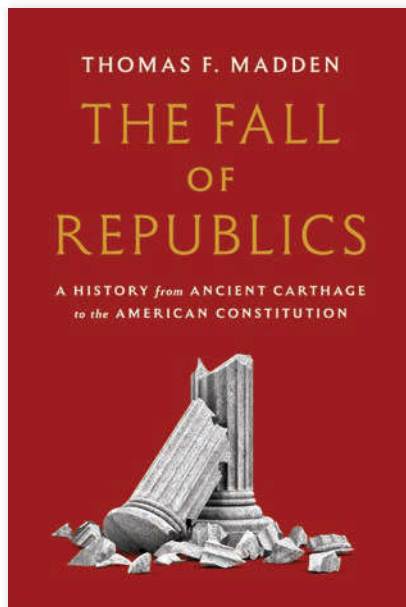
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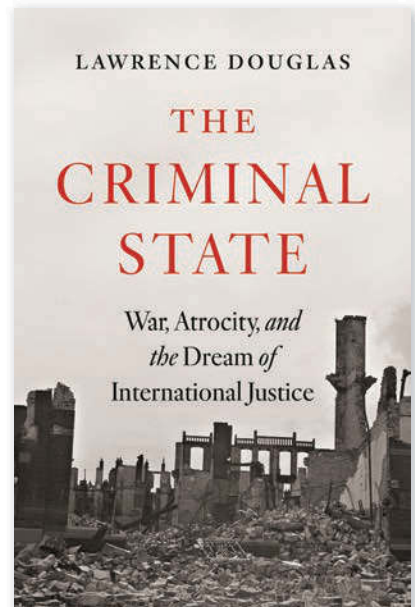
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Culture & Critics



Alien Nation

Why Americans want to believe that the government is hiding the truth about extraterrestrial life

By Adam Kirsch

“There has been a threat to publicly release government material long shrouded in secrecy.” This sentence could have been intoned by a TV newscaster anytime in the past few years, about any number of real or alleged cover-ups—of Joe Biden’s mental decline, or the names in the Epstein files, or the origins of COVID-19. In fact, it comes from the trailer that aired during the Super Bowl for *Disclosure Day*, Steven Spielberg’s new movie, opening June 12. For people who believe in aliens, or who would like to be able to believe in them, that title leaves no doubt about the kinds of secrets in question: *Disclosure* refers to the long-awaited moment when the U.S. government will admit what it really knows about visitors to our planet.

What form believers expect disclosure to take depends on what they think is being hidden. Perhaps the Pentagon will produce a spaceship or an alien corpse; according to one of the best-known UFO legends, both were retrieved from a crash site near Roswell, New Mexico, in 1947. Or the proof could be something less tangible—a clear image of a nonhuman craft in flight, a radio signal from an extraterrestrial civilization. However it happens, disclosure will finally reveal the truth—not just about aliens, but about the authorities that have been deceiving us for so long.

This isn’t a new theme for science fiction, or for Spielberg. His career as a director took off in a post-Watergate climate when Hollywood was obsessed with official conspiracies and heroic whistleblowers—think of Alan J. Pakula’s *All the President’s Men*, Sydney Pollack’s *Three Days of the Condor*, and Francis Ford Coppola’s *The Conversation*. Spielberg brought this suspicious, anti-establishment mood to his early blockbusters, starting in 1975 with *Jaws*, in which the mayor of a northeastern beach town tries to cover up a deadly shark attack.

But the perfect genre for a story about government lies was the UFO movie, as Spielberg showed with *Close Encounters of the Third Kind* in 1977. “All I wanna do is know what’s going on,” says Roy Neary, the working-class hero played by Richard Dreyfuss, after a brush with

Disclosure will finally reveal the truth—not just about aliens, but about the authorities that have been deceiving us for so long.

a UFO. Unfortunately, powerful forces are determined to keep him from finding out. The term *gaslighting* wasn’t as popular then as it is today, but every military and government official in the movie is engaged in exactly that—trying to convince Neary, and other ordinary people like him, not to trust their own eyes.

“Now, there are all kinds of ideas that would be fun to believe in—mental telepathy, time travel, immortality, even Santa Claus,” a condescending government spokesman says to a group of UFO witnesses. At the film’s climax, the Army invents a story about a chemical-weapons spill as an excuse for evacuating a swath of Wyoming where the aliens are expected to land. If they hadn’t finally shown themselves at the end of the movie—in a sky-filling, strobe-lit mother ship too awe-inspiring to conceal—there’s no doubt the U.S. government would have gone on hiding the truth forever.

That’s just what it tries to do in Spielberg’s next alien movie, *E.T. the Extra-Terrestrial*, from 1982. When the government learns that Elliott, a young boy, is hiding an adorable alien, his entire house is sealed off in a plastic tarp—a quarantine that also serves as a perfect concealment. When the boy and the alien manage to break out, they are pursued by agents with guns, escaping with the aid of a bicycle and the power of imagination.

The lesson of these movies is clear: Trust yourself, not the government. It’s a message deeply in the American grain, and science fiction has been amplifying it for decades. In the long-running TV series *The X-Files*, the FBI agents Mulder and Scully battle the “Syndicate,” a conspiracy at the highest levels of power to sell out the human race to alien invaders. The *Men in Black* movies play the idea for laughs, imagining a world where law enforcement keeps tabs on aliens living among us in disguise. The titular agents use a “neuralyzer” device to wipe the memory of anyone who stumbles upon the secret.

DISCLOSURE DAY promises a new kind of UFO story, in which government secrecy is defeated and the world



On the set of *Close Encounters of the Third Kind*, which came out in 1977



Elliott (Henry Thomas) and E.T. in *E.T. the Extra-Terrestrial* (1982)

finally learns the truth. Spielberg may be a half century older than when he made *Close Encounters*, but he clearly hasn't lost his power to read the mood of American culture. In the past decade, a profound shift has taken place in the way we talk and think about UFOs. To quote the title of a 2025 documentary on the subject, we are living in "The Age of Disclosure."

The most important sign of this change is that aliens have become respectable. It used to be that only supermarket tabloids such as the *National Enquirer* reported on UFO sightings; now they are seriously discussed in mainstream media and congressional hearings. Even the term *UFO* has fallen out of favor, tainted by its long association with crankery. Government officials and true believers alike now prefer to talk about UAP. At first the acronym stood for "unidentified aerial phenomena," but *aerial* was soon changed to *anomalous*, to include all kinds of "space, airborne, submerged, and transmedium objects." That is how UAP are defined in the mission statement of the All-Domain Anomaly Resolution Office, a government agency created in 2022 "to synchronize efforts across the Department of Defense, and with other U.S. federal departments and agencies, to detect, identify and attribute objects of interest."

Our age of disclosure was born on December 16, 2017, when *The New York Times* published an article headlined "Glowing Auras and 'Black Money': The Pentagon's Mysterious U.F.O. Program." The story revealed that, from 2007 to 2012, the Defense Department had allocated approximately \$22 million to the Advanced Aerospace Threat Identification Program (AATIP), a secret task force charged with investigating reports of flying objects that maneuver and accelerate in ways that ordinary aircraft cannot.

Such sightings aren't new. Americans have been noticing inexplicable things in the sky since World War II, when pilots over Germany reported being followed by glowing balls that they nicknamed "foo fighters." The term *unidentified flying object* was coined in the early 1950s to describe such phenomena in a neutral, noncommittal fashion. But of course, what made UFOs fascinating was the possibility that they could be extraterrestrial spacecraft.

In 1966, public concern about the issue prompted the Air Force to convene a panel of scientists to review UFO reports. The committee, headed by the physicist Edward Condon, bluntly concluded that such sightings were meaningless, blaming them on "inexperienced, inept, or unduly excited" observers who mistake ordinary sights like planets and balloons for flying saucers. "Nothing has come from the study of UFOs in the past 21 years that has added to scientific knowledge," the committee reported, and "further extensive study of UFOs probably cannot be justified."

That verdict led the U.S. military to stop officially taking notice of sightings, even by its own pilots. But the 2017 revelations about AATIP seemed to prove what advocates of disclosure had always maintained: Though the Pentagon publicly denied that it had any evidence of aliens, it actually knew they were real. In fact, it possessed videos of encounters between UAP and American military aircraft. The *Times* and other news outlets published several of these videos online—low-resolution black-and-white footage of what looked like a small blob zooming over the ocean.

All of this respectful attention drove a transformation in public opinion. In 1996, a *Newsweek* poll found that 20 percent of Americans believed that UFOs were "probably alien ships or alien life forms."

David Duchovny and Gillian Anderson in the *X-Files* movie (1998)Josh O'Connor and Emily Blunt in Steven Spielberg's *Disclosure Day*

When a YouGov poll asked the same question in 2022, that figure had increased to 34 percent. Even people who don't think aliens have been here are now much more likely to believe that they will be here soon. In 1996, 69 percent of Americans thought that humanity would not contact aliens in the next half century; by 2022, only 39 percent did.

No wonder politicians who would once have scoffed at UFOs began to see them as a winning issue. Disclosure has never seemed closer than it did on July 26, 2023, when the House Oversight Committee held an open hearing on UAP as a national-security threat. Witnesses with apparently unimpeachable credentials testified under oath that the U.S. military has been hiding its knowledge of UFOs for decades. David Fravor, a retired Navy pilot, said that in 2004, his fighter squadron encountered a "white Tic Tac object" in the sky off the coast of San Diego. The craft had "no rotors, no rotor wash, or any sign of visible control surfaces like wings," yet it was able to outrun fighter jets.

David Grusch, a former Air Force intelligence officer, made even more explosive claims. "I was informed in the course of my official duties of a multi-decade UAP-crash retrieval and reverse-engineering program" that operated in secret, "above congressional oversight," Grusch testified. In interviews with journalists, he was more explicit, saying that the U.S. government possessed both intact spacecraft and extraterrestrial bodies.

Last year's documentary *The Age of Disclosure* includes similar claims. Pilots talk about seeing objects with no wings or engines that seemed to defy the laws of physics, or at least the limits of human technology; Fravor mentions an oval-shaped object that could move at speeds of "32,000 miles an hour." The narrator of the

For all the attention paid to UFOs over the past decade, we still have no evidence that they exist.

film, Luis Elizondo—a former Army intelligence officer who worked on AATIP—talks about a Defense Department effort he calls the "Legacy Program," which has "been capturing, retrieving, and reverse engineering UAPs since at least 1947. On numerous occasions, these retrievals included the bodies of nonhumans."

These are exactly the kinds of admissions that disclosure was supposed to bring, and though the more outlandish claims were denied by the government and treated skeptically by the mainstream media, they couldn't be ignored—not when they were taken seriously by people such as Secretary of State Marco Rubio and former Director of National Intelligence James Clapper, both of whom appear in *The Age of Disclosure*. Who could blame UFO believers for thinking that the world was about to change in profound and disconcerting ways? "This is Disclosure. This is it Right Now," a Reddit user announced on r/UFOs, a forum with hundreds of thousands of weekly visitors, in the aftermath of the House hearings. "If you have loved ones, it may be a good idea to begin deciding how you will broach the subject, especially if they are dependents."

IN THE **DISCLOSURE DAY** TRAILER, one character asks what would happen "if you found we weren't alone. If someone showed you, proved it to you." But showing and proving are exactly what Elizondo and other self-styled whistleblowers have never been able to do. For all the attention paid to UFOs over the past decade, we still have no evidence that they exist. The public may be more willing to listen to claims about downed spaceships and alien life forms, but we haven't actually seen any. The murky Pentagon UFO videos have not been followed by clear pictures of

alien spacecraft, which could theoretically be taken by anyone with an iPhone.

The most parsimonious explanation for this failure is that there is nothing to disclose. But UFO believers are compelled to reject this idea, because the U.S. government is better equipped than any entity on Earth to detect the arrival of extraterrestrials. If they have been here, some kind of cover-up is a logical necessity. At least one person is certain enough to bet on it: In February, the prediction market Kalshi recorded two wagers, totaling almost \$300,000, that the U.S. government would announce the existence of aliens by the end of the year. Inevitably, the news prompted speculation that the bettor was a Trump-administration insider who knows that something big is coming.

Disclosure isn't just about logic, however. It is awaited with an almost religious fervor because it will give UFO believers the same kind of affirmation that the coming of the Messiah will give religious believers. Faith, the New Testament says, is the evidence of things not seen. But at the end of days, when God finally becomes visible, faith will give way to knowledge: "For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face." UFOs are not supposed to be supernatural; if they exist, they must obey the same laws of physics that reign here on Earth. But for now, they remain objects of faith because we have never been able to see one face-to-face. Disclosure will show that this faith was justified all along—that the believers were right and the skeptics wrong.

If this sounds a bit like a revenge fantasy, that's understandable. UFO belief, like traditional religion, tends to attract the scorn of what the Protestant theologian Friedrich Schleiermacher called "cultured despisers," people who consider themselves too sophisticated to fall for a popular error. How sweet it will be when disclosure proves that the experts and elites were wrong—worse, that they were actively suppressing the truth that nonexperts always knew was out there.

This dynamic of condescension and vindication has become central to American life over the past decade. It drives all kinds of populist causes: vaccine skepticism, the MAHA movement, Roswell-level conspiracy theories such as QAnon and Pizzagate. Every kind of "truther" makes a demand for disclosure—to stop hiding the truth about why the World Trade Center collapsed on 9/11, or where Barack Obama was born, or how Donald Trump's ear got bloodied in Butler, Pennsylvania.

It's tempting to dismiss these as fantasies born of ignorance and nourished by paranoia. And the cultured despisers are right, most of the time. There is no convincing evidence that the Earth has been visited by aliens, just as there is no convincing evidence that vaccines cause autism. And yet, the Pentagon really was

hiding videos of flying objects that could not be readily explained. Jeffrey Epstein really was friendly with royals and presidents. These things were disclosed only after years of public pressure from people who weren't content with the official story.

And when people are convinced that they know a secret, world-shaking truth, they are willing to wait a long time for vindication. This is another way in which UFO disclosure resembles the coming of the Messiah: Both are constantly running behind schedule.

In 1950, Donald E. Keyhoe, a pilot and fiction writer, published a book called *The Flying Saucers Are Real*, in which he argued that the government's apparent UFO denials were actually "part of an elaborate program to prepare the American people for a dramatic disclosure." After all, the news that there are aliens among us would likely have devastating consequences. People would panic about a possible invasion of the planet and turn against institutions that had been hiding the truth. Nations would compete to benefit from the newcomers and their technology, and religious authorities would have to rethink the foundations of their faith.

It makes sense that the custodians of such knowledge would want to release it little by little, to help humanity prepare for the shock. In fact, UFO believers have long speculated that Hollywood stories about aliens play a role in this acclimatization process. Some online theorists are already arguing that *Disclosure Day* itself is part of such a campaign: "Is this all just coincidence + perfect marketing timing for the movie? Or has someone been dropping clues?" one Redditor asked after the first trailer appeared.

Keyhoe promised that "the official explanation may be imminent." In 2024, Elizondo used virtually identical language in his book, *Imminent: Inside the Pentagon's Hunt for UFOs*, looking forward to "imminent government disclosure about nonhuman intelligence." Three-quarters of a century is a long time for disclosure to remain imminent. But if it proves once and for all that humanity is not alone in the universe, isn't it worth the wait? Religious believers have been waiting thousands of years for the apocalypse, the vision of the End Times described in the biblical books of Daniel and Revelation. *Apocalypse* and *disclosure* are, in fact, Greek and Latin ways of saying the same thing: Both refer to uncovering, the removal of concealment. And as long as we're convinced that some great, mysterious truth is being hidden, we don't have to confront an even more unsettling possibility—that there's nothing out there to believe in at all. *A*

When people are convinced that they know a secret, world-shaking truth, they are willing to wait a long time for vindication.

Adam Kirsch is a senior editor at The Atlantic. His new book, We Want to Believe: How Aliens Went Mainstream and Why It Matters, will be published in August.



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BOOKS

Glory Days

Heartland rock was shot through with nostalgia—but nostalgia for what?

By Jack Hamilton

What was heartland rock? Did anyone ever really know? No less an authority than John Mellencamp dismissed the term as the work of “lazy journalists.” But in the 1980s, the music’s heyday, the phrase denoted an array of artists and tendencies while also conjuring something more atmospheric. Everything about the sound was big: the guitars, the drums, the voices, the choruses tailor-made to be shouted along to at a stadium or at a wedding or in your car, nowadays probably to the embarrassment of your kids (or maybe grandkids). The bigness is in the blaring synthesizer riff that opens Bruce Springsteen’s 1984 smash “Born in the U.S.A.,” and the soaring refrain of Tom Petty’s 1989 classic “Free Fallin’,” and the pounding drums and crunching guitar that propel Mellencamp’s own 1982 chestnut “Hurts So Good.”

Heartland rock had a big heart, too. It was concerned with the lives of everyday people, building worlds so vivid that listeners effortlessly recognized themselves in them. Heartland rock's imagined community lies in both the quirky detail of chili dogs outside the Tastee Freez in Mellencamp's "Jack & Diane" and the more impressionistic evocations of bygone back-seat dalliances in Bob Seger's "Against the Wind."

The dominant mood was obsessive nostalgia: A remarkable amount of the music consists of grown men singing about teenagers. Tugging on the heart-strings can be a cheap trick in the hands of the wrong songwriter, but the genre's best songs are redeemed by a fastidious eye and a poetic ear. In Springsteen's "Born to Run," lovers, like fast cars, are "sprung from cages on Highway 9 / Chrome-wheeled, fuel-injected, and steppin' out over the line." Seger, in "Night Moves," evokes callow summer fumbblings in language that's decidedly unromantic: "I used her, she used me, but neither one cared / We were getting our share."

Heartland rock had a consistently left-leaning politics, although this aspect has long been a point of misunderstanding. "Born in the U.S.A." expresses a Vietnam veteran's disillusionment with the country that sent him to war and then abandoned him; the title refrain is meant to be ironic. Just a few months after the song's release, the conservative columnist George Will chose not to hear it that way, describing the chorus as a "grand, cheerful affirmation." Ronald Reagan praised the song's "message of hope" during a reelection-campaign stop in New Jersey. Reagan's people reportedly also wanted to turn Mellencamp's "Pink Houses" into a theme song. Mellencamp intended the song to address racial and economic inequality—its refrain, "Ain't that America," is at least partly sardonic.

Mellencamp quashed the Reagan camp's effort, but decades later such unauthorized uses keep occurring. In 2022, Petty's estate wrote a cease-and-desist letter to Kari Lake, who included his song "I Won't Back Down" in a video she posted on social media when she was refusing to concede the Arizona governor's race. Donald Trump, who rose to political prominence questioning the citizenship of Barack Obama, used "Born in the U.S.A." at rallies during his 2016 presidential run. The chorus of a song filled with indelible images of American decline—

Down in the shadow of the penitentiary
Out by the gas fires of the refinery
I'm 10 years burnin' down the road
Nowhere to run, ain't got nowhere to go

—was pressed into service to score nativist points.

In her new history, *Won't Back Down: Heartland Rock and the Fight for America*, the music journalist

*Heartland
rock reached
across the
ideological
spectrum in a
way that seems
unimaginable
today.*

Erin Osmon sets out to recover heartland rock's progressive potency, and to illuminate how the musicians behind the genre dedicated themselves to improving the lot of ordinary Americans. Although most heartland rockers emerged in the 1970s and flourished in the 1980s, they were deeply influenced by the legacy of the 1960s, inheriting from those years a romantic belief in rock and roll as a force for psychic and social transformation. In the second half of the decade, rock festivals such as Woodstock and Monterey came to be seen as movement happenings as much as musical ones, and stars including Bob Dylan and the Beatles were cast as generational spokespeople whether they liked it or not. When nearly half a million people descended on Bethel, New York, in August 1969, a lot of them earnestly believed that the music they listened to could be a key to a better future.

By the time that Springsteen burst into superstardom with the 1975 album *Born to Run*, that dream had mostly died, its demise brought about (depending on the telling) by the Rolling Stones' Altamont disaster, or the overdoses of Jimi Hendrix and Janis Joplin and Jim Morrison, or maybe just Led Zeppelin. This might explain why so much early coverage hailed the young Boss as a savior. "I saw rock and roll future and its name is Bruce Springsteen," the critic Jon Landau gushed after taking in a Springsteen show in 1974. (Shortly after writing those famous words, Landau put away his typewriter to co-produce *Born to Run*, ultimately becoming Springsteen's manager.) At the zenith of heartland rock's popularity, it maintained its connection to '60s-era utopianism, even as the country's rightward lurch imperiled such bleeding-heart optimism. (The dominant rock genre of the 1990s, grunge, would take a far more cynical view of the world.)

Heartland rockers were idealists, but they weren't radicals. They made big-tent music that sweet-talked more than it proselytized. It reached across the ideological spectrum in a way that seems unimaginable today, through both its sentimental songwriting and its small-*c*-conservative musical aesthetics: irresistible riffs, swelling choruses, unpretentious chord changes. Heartland rock, Osmon writes, was "the sound of a time when political disagreement didn't separate families and neighbors." That is probably an overstatement. Still, the music flourished on terrestrial radio and music-video television, two venues for mass musical experiences whose power has diminished drastically in the streaming era. The era of heartland rock was one of the last times when artists and audiences looked to enormously popular music as a vehicle for change. Osmon's book is a welcome opportunity to revisit that idea and perhaps take it more seriously.

OSMON'S CAST of characters sometimes sprawls to confounding breadth, but her linchpin figures are Springsteen, Mellencamp, Seger, and Petty. Springsteen's *Born to Run* is a foundational heartland-rock text, from its spectacularly cinematic opener, "Thunder Road," inviting us to go out riding "tonight to case the promised land," to its nine-and-a-half-minute closing track, the Jersey street epic "Jungleland." Seger's multi-platinum *Night Moves*, buoyed by its hit title song, came out in 1976. Tom Petty and the Heartbreakers' breakthrough was 1979's *Damn the Torpedoes*, which included the future classics "Refugee" and "Don't Do Me Like That." Mellencamp achieved megastardom in 1982 with *American Fool* and its singles "Jack & Diane" and "Hurts So Good."

Heartland rock tended to be more circumspect than the socially conscious pop of the previous decades. Certain heartland rockers—Mellencamp especially—did take on issues of race, but little in the music's canon approaches the righteous indignation of earlier anti-racist screeds, such as Neil Young's "Southern Man" and "Alabama," and the music's artists and audiences were overwhelmingly white. (An old joke has it that Clarence Clemons, the late saxophone player for Springsteen's E Street Band, was the only Black person who's ever attended a Springsteen concert.) Osmon notes that critics called the music *working-class rock* before *heartland rock* came into vogue; the terms are sometimes treated as interchangeable, but *heartland rock* is in much wider use. Maybe that's because the "working class" in these songs didn't really resemble the nation's actual working class: Heartland rock has a lot to say about white kids driving cars (or fooling around in the back seat of them), but not much about Black teenagers slinging burgers. And it wasn't always clear that the subjects of the songs were working-class at all. The protagonist of Seger's "Against the Wind" is pretty bummed out, but the song's line about his "deadlines and commitments" has always struck me as white-collar, and you'd be hard-pressed to find a line in "Jack & Diane" that says they're from the wrong side of the tracks.

For an exemplary heartland-rock anthem, one could do worse than the song that Osmon chose for her book's title, Petty's 1989 hit "I Won't Back Down." Its opening verses are carefully understated, set to a cozy bed of keyboard pads and churning rhythm guitar, but once we hit the chorus, the recording explodes. There are soaring layers of harmony vocals, a glistering 12-string-guitar part, driving drum fills that speed the song forward. And Petty's voice is direct and instantly unforgettable: "Hey, baby / There ain't no easy way out," he belts. "I will stand my ground / And I won't back down." As a fist-pumping paean to resolve, it's tough to beat.

But what is "I Won't Back Down" *about*? Damned if I know: The song is incredibly vague. The most detail that we get about the song's narrator is that he lives "in a world that keeps on pushin' me around." We could be listening to a left-wing protester standing up to the cops, or a small-government conservative raging against the bureaucratic nanny state, or a teenager arguing with his parents. Or maybe he's simply a guy whose girlfriend is trying to break up with him, and he's fighting to save the relationship—the "baby" that the chorus addresses certainly lends itself to this reading.

And yet the vagueness is part of what makes the song endure. Of course Kari Lake hears herself in "I Won't Back Down," because everyone does. Most great songs aren't great because of what they're about; they're great because of how they make us feel. Heartland rock had big sounds and sometimes big ideas, but what it really specialized in was big feelings.

NONE OF THIS diminishes the political commitments of the artists Osmon writes about, all of whom strove to live up to the ideals that their music gestured toward. The "fight for America" in the book's subtitle might mean sticking up for the fans—battling a record label to keep records inexpensive, as Petty did, and playing midsize markets so as to keep ticket and travel prices down, which Mellencamp insisted on. Springsteen became an advocate for veterans, Seger for autoworkers. Mellencamp simply refused all corporate sponsorships. Globe-spanning benefit concerts and blockbuster charity singles boomed in the '80s, and heartland-rock artists were fixtures at these affairs. In 1985 alone, Tom Petty and the Heartbreakers performed at Live Aid, Springsteen donated growly vocals to U.S.A. for Africa's "We Are the World," and Mellencamp co-founded Farm Aid, an annual music festival that continues to this day and has raised more than \$90 million.

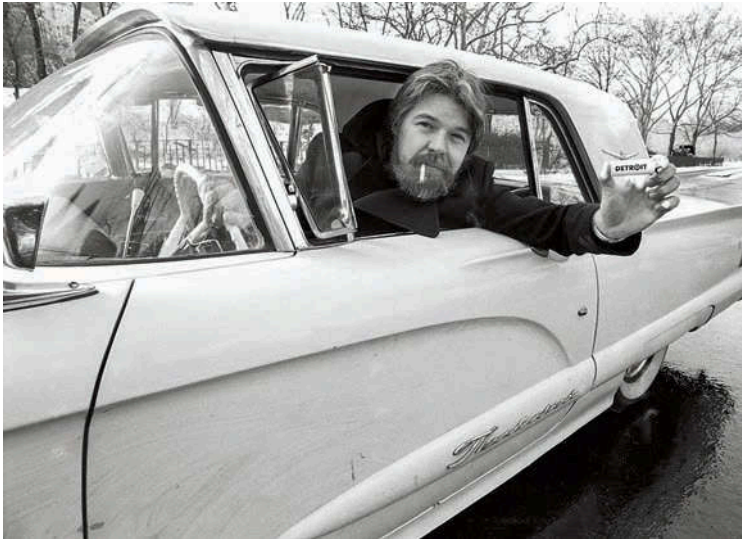
Osmon is particularly keen on resuscitating Seger, an artist who often gets short shrift in standard rock histories. A galvanic performer and graceful songwriter, Seger came out of Detroit in the late '60s as a purveyor of barn-burning blues rock. By the beginning of the 1980s, though, he'd found his greatest successes with country-inflected blue-eyed-soul ballads like "Night Moves" and "Against the Wind," as well as the prom staple "We've Got Tonite." In 1983, his 1978 recording "Old Time Rock and Roll" enjoyed a second life when it was featured in the underwear dance sequence in Tom Cruise's star-making hit, *Risky Business*, one of the great depictions of uncorked adolescence.

Seger's music also seems to have been less conducive to the sort of right-wing political co-optation

WON'T
BACK DOWN:
HEARTLAND
ROCK AND
THE FIGHT
FOR AMERICA

Erin Osmon

NORTON



Above: Bob Seger in a Ford Thunderbird in 1982, the year his tribute to autoworkers, “Makin’ Thunderbirds,” came out. *Below:* Tom Petty in Los Angeles circa 1988. He blended punk, new wave, and psychedelia into his heartland sound.



that has persistently befallen Springsteen’s, Petty’s, and Mellencamp’s work. The willful mishearing of “Born in the U.S.A.,” “Pink Houses,” and other songs might partly be attributed to their sound: The bellowed choruses and clattering power chords sometimes drown out a finer-tuned political message. Heartland rock’s penchant for nostalgia might also play a role. The music’s evocation of simpler times when men were men, teenage girls were both innocent and horny, and cars were made in Michigan has a natural appeal for the MAGA movement.

And sometimes the music does traffic in the kinds of clichés about middle-American purity of spirit that have long been a hallmark of conservative rhetoric. Whatever the staunchly liberal Mellencamp intended to convey in songs such as “Pink Houses” and “Small Town,” the ambiguity of the writing makes them ripe for misuse. Osmon points out that Mellencamp’s music has recently been covered by right-leaning country artists, including Trump supporters such as Jason Aldean and Luke Bryan.

Still, the pinnacles of the heartland-rock canon continue to thrill us in unexpected ways. Petty died in 2017, leaving behind a body of music so rich and distinctive that it overflows a genre history like Osmon’s. His early work with the Heartbreakers had an affinity with the more cutting-edge sounds of punk and new wave; the term *pop punk* probably comes from the *New York Times* critic John Rockwell’s write-up of a Petty performance at the Bottom Line in 1977. In the ’80s, Petty’s music was certainly classified as heartland rock but was far more influenced by the dreamy psychedelia of the Beatles and the Byrds than most other music in the genre.

Through it all, he wrote incredible songs. His 1976 recording “American Girl” is undergoing a revival, thanks to a heart-racing needle drop at the end of Paul Thomas Anderson’s *One Battle After Another*, where it breathes its 50-year-old energy into a new image of teenage exhilaration and political rebellion. The first time I saw Anderson’s film in the theater and that chiming, buzzing guitar riff began pouring out of the speakers, I almost couldn’t believe my ears: It was such an audacious choice, and a perfect one. Maybe “American Girl” is heartland rock, maybe it’s pop punk, or maybe it’s just rock and roll. Or maybe it’s all of those things and still defies categorization, as the best American music always has. *A*

Jack Hamilton is an associate professor of American studies and media studies at the University of Virginia. He is the author of Just Around Midnight: Rock and Roll and the Racial Imagination.



BOOKS

The Secret of Elizabeth Strout's Appeal

How she writes best sellers that are also critical darlings

By Adam Begley

How does she do it? Not just the neat trick of beguiling highbrow critics while at the same time pleasing millions of readers who don't care about literary bona fides. The real feat is harpooning the reader artlessly (or so it seems), with language as plain as a Congregational church, a paucity of dramatic incident, and a cast of characters no more exotic than your neighbors. They aren't exotic, her characters, but they're quirky—some cantankerous, some bafflingly passive, all convincingly real. Thinking about them, I keep coming back to the bedrock of her work, what she has called “the singularity and mystery of each person.” She shows us how strange we are, and how similar (an insight verging on homily but thankfully sugar-free). She's not a minimalist, but Elizabeth Strout does more with less than any writer I can think of.

Her 11th novel, *The Things We Never Say*, is classic Strout (New England setting, unhappy marriages, family secrets, lots of what mental-health professionals call “suicidal ideation”); her legion of fans is bound to propel it to the top of the best-seller lists. And this time, there's an urgent topical element: The story begins in the summer of 2024—not in Maine, where Strout grew up, her go-to fictional territory, but rather in an unnamed seaside town in Massachusetts—and Donald Trump (whose name is one of the things never said) is about to be elected president for the second time. Strout's hero, Artie Dam, is a high-school history teacher, so it comes as no surprise when he eventually writes the word FASCISM on the blackboard.

Artie grew up poor, married rich, worked hard, and now is grateful for his settled, comfortable life (“He was, in many ways, the embodiment of the American dream”). Instinctively humble, he insists on egalitarian ethics, telling his class, “Do not *ever* feel that you are superior to someone else.” You want to like Artie—and when you find out that his placid, often-jovial exterior conceals a troubled inner life, you want to know him better (even though his closest friend admits to herself that he's “almost dopey”).

He suffers from the most common ailment in Strout's world—loneliness. The eponymous main character in *Olive Kitteridge*, which won a Pulitzer Prize in 2009,

knows “that loneliness can kill people.” She tells a man who doesn’t want to die alone: “We’re always alone. Born alone. Die alone. What difference does it make?” (The sentences enact isolation.) In *My Name Is Lucy Barton* (2016), Lucy confesses, “Lonely was the first flavor I had tasted.”

Artie’s brand of loneliness is specified in the novel’s epigraph, from Carl Jung; it comes from “being unable to communicate the things that seem important to oneself.” His grown-up son has been a little distant lately, but his students call him “Damn-dam, the greatest man,” and his colleagues like and respect him. Still, Artie is lonely; the flow of thought and feeling finds no outlet. He goes to a cocktail party with his wife; on the way home, he wonders why “people never say anything real,” and as he hangs their coats in the closet, he feels “a dismalness return to him.”

On page 16 we learn his “secret” answer to his condition: “For more than two months, he had been thinking how to kill himself without his wife or son (or students) knowing that he had done so.” Considerate even as he plots self-slaughter, Artie decides that drowning is the way to go. His sailboat is moored in the bay. A boating accident might be staged. But then a boating accident very nearly does kill him (he slips when stepping from dinghy to boat). The water in the cove is frigid—“so cold he felt as though he had been dropped into a test tube of acid.” As the current sweeps him away from shore, Artie understands that he won’t last long.

Strout has set the scene with a comically banal metaphor: “The sky was once again a terrific blue; white clouds rolled past, puffy-looking like enormous cotton balls.” Now, unable to swim against the current, his boots full of icy water, his sodden sweater and coat weighing him down, Artie stares up at the sky. “Oh, it was beautiful! White clouds moved far above him, momentarily blocking the sun, and then the sun came out again.” Stripped of ornament, the goofy simile gone, the radically spare sequence of sun-clouds-sun matches the seesaw of emotion visited upon the reader—lovely day, mortal fear, sudden hope when rescue arrives. After the tension, release. “It was that quiet and that simple, but Artie—having almost died—no longer wanted to.”

BECAUSE WE nearly lose him (less than a quarter of the way through the novel), Artie is now that friend we hug close and watch over nervously. Fear of spoilers prevents me from saying why, but Artie’s troubles (mostly centered on his wife, who thinks he’s “soft,” and his son, whose marital woes may or may not explain his hangdog look) have not blown away like cotton-ball clouds. Soon Artie feels as cut off as he did before the near-death drenching.

Which could be why, at age 57, he starts shoplifting, taking first a cheap plastic comb from a

drugstore. Then comes a remarkable episode in a shop three towns away from where he lives.

Strout’s scene-setting is brilliantly terse and precise: “A little bell tinkled as Artie stepped over the threshold of the men’s carpeted clothing store. There was almost a sense of stepping inside a small church, it was that quiet.” The peculiar placement of “carpeted” and the hesitant, almost-apologetic church metaphor do plenty of work, reflecting Artie’s confusion, echoing his voice, invoking traditional morality, and pretending with the colloquial phrasing that nothing literary is happening on the page.

Artie buys a shirt and then tries to steal two dress shirts (impossible, by the way, to imagine him actually wanting to wear them). “What am I doing?” he thinks, feeling “bizarrely far away.” Strout gives the tinkling bell she started with a sinister echo: “As he stepped through the shop’s front door, a loud buzzer went off, and Artie experienced both an immediate terror and bewilderment.” He’s been caught, a blaring indictment spoiling the holy hush.

A wrenching swerve here, I know, but I want to revisit the hilarious shoplifting scene near the beginning of Jonathan Franzen’s *The Corrections* (2001). Chip Lambert steals a filet of line-caught Norwegian salmon from a Manhattan food emporium Franzen calls “the Nightmare” (though it’s obviously Dean & DeLuca). The scene is a flamboyant satire of turn-of-millennium yuppiedom:

A humidity had stolen over the sky, a sulfurous uneasy wind from Rahway and Bayonne. The supergentry of SoHo and Tribeca were streaming through the Nightmare’s brushed-steel portals. The men came in various shapes and sizes, but all the women were slim and thirty-six; many were both slim and pregnant.

Chip has no way of paying the \$78.40 that the filet costs. When he tucks it under his sweater, it slips down into his pants: “The dangling filet felt like a cool, loaded diaper.” Later it spreads into his underpants “like a wide, warm slug.” The Nightmare is hellish (that sulfurous wind) and stealing from it hardly seems sinful; the thief’s only discomfort is physical, and Franzen plays it for laughs.

Shoplifting is a crime against capitalism, an insult to consumerism, the pursuit of happiness perverted. Ostentatious, almost boastful, Franzen amplifies the socioeconomic implications. Strout—subtle, almost furtive—mutes them. But both highlight the character’s desperation. Chip is beyond broke and generally in a bad way. A purloined salmon filet covering the groin “like a codpiece” is a low point for him (and reminds us of his priapic obsessions), but he gets away with it—zero remorse—and that’s somehow exactly

Her latest protagonist suffers from the most common ailment in Strout’s world—loneliness.

right. Unashamed, unpunished, he'll regale dinner guests with the story and get a laugh.

Strout, meanwhile, looks inward, deep into Artie, who's mortified, profoundly shaken. Once the shock has worn off, he sees his behavior as an alarming symptom—has he had a stroke?

Diametrically opposed in temperament, Strout and Franzen do have something in common: They've both had books chosen for Oprah's Book Club. Whereas Strout was a gracious and grateful beneficiary of the "Oprah effect," Franzen famously made disobliging comments about some previous picks—"schmaltzy, one-dimensional," he called them.

IS STROUT one-dimensional? Though quiet (the clang of current events mostly muffled), her novels are complex and layered. She's a keen dissector of American class structure. Whether she's schmaltzy is trickier. More interested in virtue than vice, she likes to show what appears to be vice vanquished by the revelation of hidden virtue. Are you a schmaltzy writer if you shy away from depicting evil, if your baddies turn out to be merely misguided?

The Burgess Boys (2013) revolves around what seems to be an act of evil. In a small town in Maine coping with a substantial influx of Somali immigrants, Zach (the Burgess brothers' teenage nephew) throws a frozen pig's head through the door of a storefront mosque—during Ramadan.

As usual when a public issue is at stake, Strout makes it personal. She channels her character Abdikarim, a café owner homesick for Mogadishu, to show the pain and fear inflicted by this desecration, and she also gradually reveals what motivated Zach, who eventually sees the gravity of his "dumb joke." His regret shades into genuine contrition. Moreover, Abdikarim manages to forgive Zach, whom he understands is no more than a frightened child.

Strout sympathizes with the Somali immigrants. Her protagonist, Bob Burgess, laments "the terrible, terrible stuff they've been through" (and also acknowledges the difficulties that communities face in integrating and assimilating people from a very foreign culture). She despises bigotry and racism—the whole gamut, from the townsfolk who know better but insist on calling the new arrivals "Somalians" to the neo-Nazi white supremacists who make a cameo and call them "parasites." As anyone who's read any of her work can testify, Strout champions tolerance. Her tender heart is clearly center-left.

But to call her tenderhearted would be wrong. Angry, blunt, brittle, occasionally cruel (and especially intolerant of "meek-and-mousy-looking people"), Olive Kitteridge, in many ways the quintessential Strout character, is nobody's idea of a liberal snowflake. She's no

conservative, either. Her disdain for George W. Bush (whose name, like Trump's, is never mentioned) affects her physically: "She couldn't stand to look at the president's face: His close-set eyes, the jut of his chin, the sight offended her viscerally." Nor is she woke, or rather (to avoid anachronism), politically correct: "Here was a man who looked retarded," she thinks. "You could see it in his stupid little eyes."

The tender side of Strout is her hopefulness—and that may be toughening up. In *The Burgess Boys*, *Olive Kitteridge*, and other early books, Strout seemed confident that good would eventually prevail, or at least persist. She never did happy endings, but in general her characters coped or grew or showed remorse; they endured, and the reader cheered them on.

LONELINESS ISN'T Artie's sole affliction. He's deeply disturbed by the temper of the times. The upcoming presidential election makes him feel "as if a noose was tightening each day around his neck." His wife calls him a "doomsayer." And indeed, he thinks his country will "never be the same, not in his lifetime." When he teaches the Civil War to 11th graders, he assigns each student a soldier or nurse from Massachusetts to research. The principal calls him in and tells him some parents have demanded that he also assign "the Confederate side." Dismayed, the principal apologizes: "This forcing you to take on Confederate soldiers, I'm sorry. This is what anticipatory obedience is." Artie complies, yet sticks to a core principle. "In all my years of teaching," he says when asked in class whom he'll vote for, "I have never made my political views available to my students." The reader is in no doubt.

Olive Kitteridge, a recurring character who gets a nod in the new novel, allows Strout to explore how to be a good person when you're not, in fact, a particularly good person. With Artie, she shows how a good person fares in the age of Trump, when dismalness is an ever more common complaint and her characters' sins of omission snowball into big, consequential lies; the moral slippage is both personal and political, domestic and national.

Always eager to exploit tension among her characters, Strout sets up a contrast between the meals Artie shares with two friends. One is Kenneth Moynihan, the man who saved Artie when he nearly drowned; the other is Anne Merrill, a colleague who teaches English at the high school and has been "a little bit in love with him" for years. Making canny but sparing use of fiction's superpower—interiority—Strout lets seemingly trivial interactions give rise to unexpected emotions.

With Ken, Artie opens up easily: "Boy, I talk a lot with you. I just yak away." When he tells him a momentous secret he's shared with no one else, Ken

THE THINGS WE
NEVER SAY

Elizabeth Strout

RANDOM HOUSE

feels privileged to be his confidant. They talk about their children, their parents, “how deeply upset people were these days,” the mess in the Middle East. Tucked between parentheses is the exception: “(They did not talk about the upcoming election in their own country.)” It later emerges that Ken may be a supporter of the unnamed Trump, but Artie doesn’t let that trouble him. The easy connection between the two men—Ken reaches out, touches Artie’s hand, and even says, though self-consciously, “Thank you for sharing”—is just a little mawkish.

A painfully awkward lunch with Anne swings the pendulum the other way. Here, Artie is incapable of telling his old friend anything, and when she tries to confide in him, his reaction disappoints. Both are baffled by the disconnect. Later, he realizes that what he fails to tell her shields her, and him, from having to acknowledge a chain of betrayals. Because he doesn’t open up to her, the best they can do is shake their heads in tandem over the topic du jour: “The election, Jesus,” she says. He answers, “I know, Anne. I know.”

Strout questions the conventional wisdom of our combative times by suggesting that partisan agreement doesn’t always bring us together, and that the partisan divide doesn’t always divide. A refreshing perspective—but how wearying, how unsettling, to be unsure even of our friends’ loyalties. Artie’s emotional range shrinks as the book draws to a close. In the epilogue, he says repeatedly that he’s tired. He’s tired of the lies he’s lived with; tired of the ambient anger; tired of the daily shocks administered by the new president. “On and on it went. Artie watched all these things, and he slowly understood that what he had felt the day of the election was true: His country was committing suicide.”

The Things We Never Say ... and yet, in two unmistakably political paragraphs in the novel’s epilogue, Strout makes a point of *saying*. She compiles a record of Artie’s distress during the first year of the new administration (deportations, arrests of student protesters, “Alligator Alcatraz”—he’s serially appalled). I suppose it could be mistaken for an anti-Trump rant: She certainly lets us know where she stands. Yet she’s neither preaching to the converted nor attempting to convince the misguided. Artie’s distress could be common ground, or not.

Lucy Barton—another writer, a stand-in for Strout—learned when she was very young that books soothed her sense of isolation. Lucy found her calling thanks to a rush of fellow feeling: “I will write and people will not feel so alone!” *A*

Adam Begley is the author of several biographies, including Updike. His book about Harvard College will be published in the spring of 2027.

Ten Thousand Things Arising By Jenny Xie

Not even *if* is a wildfire in close enough range.

Not even the present is within breath.

For years the answers came, the same

answer, or not the same at all,

spotted in a different tongue, then none at all.

The soft filling of the future tense

that would not fit into a grid, one I could name.

And right in the midpoint of what I thought was mid-

life, a new character padded onto the page.

Who traveled from the long after.

Leaking the afterlife.

And all that year, I couldn’t read, knowing language

could be directional, drawing close. Moving away.

But the character was recurring, then the main figure.

His mouth loaded, the *bababa*.

Between his diaphragm and hard palate:

phonic vibration and smear.

Strained visage behind my 37th year.

And how did we get here—you and I, I mean.

My child whose modifiers I tend and prune on the screen.

You were a no and then one

of ten thousand things arising in the mind’s snow.

Stay, you bid me, *stay*.

And from that point on there was no question laid

and there I was, now dragged by

the endless itching

of the clock’s hands, around and around

the now, now, now.

Was there ever a chase?

It’s getting late.

I shiver, touching you

here on the page.

Jenny Xie is the author of Eye Level and The Rupture Tense. She teaches at Bard College.

BOOKS

How America Celebrated Its 100th Birthday

The Centennial Exhibition of 1876 promised a glorious industrial future. Outside its gates, the country seethed with violence and corruption.

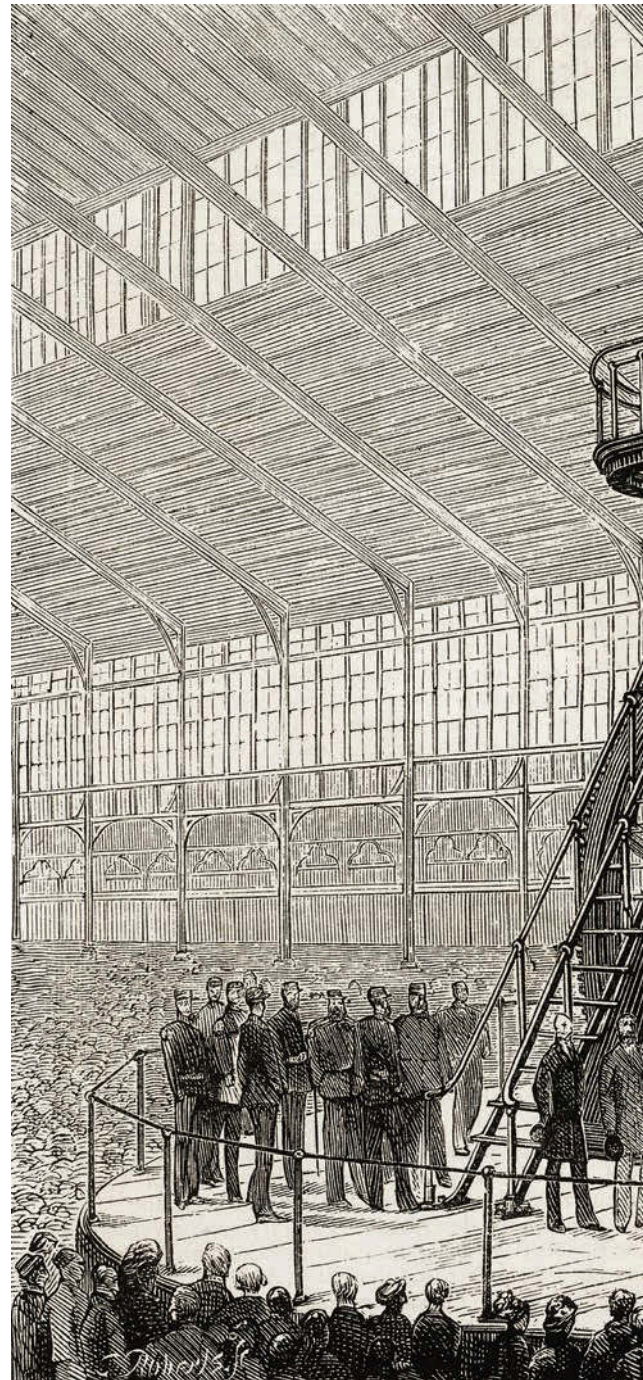
By Jake Lundberg

William Dean Howells, the editor of *The Atlantic*, wandered through Philadelphia's Centennial Exhibition of 1876 trying to make sense of a spectacle that defied description. Two wheels, one small, one large, seemed to tell the story of the great transformation on display. The small one was made of wood—an old spinning wheel set up in a rude log cabin meant to conjure colonial Plymouth. As Howells related, a reenactor playing the Mayflower pilgrim Priscilla Alden paused in her work to give an old Quaker woman a turn. At first, the woman's "long-unwonted fingers" seemed rusty. She struggled to splice the thread, then got it tangled while Howells and others watched in breathless silence. Finally, though, her dexterity revived, and the wheel came to life "with a soft triumphant burr, while the crowd heaved a sigh of relief." It was, Howells reflected, "altogether the prettiest thing I saw at the Centennial."

But Howells and millions of other Americans went to Philadelphia as much to look forward as to look back. Far more thrilling than the wooden spinning wheel was the huge cast-iron wheel—30 feet in diameter and 122,000 pounds—turning almost noiselessly at the center of the complex works of the Corliss Engine in Machinery Hall, driven by steam pumped in from a separate building. Howells sat, stunned, before the engine's "infinitely varied machinery" working "with unerring intelligence." No Priscilla Alden or old Quaker was necessary here—just a single, mostly idle attendant whose only job was to occasionally put down his newspaper and administer a few drops of oil.

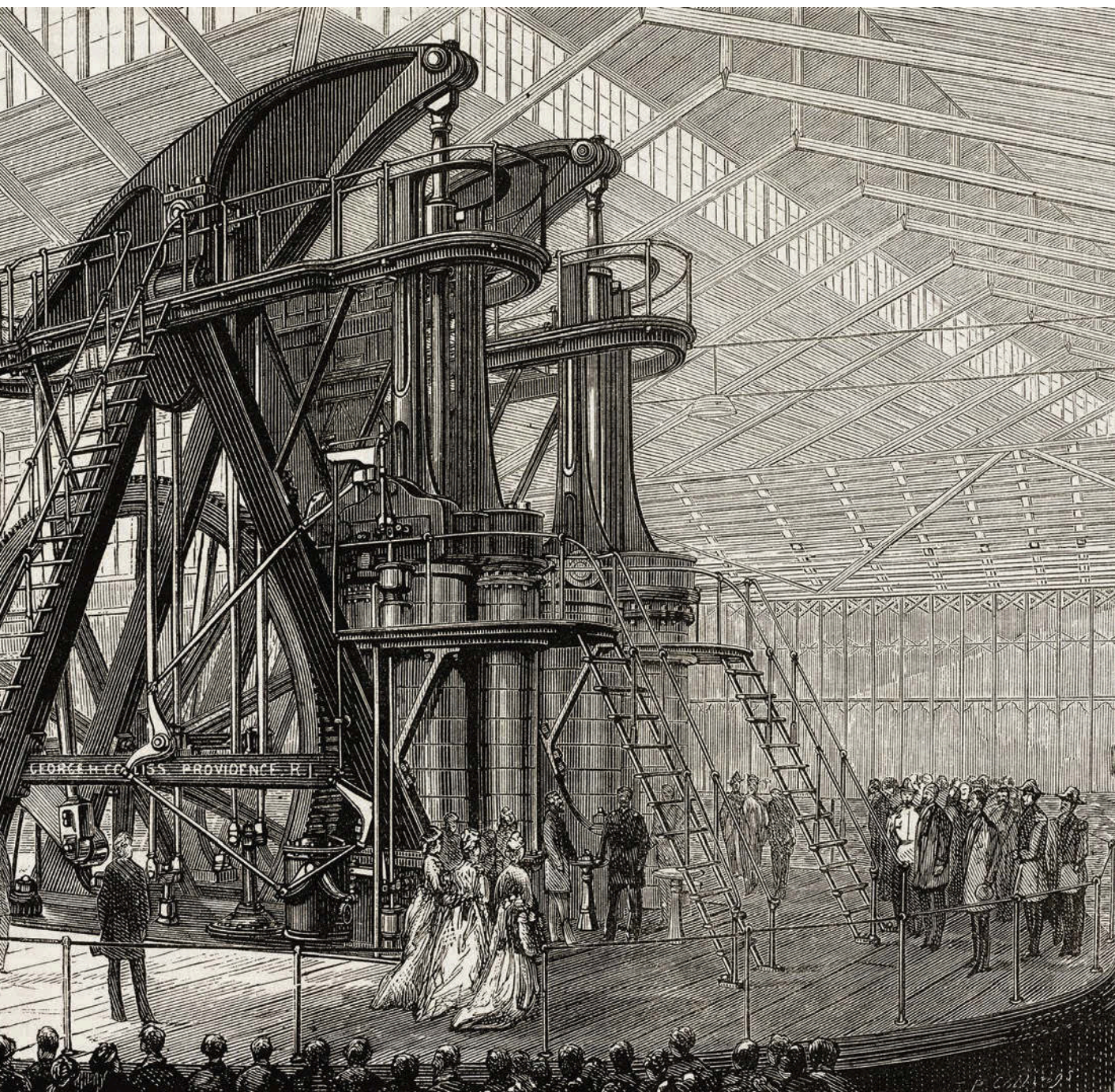
In *Centennial: The Great Fair of 1876 and the Invention of America's Future*, the historian Fergus M. Bordewich takes a tour of the exhibition—and, venturing beyond it, takes the measure of America on its 100th birthday. At not quite 200 pages of text, the book is brisk and tightly constructed, filled with vivid characters and finely wrought, often-wrenching scenes. Along the way, Bordewich finds a country caught between the marvel of its material progress—what he calls a "phantasmagorical

When the centennial in Philadelphia closed, about 20 percent of the U.S. population had visited, including a 79-year-old man who walked from Indiana.



theater of national glory"—and the fragility of its ideals and institutions. While the fair celebrated a confident industrial future, the nation outside its gates seethed with violence, corruption, and social inequality.

Writing in our own anniversary moment, when historical narratives are themselves the stuff of cultural and political conflict, Bordewich largely lets the discord speak for itself. But taken together, the dizzying disorientations of 1876 can't help fueling grim conclusions. Bordewich, who has written forceful histories of the Underground Railroad, the radicalism of



the Republican Congress during the Civil War, and Reconstruction-era Ku Klux Klan violence, presents a country turning its back on two revolutions—those of 1776 and 1865. In their place, Americans embraced a third: an industrial revolution that rendered the spinning wheel a quaint relic of the past and the iron wheel an object of faith for the future.

THE CENTENNIAL commenced on the morning of May 10, 1876, with a seemingly providential break in the rain. The program—which included lengthy

An 1876 etching of President Ulysses S. Grant and Emperor Dom Pedro II of Brazil starting the Corliss Engine in the Centennial Exhibition's Machinery Hall

speeches on the marvels of American growth, and an orchestra playing an array of national anthems from around the world in addition to Richard Wagner's made-to-order "American Centennial March"—had swelled to fit the exhibition's hybrid nature. What had originally been intended as a national birthday celebration had been joined to a World's Fair displaying the material wonders of the Industrial Age. The ensuing event, which ran for the next six months, was designed to show how happily material progress and national glory could be made to blend. Financed

through a mix of public and private money and enabled in no small part by the backroom maneuvering of the Pennsylvania Railroad boss Thomas Scott—whose lines stood to benefit from the traffic—it was a perfect Gilded Age confection.

The massive glass-and-iron main building was the largest man-made structure on the planet at the time, encompassing more than 21 acres of floor space. It was just one of some 200 buildings across the site, many of them sparkling architectural showpieces dedicated to, among other things, pomology, photography, brewing, dairy processing, and glassmaking. Nations and states commissioned their own buildings—a Tudor mansion for England, a residence and “bazaar” for Japan, a “cottage” for Connecticut, a Spanish-moss-fringed log cabin for Mississippi. Fairgoers could see some of the first mechanical typewriters in action, sample Charles E. Hires’s root beer, hear the ear-splitting “annunciator” of Western Electric’s new heat-sensitive fire alarm.

When the exhibition closed in November, at least 9,799,392 people—about 20 percent of the U.S. population—had visited, including a 79-year-old man who *walked* from New Albany, Indiana, with the aid of a stick cut and carved in the 1810s. Most of those who went were delightfully overwhelmed. In a letter home, a young woman from Providence, Rhode Island, struggled to find words for what she saw: “Dear Mother, Oh! Oh!! Oh!!! Oh!!!! Oh!!!!! O-o-o-o o-o-o-h!!!!!! Your affectionate daughter, Mary.” Even Alexander Graham Bell, whose newly invented telephone was one of the fair’s sensations, said that it was all “so prodigious and wonderful that it absolutely staggers one.”

BEHIND THE UNSPEAKABLE WONDERS of Machinery Hall stood a world of labor—dirty, dangerous, and low-paid—that constituted a grave threat to the values of the republic. Such toil clashed with Jeffersonian ideals that equated independent proprietorship of farms and shops with the moral virtue necessary for honest citizenship. Just before the Civil War, Abraham Lincoln had said that men performing wage labor for more than a short stint suffered from “either a dependent nature which prefers it, or improvidence, folly, or singular misfortune.”

By 1876, industrial wage labor was the permanent misfortune of a growing class of people. Their absence from the spectacle in Machinery Hall was telling. The ingenuity of those who’d designed and displayed the machines fit easily on the trajectory of national greatness; the drudgery of those who did the grunt work off-site did not. The old ethos that Lincoln had believed in still had enough purchase that workers themselves bore the blame for their own miseries. “Had an unfortunate accident this morning,” a Pittsburgh plant manager

working for Andrew Carnegie reported (one of Bordewich’s many well-chosen quotes).

Rope on cupola hoist broke and cage fell catching the Hoist Boy in the act of crossing under, crushing him to a jelly. It was caused by the boy’s carelessness, and disobedience of order and the poor fellow paid the penalty with his life. Delayed works slightly.

Events unfolding that summer in Pennsylvania coal country, about 100 miles away from the exhibition, showed how little hope there was to at least improve working conditions through unions and other forms of labor organizing. As Bordewich narrates in an astonishing set piece, the Philadelphia and Reading Coal and Iron Company had seen to that. When it sought retribution against Irish miners who had gone on strike the previous year, it didn’t merely have the backing of public authority in Schuylkill County; it *was* the public authority. With the help of a private police force, the company’s president took on the powers of a district attorney and personally prosecuted a set of cases against the miners, most of whom were labor activists. In a series of show trials, the men were charged with murder and assorted acts of terror, and 20 were sent to the gallows.

If industrial workers were largely absent from the centennial, Bordewich shows how Native Americans turned into a different kind of disappearing act. Assumed for decades to be “vanishing” before the tide of Anglo-American civilization, they had become objects of ethnological interest, their “primitive” cultures underscoring the marvels of the present age. Taking the lead on the event’s many Native American exhibits, the Smithsonian’s director, Joseph Henry, first planned to stage a living display of several hundred Native Americans—a Museum of Natural History diorama brought to life. But ongoing hostilities in the West got in the way. Instead, Henry sent expeditions to gather as many Native American artifacts as possible, in order to “present savage life and conditions in all grades and places.” For fairgoers, the juxtaposition with mechanical developments was powerful.

Beyond the exhibition, of course, the “vanishing” of Native Americans was not an abstraction but a policy. Writing on “the Indian question” in 1873, Commissioner of Indian Affairs Francis A. Walker had asked, “What shall be done with the Indian as an obstacle to the national progress?” The answer, he hoped, would involve peaceful means, albeit with extant Western Indians coerced onto reservations, where they would be subject to a “rigid reformatory control” while learning to adopt Anglo-American culture and practices. More often, the putative “Peace Policy” devolved into war, as was the case with the American campaign against the Lakotas happening during the centennial.

CENTENNIAL:
THE GREAT
FAIR OF 1876
AND THE
INVENTION
OF AMERICA'S
FUTURE

*Fergus M.
Bordewich*

ALFRED A. KNOPP

That campaign—provoked by America’s violation of an existing treaty after the discovery of gold in the Black Hills—produced a great shock at the fair. Just three days after the triumphant Fourth of July celebrations in Philadelphia, news arrived that the Lakotas had routed American forces under the command of General George Armstrong Custer near the Little Bighorn River, in the Montana territory. Custer, who was killed along with more than 260 of his men, had confidently predicted that “civilization in its advancing tread” would “roll mercilessly over” the Plains Indians. Only weeks before, he’d been at the centennial—to take in the wonders of civilization in its advancing tread.

FOR BLACK AMERICANS, the centennial posed a pressing question: What place would they have in the national future it claimed to celebrate? Some, such as Representative Josiah Walls of Florida, anticipated that the fair would blot out “all questions of minor differences and all hurtful recollections of past disagreements.” Walls was mostly right, just not in the way he hoped. Bordewich describes how, at a moment when political support for Reconstruction was ebbing, the exhibition staged a reconciliation not between races, but between regions. White northerners and white southerners restored their old bonds of friendship through symbolic gestures—Union and Confederate generals seated together; a relative of Robert E. Lee reading the Declaration of Independence on the Fourth of July.

Still, claiming their place in both the exhibition and the nation at large remained a goal of Black Americans. Members of the African Methodist Episcopal Church commissioned a monument to Richard Allen, a prominent Black Philadelphian of the early republic and the founder of the denomination. “We intend to leave Philadelphia in 1876 as did the heroes in 1776, with a fixed resolve to achieve noble results,” the group announced. “And in 1976, we expect our progeny to

gather around the Monument in question, shed tears of gratitude for the example we have left them, and call us blessed.” Delayed first by a missed deadline and then by a train accident, the monument was installed just a week before the exhibition closed.

In Allen’s absence, the most prominent “memorialization” for Black Americans was a restaurant, not a monument or a pavilion. When a white Atlanta businessman proposed to open a “Restaurant of the South,” centennial commissioners welcomed the prospect. The waitstaff would be among the only Black employees on the fairgrounds (Black workers were mostly excluded from the centennial), and their job would include playing enslaved people on a plantation, singing “quaint melodies,” and strumming the banjo. Northern fetishization of southern slavery was nothing new; the minstrel show had become popular in northern cities in the decades before the Civil War. But the success of the restaurant and its apparent nostalgia for slavery seemed to complete a notable shift in national sentiment since Appomattox.

Many northerners (Republicans, at least) had linked Black freedom to national progress immediately after the Civil War. That connection had all but faded by 1876, amid violent campaigns to “redeem” southern states from Republican rule and Black voters. As Bordewich relates in a harrowing account, those efforts had turned to South Carolina in the summer of 1876. Well aware that they were in the minority in their state, South Carolina’s redeemers had been waiting for a chance to “provoke a riot and teach the negroes a lesson,” as the future governor and senator Ben Tillman recalled. “It was generally believed,” Tillman wrote, “that nothing but bloodshed and a good deal of it could so well answer the purpose of redeeming the state from negro and carpetbag rule.”

The redeemers had their opening when two white men in a carriage confronted a Black militia marching in a Fourth of July parade in the town of Hamburg. When the two men returned for a court date four days later, they came with a mob and a cannon. The militiamen did not appear at the courthouse, but took shelter instead in a nearby building that housed their weapons and ammunition. In the ensuing standoff, the mob (including Tillman and his rifle club) began shelling the building. When the militiamen were driven from the building, the mob killed six of the men, as well as the town’s Black marshal, cutting out his tongue. The massacre was just a piece of what became a successful campaign to oust the Republican governor and legislature. The following month, a Black South Carolina Republican wrote to President Ulysses S. Grant begging for federal protection after another armed white group attacked a party meeting and demanded that the men “give up the flag” or be shot.

An 1878 painting of a congressional hearing addressing the disputed 1876 election between Samuel J. Tilden and Rutherford B. Hayes



AT THE CENTENNIAL'S CLOSING, on November 10, 1876, there was no providential break in the rain. Those on hand for the ceremonies packed into Judges' Hall for valedictory reflections and final rounds of Handel's "Hallelujah" chorus, Wagner's march, and a rendition of "America." Grant declared the exhibition over, and a telegrapher tapped out instructions to the Corliss Engine's operator to halt the great machine.

Three days earlier, on Election Day, the great machine of American self-government had also come to a halt. That year's presidential contest pitted New York's Democratic governor, Samuel J. Tilden, against Ohio's Republican governor, Rutherford B. Hayes. Neither was a man of great charisma—Tilden shy; Hayes upright, teetotal, and vague—but everyone knew what was at least nominally at stake in the election. In addition to taking on the widespread corruption with which the Republicans had become associated, Tilden promised an end to Reconstruction. Hayes paid lip service to the rights of former slaves, while also voicing his commitment to reconciliation between the North and the South.

Though the choice was not exactly stark, the outcome was opaque. Bordewich offers a concise account of the tangled mess that followed. Tilden won the popular vote and stood on the precipice of claiming the Electoral College, but given rampant problems and irregularities, the nation "teetered on the edge of a constitutional abyss," as Bordewich writes. The result came down to three southern states—Florida, South Carolina, and Louisiana—in which both parties claimed victories in state and national races.

Absent the violence and intimidation visited upon Black voters, the Republicans would likely have won each state, but winners were impossible to determine. Florida ended up with three separate vote counts. In South Carolina, where the number of votes exceeded the number of eligible voters, two legislatures and two governors vied for control and haggled over the presidency. Louisiana's electoral commissioner put the state's returns up for sale to the highest bidder, while a monitoring commission tossed out the results from 15 parishes in which the fraud and violence had been particularly egregious.

Another civil war loomed. While the White League in Louisiana threatened to attack the statehouse, and representatives of rival governments, all heavily armed, faced off in South Carolina, former Union General George B. McClellan, a Tilden supporter, talked of marching on Washington at the head of an army. Resolution came only through shadowy negotiations and political compromises. Congress created a special Electoral Commission—composed of senators, representatives, and Supreme Court justices—to determine the outcome, but its deliberations quickly

broke along partisan lines. In a series of backroom dealings, Democrats agreed to accept Hayes's election if federal troops were withdrawn from the South. Reconstruction, already heading toward a violent end in places like Hamburg, came to an official close as Hayes removed the last federal troops from the South, seven weeks after his inauguration.

NOT LONG BEFORE the Centennial Exhibition ended, a Massachusetts man published a poem in a Washington, D.C., newspaper telling "The Story of Hamburg," just a few columns over from a grim run of headlines leading an article on continuing violence associated with the election. The poem isn't in Bordewich's book, but, like the stark contrasts in its pages, the lines speak to our moment. "Let others tell of the nation's glory," the poet began; his attention would be elsewhere:

I sound no paeans of valor and fame—
My song is shadowed by strains of sadness;
I tell the tale of the nation's shame.

*The fight
over where to
look—and how
to look—at our
past remains
the crux of our
commemorations.*

On the 250th anniversary, we are no less caught between the glory and the shame than our forebears were on the 100th. Since the 1960s, the writing of American history has largely been a project of recovering and reckoning with conquest and its legacies, racism and the limits of democratic practice, and horrific events like the Hamburg Massacre. The aim of the official anniversary proceedings embodied in President Trump's 2025 executive order has been to "restore truth and sanity to American history"—and, in the process, to recover the glory and forget the shame. That effort was vividly realized in Philadelphia earlier this year, when the National Park Service removed a slavery exhibit from the President's House in Independence National Historical Park. A federal judge's order to restore the exhibit is now being appealed, and the fight over where to look—and how to look—at our past remains the crux of our commemorations.

Though we'll mostly be looking back at 1776 this year, Bordewich has done a great service in calling our attention to 1876. The soundness of our democratic machinery is again in doubt; we, too, wonder at the power of new technology, and what it means for work; race remains a source of conflict and a tool of power. Bordewich is as cautious in drawing such parallels as he is in spelling out the lessons that might lie in the juxtapositions of fairground and background. It's up to us to hear the echoes, and to make sense of the glory and the shame. *A*

Jake Lundberg is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

Science was supposed to bury God. *Instead, it keeps finding evidence of Him.*

Three discoveries that changed the debate — and what leading scientists now say about them.

PROBLEM I

The universe had a beginning

For centuries, materialists assumed the universe was eternal, meaning it required no cause and no creator. Then came the Big Bang. Einstein's relativity, Hubble's observations, and the discovery of cosmic background radiation converged on an unsettling conclusion that

time, space, and matter all had a definite starting point. But, if **nothing comes from nothing, the question of what — or who — preceded everything becomes unavoidable.** Nobel laureate Robert Wilson, who discovered cosmic background radiation, puts it plainly: "If the universe had a beginning, then we cannot avoid the question of creation."

Drawing on insights from 62 Nobel Prize winners and over 100 leading scientists across cosmology, physics, biology, and chemistry, this landmark work makes the rational, evidence-based case that science and faith are not enemies — they never were.

PROBLEM II

The universe is improbably fine-tuned for life

If we alter the gravitational constant by one part in ten to the sixtieth power, no stars form. Shift the cosmological constant even slightly, and the universe either collapses or expands too fast for matter to coalesce. Physicists have catalogued

dozens of fundamental constants that are each calibrated to extraordinary precision to make atoms, chemistry, and life possible. The probability of this arising by chance staggers even skeptical scientists. Voltaire once said he couldn't imagine a clock without a clockmaker. Today's scientists are opening the case of a far more intricate timepiece.

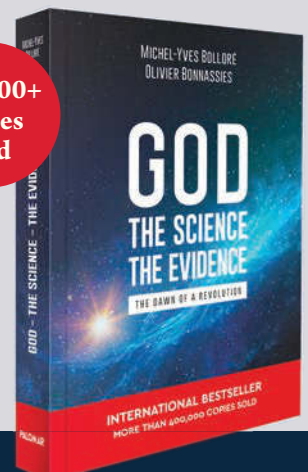
**"This book will change lives."
— Fr. Robert Spitzer,
astrophysicist
and philosopher**

PROBLEM III

Life cannot explain its own origin

Darwin accounted for how life diversifies, but he did not account for how it begins. The simplest living cell contains DNA — a molecule that encodes more functional information than any human-engineered system — along with ribosomes, proteins, and metabolic machinery that must all be present simultaneously to work. No materialist theory has successfully explained how inert chemistry spontaneously crossed into self-replicating, information-processing life. **The leap to life remains, in the words of biologists who study it, one of the deepest unsolved problems in science — and one that points, again, toward a guiding intelligence.**

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MUSIC

The Diva

Denyce Graves is retiring from performing after a career as one of opera's leading women. But there's more work for her to do.

By Soraya Nadia McDonald

When the curtain of New York's Metropolitan Opera House rose for the closing matinee of *Porgy and Bess* in January, the boos that typically accompany the entrance of the show's villains were a mere murmur. The nearly 4,000 people who packed the space to capacity—175 of them standing-room ticket holders who remained on their feet for the opera's three-and-a-half-hour run time—had come to cheer.

Thirty-one years before, Denyce Graves had made her Met debut in the title role of Georges Bizet's *Carmen*. The mezzo-soprano had been a revelation, her full, rich voice and lusty physicality defining the role for a generation. Graves was a diva in the original, operatic sense: a world-renowned performer who made journalists wilt, and whose name alone was enough to draw crowds. But here she was, playing a supporting character in *Porgy and Bess*. Graves was singing the part of Maria, the matriarch of the 1920s working-class Black community of Catfish Row, the Lowcountry settlement where the show takes place. It was set to be

JACK VARTOOGIAN / GETTY

her final performance ever, a return to the opera that had launched her professional career in 1985.

After intermission, but before the opera resumed, the entire company crowded onto the stage, and the house rose to its feet. Peter Gelb, the company's general manager, presented Graves with a plaque recognizing her career. It would be installed in the Met's List Hall, where aspiring artists audition. "My heart is unrehearsed at having to hold so much love," Graves said, tearing up and taking a few beats to collect herself. "It has never been asked to hold this capacity of love before."

It was a rare moment of harmony in a year—for opera as for much else—that had been defined by conflict. Just weeks after his second inauguration, President Trump had fired members of the board of trustees at the Kennedy Center—the longtime home of the Washington National Opera, the other major opera company that Graves had performed with for decades. He handpicked the artists recognized for the Kennedy Center Honors, banned drag queens from performing there, and affixed his name to the building's facade. He successfully pushed to dismantle the Corporation for Public Broadcasting, which for decades had helped opera find audiences on television and radio. After the WNO voted to leave the Kennedy Center early this January, and after several acts refused to play the venue in protest of Trump's changes, he announced that the building would be closed for "renovations" for two years.

The administration had also engaged in a sweeping campaign against Black history—against what it calls "wokeness"—perhaps most notably demanding a review of every exhibit in the Smithsonian's halls, singling out the National Museum of African American History and Culture, with its unflinching portrayal of slavery, as a purveyor of "corrosive ideology." Two days before *Porgy and Bess*'s closing matinee, National Park Service workers removed an exhibit at Philadelphia's Independence National Historical Park memorializing nine people enslaved by George Washington (the administration is now appealing a federal judge's order that the exhibit be restored).

Graves is a perfect avatar of everything the Trump administration seeks to eradicate, a fact that gave her swan song an even more sentimental air. She has consistently used the artistic capital she amassed through her mastery of the European canon to unearth and preserve Black history, and to promote productions that challenge Eurocentrism. She's sought to diversify the world of opera. And Graves does not consider her work finished, even if she has now walked offstage for the last time as a performer. With both the arts and Black history under attack, she is entering a new phase of her career, one that may well be more consequential than the first.

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AFTER THE SHOW, I found Graves backstage, already changed out of Maria's plain apron, shift dress, and sensible black Mary Janes. She wore a strapless burgundy A-line number paired with stiletto pumps, an ensemble more befitting a diva. A crowd had gathered outside the stage door of the opera house, and another in the front plaza of Lincoln Center, even as frigid winds cut through layers of clothing like X-Acto blades. A staffer coordinated a receiving line so that Graves could greet her frozen public before she was taken to her retirement party.

"I was genuinely surprised," she told me, speaking about the intermission ceremony, her voice deep-toned, like polished mahogany. "You know what I thought about? I thought about what we see happening right now, with our history being erased." The placement of the plaque in the Met's audition hall, where a new generation of Black artists would see it and perhaps be inspired, was what had touched her most.

Graves's path to the stage was challenging, in no small part because of racism. She was born in Washington, D.C., in 1964 and raised in a poor neighborhood in the city's Southeast quadrant. When she was 4 years old, riots erupted after the assassination of Martin Luther King Jr., and nearly 12,000 federal troops were deployed to the city.

Graves grew up singing in church, initially at the behest of her mother, Dorothy Graves-Kenner, who had to coax her daughter past her shyness and toward some sense of authority behind the microphone. Judith Allen, her first music teacher, recognized that she had something worth nurturing, both in voice and in presence. Allen took a young Graves to rehearsals of D.C.'s All City Chorus at Constitution Hall. At age 13, when Graves heard a record of Leontyne Price singing Puccini arias, she was struck with a revelation: She needed to be an opera singer.

With Allen's encouragement, Graves auditioned for the Duke Ellington School of the Arts, a D.C. public magnet high school seemingly worlds away from the racialized poverty that characterized her neighborhood. Still, when Graves informed her mother that she wanted to study singing in college, Graves-Kenner was surprised. People attended college to become doctors or lawyers. What on earth was her daughter going to do with a degree in something she'd already learned in church?

Graves ultimately studied at Oberlin College, where she encountered the first in a procession of gatekeepers who saw her as a misfit or a novelty because they believed that opera was a white art form. A professor told her, "This is not a place for you" when she showed up to his class, she recalls. Still, in 1985, she signed a contract with the Tulsa Opera, taking roles in *Porgy and Bess* and *The Magic Flute*. The former carries a fraught

reputation because it is a work about poor Black people, written and composed in 1934–35 by a white creative team (George and Ira Gershwin and DuBose Heyward), and almost always conducted and directed by white leaders. Even now, aspiring Black opera singers are warned against *Porgy and Bess*, lest they find themselves confined to Catfish Row for the rest of their career.

But Graves, like her Black-diva predecessors—Price, Marian Anderson, Jessye Norman—has always had a gift for transforming domains in which she was considered foreign, and making them bend to her. She went on to perform with the Vienna State Opera, London's Royal Opera, and the Paris Opera. Graves met her friend and close collaborator Francesca Zambello, now the WNO artistic director, when Graves was singing with the Bavarian State Opera and Zambello was directing the company's production of *Otello*. In 1995, Graves made her Met debut in *Carmen*. A busload of 75 family members and friends traveled from Washington to see her.

She was incredibly magnetic. Before that Met debut, a smitten Morley Safer interviewed her in her dressing room for *60 Minutes*, seeming more nervous to speak with her than she was about performing. Graves soon became an opera evangelist to young children, appearing multiple times on *Sesame Street*, including in a memorable segment where she uses Bizet's "Habanera" melody to fashion a lullaby for Elmo. She sang with BeBe Winans and Patti LaBelle, and released several albums. But if you really wanted to witness her talent in its fullest, you had to go see her in her element.

Unlike musical theater, there are no microphones in opera. When singing fills an opera house, it floats on the power of the lungs, assisted by only the acoustics and architecture of the room. Both the form and its fans can be unforgiving. But Graves was an *experience*, the sort of performer who reaches through the proscenium, grabs you, and doesn't let go until curtain. She more than held her own when sharing the stage with the Three Tenors—Plácido Domingo, José Carreras, and Luciano Pavarotti—the supergroup that made opera sexy and popular in the '90s.

In *Carmen*, and in her other signature role of Dalila in Camille Saint-Saëns's *Samson et Dalila*, she played seductresses with such believability and authority that many profiles raved over the carnality she projected. Her crossover appeal extended to the halls of power. Graves sang at the inauguration of President George W. Bush and became close friends with Ruth Bader Ginsburg, singing at the justice's funeral in 2020.

Graves used the fame and influence that *Carmen* brought to nurture her passion for Black artistic history. In 2005, she starred in the opera *Margaret Garner*, composed by Richard Danielpour, with a libretto by Toni Morrison. Garner was a woman in antebellum



Above: For most of Denyce Graves's career, the titular character of *Carmen* was the role most people associated with her.

Right: Graves sang at the funeral of her friend Ruth Bader Ginsburg in 2020.

Below: Graves's final performance brought her back to Catfish Row in *Porgy and Bess*, the opera that launched her career.



Kentucky whose escape from slavery—and decision to kill her daughter rather than allow her to return to bondage—had inspired Morrison’s 1987 novel, *Beloved*.

Margaret Garner brought Black artists together to an extent that few operas could, and since its debut, Graves has consistently supported Black vocalists, conductors, composers, directors, and librettists. In 2013, she sang in the composer (and frequent Spike Lee collaborator) Terence Blanchard’s first opera, *Champion*. In 2021, she went back to the site of her first paying gig, the Tulsa Opera, to sing in *Greenwood Overcomes*, a production memorializing the 1921 Tulsa Race Massacre.

Graves has always chased a sense of workplace and artistic camaraderie, of homecoming. I recognized it in the Met dressing rooms when I visited her: Black singers casually trading stories about jobs, directors, and cities, able to let down their guard and enjoy one another’s company. For much of Graves’s career, such a scene was a rarity. Instead, there was a tremendous, lonely pressure to be perfect. She wants things to be different for her heirs, for the future Black standard-bearers of opera. Implicit in this desire is also the desire for opera to persist, not as a remnant of its old grandeur, but as an art form that has been elevated by accessibility.

AS I SPOKE WITH GRAVES in the weeks before her final performance, she seemed ready, happy even, to say goodbye to performing. She could finally set aside the monastic life required to keep her voice in top shape. “I know I’m not going to have dairy,” she said, explaining a typical day to me. “I know I’m not going to have vinegar. I know I’m not going to have all of those things which cause acid reflux and which will play out in the quality of the sound. I’m even thinking about talking to you, and the cost of that. If you’re a violinist, you’re not playing the violin from the moment you wake up until the moment you go to bed. But you’re using your voice. It’s very, very different.”

Although Graves might be newly able to partake in cheeses and vinaigrettes, she is far from retired, and intends to dedicate more time to directing while continuing to teach and build her foundation, which aims to promote more diverse representation in the vocal arts. She made her directorial debut in May 2022 with a Minnesota Opera production of *Carmen*. Last year, she directed the world premiere of *Loving v. Virginia*, by the composer Damien Geter and the librettist Jessica Murphy Moo, which tells the story of Richard and Mildred Loving, the couple at the center of the 1967 Supreme Court case that ruled anti-miscegenation laws unconstitutional.

This March, six weeks after her retirement from performing, Graves was slated to direct the opening production of Washington National Opera’s 70th spring season, an expanded and reimagined version

of Scott Joplin’s 1911 opera, *Treemonisha*, with which the famed Black ragtime composer had intended to create a Black style of opera, before his death in 1917. Though Joplin paid to have the piano-vocal score published, his original full orchestrations were lost. Graves’s restoration would feature new orchestrations and arias by Damien Sneed and a new libretto adapted by the playwright Kyle Bass.

Treemonisha, which is set in the Texas wilderness in 1884 and tells the story of a Black woman trying to rid her community of the influence of conjurers and superstition, was originally scheduled to open at the Kennedy Center Opera House. But that was before all the unpleasantness began with Trump. The show would instead debut at George Washington University’s Lisner Auditorium. And if the production did not previously register as political, a revival of Black opera’s would-be foundational work by D.C.’s opera-in-exile just a few blocks away from the Kennedy Center certainly reads as a provocative statement now.

Graves was an experience, the sort of performer who reaches through the proscenium, grabs you, and doesn’t let go until curtain.

ON OPENING NIGHT, when Francesca Zambello and WNO’s general director, Timothy O’Leary, took the stage to introduce the production, they were greeted with a standing ovation filled with whoops and throaty roars, as though they were a couple of outlaws in formal wear.

“We deeply appreciate your understanding, your solidarity, and your belief in creative freedom,” O’Leary said. The opera opened with a banjo solo, and Sneed played Joplin’s score on an upright piano onstage.

The performance could never be exactly what it would have been in its planned venue. Opera is a big, melodramatic medium, designed for capturing big, melodramatic emotions. Although Lisner is a perfectly serviceable auditorium, it lacks the high ceilings, deep stage, and general grandeur of the opera house. The *Treemonisha* set didn’t have the three-dimensional, full-scale production value and enormous cast size typical of opera productions. The usual ornate set pieces were more modest and two-dimensional, relying on a floral-filigree wrap that evoked the background of a Kehinde Wiley painting. Sitting in the auditorium, I felt those constraints.

Even so, *Treemonisha*’s themes played to the times, and after the final number, in which the title character and the chorus repeat the refrain of “Marching onward, marching onward,” the auditorium erupted. Graves and Sneed joined the performers for the curtain call. And then the cast and the crowd joined together to sing to a surprised Graves. The debut was on March 7, her 62nd birthday. *A*

Soraya Nadia McDonald is a cultural critic and a journalist.

FICTION



Dinah's Hat

By Stephen King

On the day Dinah lost her hat, I was sitting on the top step of my just-right Scamp trailer doing a crossword. I was puzzling over nine-across, “Thai tidbits.” Seven letters. I had *A*-blank-blank-*E*-blank-*G*-*S*. I was debating whether or not to get my phone and look it up when Morris came out of his cute little Air-stream with Dinah’s push-chair in his arms. ¶ From the far end of Hallelujah Avenue, which ends in



a boat landing and a lick of beach, I could hear Bob Seger's "Heavy Music," an earworm if ever an earworm there was. Adding insult to injury, it seemed to be on terminal repeat.

My name is Sherry Winfield. That's Sherry with a *y* instead of an *i* at the end, which makes it old-school. I'm in my 70s now, and at plus-200, I'm sort of a truck. These days I'd look mighty silly in a mini, but there was a time, my friend, when I could knock your eyes out. I had moves.

That was then. Now I'm a widow living in the Happy Haven Trailer Park. I knit sweaters, play bridge, and attend the Mystery-Book Club every week, but—like you, reading this—I have a past. In my closet is a T-shirt that says a true thing: I MAY BE OLD BUT I SAW ALL THE GOOD BANDS. That would include Bob Seger and the Silver Bullet Band, by the way, although "Heavy Music" was never one of my favorites. I was more of a "Nutbush City Limits" gal (yes, I know Tina Turner wrote it).

Morris carried Dinah's chair down his three concrete-block steps and went back inside for the girl. I don't remember what date that was, only that it was overcast and humid and close enough to Halloween that I had bought a bunch of mini candy bars at the Publix up the Tamiami for the little ghosts and goblins.

Down the way, a bunch of young fellows are hooting and hollering. You know how they do when Friday afternoon is the launching ramp for Friday night. Back then I would have been right there with them, wearing my red bikini. Back then I had a tanned midriff you could have bounced a quarter off.

I went back to my crossword. Ten-down crossed "Thai tidbits." That one was "Connecticut river," and let me tell you what all veteran crossword puzzlers know: The places where tough clues cross are total pissers. I could name the state capitals, I knew most of the countries in Africa, ditto "The younger Guthrie" (Arlo) and "Old English *before*" (ere), but "Connecticut river"? Come on. There must be a ton of rivers in the Nutmeg State.

Except I didn't need to get off my fat ass and go look at my phone. Not when I had Morris.

He came out with his kippah perched slightly askew on his head and Dinah in his arms. If she grew a lot more, the girl would be too much for him, but the answer to both how long and how big she might grow was *not very*. How old was she on that overcast pre-Halloween day? I don't know. She might have been 6; she might have been 10 or 12. Her stomach bulged beneath her I ♥ FLORIDA boatneck and her face was round and waxy-pale. The swelling came courtesy of steroids, the steroids courtesy of everything that was wrong with her. Her eyes, a brilliant green, shone like bits of costume jewelry poked into an uncooked loaf of bread. Her legs and arms were white sticks.

Morris plopped her into her chair with a grunt of relief and pulled out the sunshade. Even with clouds, that UV is still a mother. From the stroller's back pocket he took a bright-red hat with a wide, floppy brim. On the front it said RIOT GRRRL. That kiddo was the furthest thing from a punk rocker, but I loved the sentiment and I loved the hat and I liked Morris for taking good care of her. He wasn't her father. I don't know what their relationship was, just that there were no suspicious cuts or bruises on her. He kept her clean. That was good enough for me.

"Sher-REE!" he shouted in falsetto, like Frankie Valli. He'd finished adjusting Dinah's hat. Between it and the sunshade, her face was in deep shadow. "How goes your life in our Happy Haven?"

"Not bad," I said, "but I wish those kids down there would move on to a different song. Even KC and the Sunshine Band would do."

He lifted Dinah's feet to display her plastic sandals. "Boogie shoes," he said. "Come with us. We'll urge them to change their tunes."

I had a doubt even then about whether or not that was a good idea, but I joined them. More fool me. "I don't suppose you know a seven-letter word for a Thai tidbit? Or a river in Connecticut, last two letters *I-C*?"

Dinah looked up at me from beneath her red hat. "Shah-ree." She smiled, showing her three remaining molars. They were leaning like old gravestones. I thought the

tooth fairy had gotten the best and would soon have the rest.

I took a knee—not easy when you're a heavyweight, but I wanted to get down to her level. "How are you, pretty one?"

"Goo!" Dinah smiled more widely than ever. "I goo!"

I raised one of her swollen hands and kissed it. "Great. I goo too."

"We ... two ... goo!" Dinah said, then laughed. She had a good one.

"Your Connecticut river is 'Niantic,'" Morris said. "Which makes Thai tidbits 'ant eggs.'"

Dinah made a face. It's hard to know how much she understood, but she clearly found the idea of eating ant eggs disgusting.

"Thanks! You're a wonder, Morris."

He shrugged. "I've done beaucoup crosswords in my day. I'm wise to their tricks. Walk with us?"

"All right." I filled in the missing letters of the head-scratchers and put the magazine on my cinder-block step. The few remaining clues looked easy. "Let's go. The beach, I suppose?"

"Yeah," Morris said. "She likes to look at the water. And the birds."

"Wah-wah burts!" Dinah said.

"Water and birds, that is correct, mademoiselle. Off we go."

The few street names in Happy Haven were determinedly upbeat, with Christian undertones. Hallelujah was the main thoroughfare. Crossing it were Redemption Street, Cheery Close, and Joyful Boulevard. Mostly we *were* cheerful (if not always joyful), but there were apt to be raised voices after drunk o'clock, when the Dead River Bar closed and the local bikers roared back down Highway 41. Sometimes it was the Harrigans arguing in their Aliner. Sometimes the Sanchezes in their fancy-schmancy Forest River. Once or twice there were gunshots, but that's not unusual in Florida, and nobody has ever been killed, at least to my knowledge, although Mitch Yellin shot himself in the leg two years ago practicing his quick-draw move in his backyard. Mostly we're all right. When there's trouble, it has a tendency to come from the water.

I actually thought this as we strolled down Hallelujah Avenue toward the music. I should have listened.

DINAH SUFFERED from some kind of cancer, complicated by a stroke, liver damage, and erythropoietic protoporphyria. That rare malady results in an accumulation of the pigment found in red blood cells. It causes acute sensitivity to sunlight, which was why she was so pale and Morris took her out only on cloudy days. Those days aren't all that common in Florida, which isn't nicknamed the Sunshine State for nothing. It's true that UV can mean a sunburn on cloudy days, but in bright sunshine, even with the shade over her stroller and her floppy RIOT GRRRL hat, Dinah would have cooked like a cheese sandwich in a microwave.

She could have lived a normal life with EPP if not for the cancer. That occasioned the steroids and probably caused the stroke. The liver damage might well have been caused by EPP, or maybe it came with the original equipment and was just waiting for the moment to jump out of its box and play its part in scrambling Dinah's brains.

Morris was closemouthed about her origins, but enumerated her various conditions with a kind of doleful enjoyment. He told me, after one of her frequent visits to Sarasota Memorial, that her condition was "on the border line." I didn't ask him what that meant, because I was pretty sure I knew. All I cared about was that, though Dinah bruised easily, Morris wasn't the cause. He and I were neighbors and friends, but not what I'd call besties, and I didn't want to get any closer to him and Dinah than I already was. I'd lost a few besties along the way, and I was not eager to lose another one. Or two.

The trailer park's main drag was paved, but at the stake fence that marked its end, the asphalt turned to hardpan dirt. The music became louder. Still "Heavy Music." The long version that's on Seger's *'Live' Bullet* double album. The road went down a shallow grade to the beach. The brochure for our trailer park proclaims FULL BEACH ACCESS, and it doesn't lie, but the beach is little more than a hundred-yard swatch of white sand with the boat landing on one side and the Sunset City condos on the other. It's a nice beach for what it is ... but it ain't much. And right away my bad feeling doubled. No, tripled.

See, half a dozen guys were down there, throwing around a big, old yellow Nerf football, kicking up sand, weaving around a couple of Styrofoam coolers, and tackling one another. A guy with a goatee yanked down another guy's salmon-pink board shorts, and I got a better look at his lily-white butt than I wanted before he yanked them back up. These were not preppy tourist kids but townies with townie buzz cuts. No girls; it was strictly a stag party. Sometimes girls have a way of mellowing guys out. Not always, but sometimes.

That wasn't the worst part, though. Drunk young studs are common as dirt on the Suncoast. The worst was the party boat they'd arrived in. I recognized from the blue and red pinstripes that it was one of the rentals from Cool Water Mama, in Nokomis. This boat's party days were over. The kid piloting it, no doubt drunk as a skunk, hadn't bothered anchoring, just drove it up onto the beach, where it now leaned askew, one of its pontoons dented and the other torn off and bobbing four feet out.

The kids didn't seem to know or care that when they got back—on foot—they'd be looking at a \$2,000 deductible. If, that was, they'd taken the insurance, and I guessed they'd been too high to bother. You could blame Skip Kilgallon for renting to them in the first place, but I had to give him a break on that. Until the season gets going after the year-end holidays, everyone on the Gulf is scraping by.

The speakers on the cabin of the gravely wounded pontoon boat were momentarily silent, then once more began to blast "Heavy Music." There were yells of *bro* and *dude*.

"You know what," I said, catching Morris's arm, "this might not be such a good idea."

"Burts!" Dinah said, and pointed toward the water. Under the thinning clouds, the Gulf was like a fogged mirror. "Burts!"

"No, it'll be fine," Morris said. "They are just having a good time."

"Such a good time that they wrecked one of Skip Kilgallon's pontoon boats," I said.

It was like he hadn't heard me. "And everybody likes Dinah. What's not to

like?" That was true, most people did like Dinah, and made much of her. *Coochie-coo* and all that. She wasn't pretty, and of course she was mentally disabled—had the mind and vocabulary of a toddler—but even so, she had a certain charm. Joie de vivre? Maybe. Morris liked to show her off. He also enjoyed the kudos he got for taking good care of her. So down the hill we went, into that throbbing, repetitive bass line and into trouble.

A blond kid, shirtless, tall, built like a brick outhouse, was the first to see the

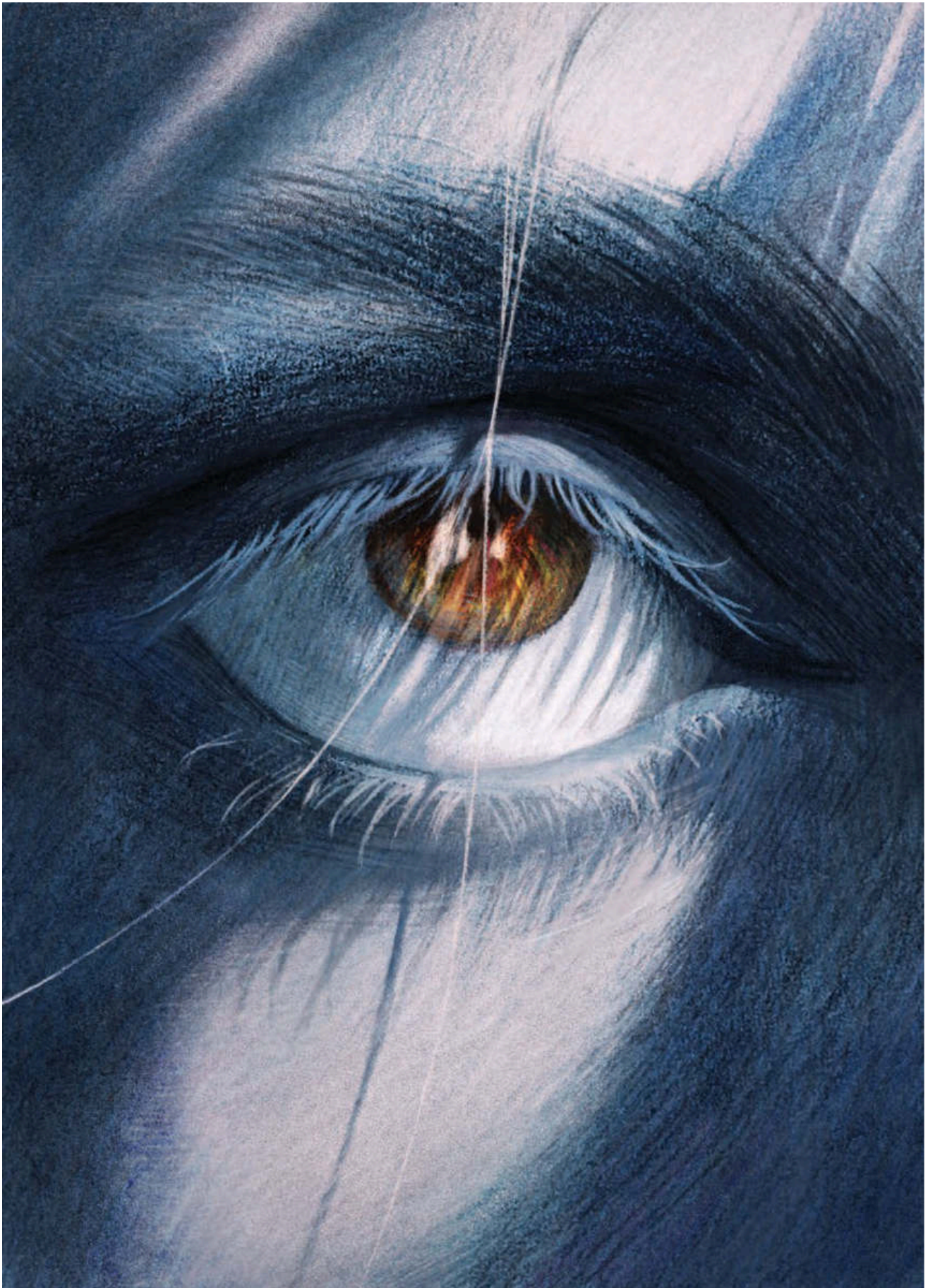
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stroller and the oversize girl in it. He grabbed a beer from one of the coolers and kangaroo-leaped over to us, kicking up sand and shouting, "Hey, baby! Hey, baby!"

Dinah gave her charming (mostly toothless) grin and pointed past him. "Burts! See burts!"

A tubby boy ran up, catching the Nerf football over his shoulder and falling on his knees, spraying sand onto Dinah's lap. He stared at her as if at an exhibit. "'Burts' is right! 'Burts' and Ernie! We're goin' to Sesame Street!"

The others clustered around, circling the stroller and throwing shade. The smell of beer and pot was strong.



"What's wrong with her?" one of them asked. He had a cat tattoo on one bicep. "Is she sick, or what?"

"She is *quite* sick," Morris said in a lecturely voice. "She has erythropoietic proto—"

"She's a alien!" another shouted. This one had a mohawk. He bent over, hands on sandy knees. Studied her and said: "A retarded alien. Are you a retarded alien, honey? Need to phone home?"

"That's not a word we use," Morris said, but Dinah smiled uncertainly.

The boys were crowding me out, so I elbowed back in. "Morris, I think we should—"

One of the kids, the boy with the trying-too-hard goatee, snatched off Morris's kippah. "Yid lid, Yid lid!" He spun it in the air. Morris lunged for it and missed. Goatee tossed it to Blondie and the boys spread out, throwing it around in a circle. They all started to chant "Yid lid." Dinah didn't like all the yelling. She started to cry.

I was pissed. Mostly at them, but also at Morris. He had wanted to come among this pride of young and drunk lions to show off his darling Dinah. He'd been expecting a lot of cooing and positive strokes, like when he pushed Dinah's chair into the circle of ladies who formed the Mystery-Book Club. He had ignored the warning signs, most especially the ruined party boat.

"Give it back!" I shouted. "Give it back, you fuckheads!"

The boy in the pink board shorts asked me if I kissed my mother with that mouth. The rest of them laughed.

The afternoon was brightening, the sun preparing to come through. If it did, it was going to be tough on Dinah. Just one more delight in what was turning out to be a delightful fucking day. The six of them weren't out of control, but dancing on the edge of it. *The boat*, I thought. *They either don't realize what they did to it, or don't care. Morris, what other warning did you need?*

One of the boys spun the kippah to the blond boy. Morris leaped for it, his face a mask of outrage.

"Look out, Morrie!" I shouted, but too late. His sandal-clad foot came down on the stroller and knocked it on its side. Dinah spilled out, at first too startled to

cry. Morris fell on top of her, knees spread to keep from squashing Dinah's chest and maybe killing her.

"Check it out!" Goatee yelled. "Yid boy's dry-humpin' his idjit daughter! Somebody call ICE!"

Dinah's floppy RIOT GRRRL hat had come off. One of the boys picked it up and threw it like a Frisbee. Tattoo Boy caught it, then spun it to Mohawk Boy. They were drifting down toward the water, the kippah forgotten in the sand.

"We have to get her out of the sun," Morris said.

It was still only a white disk above the thinning clouds, but the skin on her cheeks was red and a blister was forming over her right eye. The sunshade on her stroller had gotten twisted around its thin chrome bars, reminding me of the pontoon that had been torn off.

"Sherry, little help here!"

He picked Dinah up and settled her into the stroller. One wheel sank in the sand and she fell out again. She stopped crying, and that scared me more than anything.

"Stand back," I said, and picked Dinah up. "Get the stroller out of the sand. Hurry up."

The girl was surprisingly heavy. Sand had stuck to the mucus from her nose, giving her a mustache. The first blister had been joined by another.

Except for Blondie, the boys were now ignoring us. Which was fine with me. The one with the mohawk curled his arm and scaled Dinah's hat high into the air. The wind caught it and it sailed over the water, landing beside the half-submerged pontoon, which would never float again. Incredibly, everyone except the blond kid was laughing. He at least had the good grace to look worried. The maddening bass signature of "Heavy Music" played over and over.

Morris yanked the stroller out of the sand and I put Dinah in it. I will never forget her bulging eyes, so green, like sea glass. She knew something bad was happening but not what it was. Her scant hair was full of sand. I carried the stroller to the edge of the hardpan road that boaters used to back their small craft down to the edge of the water. Later that night I would have trouble bending over

and taking off my sneakers, but right then, muscle memory—and panic, that too—had me feeling 19 again. Once her stroller was clear of the sand, I stripped off my shirt and billowed it over the stroller like a tent.

"Holy shit, look at them jahoobies!" Goatee Boy called. He was handsome. He could have been a model in a catalog. "Are those 44s or 48s?"

"Forty-eight D's!" yelled the short, tubby one. He had a PBR in one sandy fist. "Those ain't tits, they're cannons! Anti-aircraft shells! Where'd you get a bra to hold 'em? Boobs R Us?"

Morris was looking dazedly at his kippah. He put it on his head. Sand fell out and ran down the sides of his face. The boys howled. I suppose it was funny, in a slapstick sort of way. Even Blondie was smiling, although he seemed to have some idea that the fun had gone too far.

"Morris!" I yelled. "Morris, come on!" He looked around at me as if startled out of a dream.

The blond boy came toward me, bumping Morris with one shoulder and almost knocking him over again.

"Listen," Blondie said.

I held up my hand like a traffic cop. "Don't fucking touch me."

"I'm sor—"

"Fuck off!" I yelled, and he backed away.

Tattoo Boy was wading out to get Dinah's hat. He grabbed it, waved it over his head, and whooped. The sun came out. Water droplets flew off the brim. I remember that. It's clear, like a photograph.

Under my shirt, Dinah was crying again.

"Morris! Morris, help me!"

"Her hat—"

"I don't give a flying fuck about her hat!"

We pushed her back up the hill, leaving the boys on the beach. The music cut out, creating a hole, one that was somehow as loud as the Silver Bullet Band in full flight. Pushing was hard because one of the stroller's wheels was now crooked. Dinah had gone silent under the makeshift tent. That quiet felt ominous to me. Like the sudden lack of "Heavy Music."

We were back where Hallelujah Avenue began. Except for Blondie, the boys were facing away from us, looking at the listing pontoon boat as if they were just realizing

they were going to be in a world of shit when they reported back to Skip.

The blond boy raised his hand tentatively. I gave him the finger, and there was nothing tentative about it.

MORRIS AND I had been neighbors for eight months or more, but I'd been in his Airstream only a few times—very few. (Not besties, remember?) It was small and dark and cramped. There were two chairs facing the TV, one big and plump, the other small and plump. They looked like garage-sale specials. I had carried Dinah in because Morris wasn't up to it. He sat in the big chair. Collapsed in it, more like, gasping for breath. I put Dinah in the small one and leaned on the tiny counter in the kitchenette, catching my own breath. Dinah was making a sound somewhere between a sob and a grizzle. "Bat boys," she said, and I assumed she wasn't talking about boys who were also superheroes.

"Give me your phone," I said. "I'll call 911."

"No," Morris said. "She's better. Aren't you, precious?"

"Bet," Dinah agreed. "Bat boys."

"They were," Morris said, and tried a smile. One thing I could say for Morris: He always tried to look on life's sunny side. "Probably they're sorry now."

"Sorry," Dinah said, then pointed at me. "Sherry!"

"You got it, cabbage," I said. "You got the head on ya." Then, to Morris: "We should take her to urgent care, at least. There's one on Bee Ridge."

"No need. She'll bounce back. She's gotten sun before and she always gets better."

Sun was the least of her problems, I thought, but she did look a little better. "At least let me clean her up."

His bathroom was the size of a telephone booth. It contained a sink, a toilet, and a shelf crammed with Dinah's prescriptions. There was no shower; he probably took care of his daily ablutions in Happy Haven's Courtesy Center. A damp washcloth was in the tiny sink, but it didn't smell mildewy. Morris wasn't the worst male housekeeper I've ever seen, but like most of them, *Mama will take care of it* was probably always somewhere in the

back of his mind. I wrung out the washcloth and wiped sand and snot off Dinah's cheeks and chin.

"Does that feel good?"

"Goo!"

"Yes, I bet it does. Give me a smile, can you?"

She did, showing her nearly toothless gums. She couldn't chew. When Morris fed her, it was mostly yogurt, soup, and Gerber dinners. Despite the nubs under her long-sleeved shirt that would one day be breasts (assuming she lived long enough), she was little more than a baby; childhood strokes are the gift that keeps on giving.

"You still should get her checked out," I said. "I'll drive you, if you feel like you can't—"

"No," he said again. Then, as if it were a great realization: "We should never have gone down there."

With a mighty effort, I restrained myself from saying, "I told you so."

Give him credit: He said it for me. "You told me that. I didn't listen."

Dinah's eyes closed. Her head slipped against her shoulder as she sat in her chair, reminding me of the pontoon boat, sitting beached and askew.

"She's going to sleep," I said.

"Already gone. Best thing for her. Knits up the raveled sleeve of care." He smiled. "I think I saw that in a Sominex ad."

"When you get around to taking her to the Courtesy Center, be sure to wash her hair."

"Roger that."

I realized I didn't know if he showered with her. She could stand and walk a little (although it was more like lurching), but I had never seen her run like a normal child. Because—duh—she wasn't normal. Could she wash herself? What would he do when she got her period? *Could* she get her period? What were they to each other, anyway? Did I want to know the backstory, or was that too far down the road to besties?

"I could go to Frankie's," I said. "Could you eat something, Morris?"

"Sure," he said. "A tuna-fish sandwich would be great. Mushrooms and lots of black olives. What do you want?"

"Pizza."

"Pizza gives me the runs," Morris said. "I think it's the oregano."

"TMI, Morris. Isn't that what the kids say?"

"If I ever was one, it's too far back to remember. Happy to buy. There's money under the book on my night table."

I thought of saying we'd go dutch, but I felt the first warning twinges in my back and decided that since he was the besotted fool who'd wanted to take Dinah down to the beach and show her off, he could pay for our dinner.

There was well over \$200 in 20s under a book called *Raising Children Right*. Thumbing through his stash, I realized I also had no idea where Morris got his dough. The Suncoast is pretty and its climate is temperate, but it's not cheap. Lot rental alone at Happy Haven is almost \$900 a month.

"Going," I said. "Back soon."

I CALLED IN the take-out order in my perfect-for-one Scamp trailer and had a wash. I picked the food up at Frankie's in my Neon. Dinah looked better when I got back. She was wearing a bib (I'M A BIG GIRL NOW) and feeding herself some kind of beige baby goo. She was also wearing a good deal of it. She raised one hand in a cheery wave when I came in. "Sherry! Fool!"

"Sherry with the foo, that's correct," I said. I got a couple of plates and a chair that went with the little fold-up table in the kitchenette. Morris and Dinah were watching the news. Shannon Behnken, in a pretty green dress, was talking about an air-conditioning scam in Tampa. The scammer wouldn't talk to her. No surprise there.

As I was cutting Morris's sandwich in two, there was a knock at the door. Because I was up, I opened it. Blondie stood there holding Dinah's red RIOT GRRRL hat. It was damp and looking bedraggled. Blondie looked rather bedraggled himself, but more or less sober.

"I'm sor—" he began again. I snatched the hat out of his hand and swatted his arm with it.

"You fucking should be." I started to close the door.

"No, let him come in," Morris said. "If he wants to apologize, he should apologize to Dinah."

I looked around, because Morris didn't sound like his dithery, good-natured self. He was using the same damp washcloth to clean Beef 'N Peas off Dinah's cheeks and mouth. Her green eyes were alight in a way I'd never seen before. She pointed at the kid and said, "Bat boy!"

"That's right, a bad boy," Morris said. "A bad boy who has something he wants to say to you."

"Where's your chums?" I asked him as he came in. Low ceiling; he had to duck his head to keep from bumping it.

"What's a chum?" He looked honestly puzzled. "Like, fish food?"

"Pals. Your pals."

"Oh! They went with Harley. It was Harley who rented the boat and it was Harley who beached it, driving like a mad motherf ... " He glanced at Dinah. "Like a mad mother. I'm Colin Jensen."

"Was Harley the one who swiped Dinah's hat or the one who called her a retard or possibly the one who threw it in the water?"

He didn't reply to that. He still smelled like a brewery, but at least he knew a rhetorical question when he heard one. "Harley will have to call his dad to pay the damages. Which he will. Harley is doing sh ... stuff like that all the time."

Morris bowed his head, making sure Blondie saw the kippah, which was still sandy. The sides of his face were flushed high up on his cheekbones, and were his eyes blazing? I know that's an overused phrase, total melodrama, but I have to say, they were. He was nothing like the ditzy Morris on the beach, but of course there was only one boy here instead of half a dozen.

"I take my Yid lid off to you, boychick."

It was Blondie's turn to flush, and I sort of liked him for that. I also liked him for having enough spine to come here. He must have asked which trailer the little retarded girl lived in ... although he might not have put it just like that.

"I'm sorry about that, sir. We were drunk."

"Sir! Now it's 'sir!' Such a gentleman!"

"Morrie, take it easy," I said, but he didn't seem to notice. Now I know that wasn't Morris's fury. He wasn't Dinah's father, but they were connected, all right. Oh boy, were they.

"Apologize to her," Morris said. "Me, I don't need it. I've been called a Yid before. And worse."

Colin was everything Dinah was not: handsome and healthy, tanned and smoothly muscled, in his prime. Dinah had never had a prime, never would. Fish-belly white, face and belly plump with steroids, hair a thin no-color that showed her scalp. Still, he went to her and knelt before her chair. On the TV, Juliana Mejia was

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way I'd never seen
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saying the fire danger was lower following the rain, I remember that as clearly as I remember Tattoo Boy fishing Dinah's hat out of the drink. How those drops flew!

Colin handed her the hat. "I'm sorry we scared you."

She clasped it to her chest. The TV burped static and the picture was obliterated by snow. Dinah's brilliant-green eyes turned red. I saw it. A tiny pearl of blood bloomed at the corner of each and ran down her fat white cheeks like tears. I tell you, I saw this. Her entire lower face bulged. Her lips were forced back by a cram of crooked fangs. One of her remaining teeth—her real ones—fell out

and tumbled into her lap. Her head darted forward. For a moment she looked like some kind of small but dangerous animal. Maybe a mink.

"Bite him!" Morris screamed. "Go on and bite him! Schlemiel! Kuckuhl!"

Dinah's head snapped from one side to the other. Just once. Colin cried out in surprise and pain. All at once the skin of his forearm, from wrist to elbow, was in bloody stripes.

Dinah drew back, wiping a mixture of blood and baby food from her mouth. The cuts in Colin's flesh—actually rips—were shallow. She could have done worse if she had wanted to, and I believe part of her wanted to. The animal part of her wanted to, but she fed Morris that part of her rage. If not, it might have been worse.

Blondie had entered Morris's trailer sobered-up enough to realize that they had done wrong, and Dinah now realized—in the dim room of her mind—that Colin had tried to make it right. Or as right as he could.

Blood was pattering down onto the carpet from Colin's wounded arm. The TV came back on, some final feel-good item about a bear cub caught in a culvert. The disfiguring bulge in Dinah's lower face went away.

"Oy!" Morris said, obviously distressed. "Look at this now, would you? Dinah, what did you do?"

I wasn't going to take off my shirt a second time. I got a dish towel from the kitchenette and wrapped it around the blond boy's tattered arm. He didn't even ask what she had done to him. He looked stunned. Which was how I felt.

"My gosh," Morris said. "Such a mess. What should we do, Sherry?"

That seemed clear to me. I was going to urgent care after all, just not with Dinah as my passenger.

IT WAS AFTER SIX on a weeknight, and there were only a few cars in the parking lot of the doc-in-the-box on Bee Ridge Road. Colin turned to me, his face as pale as Dinah's. "What happened, lady? Did you see her?"

"I did," I said, "but I advise you not to tell whoever treats you what we saw."

"Did you know—"

I shook my head. I was holding myself together, but just barely. I thought, *In time I'll be able to convince myself that never happened.* But as you can see, I never forgot. Everything is as clear to me as the droplets of water that flew from Dinah's hat when Tattoo Boy picked it up and shook it. As clear as Juliana Mejia saying the fire danger was low.

"Why don't you tell them you got those cuts when your friend Harley beached the party boat? They'll believe that. You may be sober now, but you still smell like Milwaukee's finest. If you tell them anything else, you'll have to tell them how a bunch of drunks harassed a little girl and stole her hat."

"What is that girl, ma'am? Do you know?"

"I don't."

I went in with him. When the doctor saw him, Colin told him about beaching the party boat.

"They look almost like animal bites," the doctor said. "You're going to need some liquid stitches."

Colin said, "The side of the door where I was standing was all splintered."

"That must have been it," the doctor said. We left with a prescription for antibiotics.

Outside, I told Colin he had done a good job, coming up with that story about the splintery doorway.

"I just want to forget the whole thing," he said. "You can drop me off at the Dead River. I need a real drink. Beer won't cut it."

I went in and had one with him, paying out of Morris's change.

THAT NIGHT, after moonrise, Morris and I sat out in front of his Airstream on lawn chairs. Dinah was asleep inside, snoring on her cot next to Morris's bed. We sat in silence at first, but then I asked Colin's question.

Morris shook his head. "I don't know what she is. Or where she came from. She knocked on the door one day, dirty and

wearing kid-size OshKosh overalls with one busted strap. There was a pocket in front. Inside it was a scrap of paper with her name printed on it. Just that one word. Scratched knees, black eyes, blood on her face. That was in Indiana. She asked—in her way—if she could have something to eat. My wife fed her soup and a sandwich. I was never a very good Jew. Marta was a little better. But we tried our best. Deuteronomy tells us to

I was holding myself together, but just barely. In time, maybe I'd be able to convince myself that never happened.

love the stranger, because we were strangers in the land of Egypt. Does that answer your question?"

"No."

"Me either. Mostly I don't think about it. Dinah could eat the sandwich because back then, she still had teeth."

"Wait," I said. "Wait a darn old minute. Your wife?"

"Marta died five years ago," Morris said. "Kidney failure, God rest her."

"How long has Dinah been with you?"

"It's almost 15 years now. She was sick then, but she's gotten sicker since then.

It's a slow process, but I can't wait for it to be over. To be free."

"She has ... what, a power over you?"

"When she needs to use it, yes. I'm her safety valve. I love her, which makes it better. She loves me. I think. I'm never sure."

"She goes to a doctor?" I was thinking of all the prescriptions crowding the shelf.

"Yes. I'll move in six months or a year so her local physician doesn't get suspicious. We're rolling stones, Dinah and me. We've lived all over the country."

"Where do you get your money, Morris?" It was a question I hadn't meant to ask.

He shook his head slowly. "You don't want to know, and you wouldn't believe it."

"Does Dinah have something to do with it?"

"Yes. That's all I'm going to say. I tell people she's 12 these days. I used to tell them she was 9."

I had other questions. What did she live on, really? It sure wasn't baby food. What was the extent of the power she had over him? What happened to his wife? Was it really kidney failure? Did those green eyes of hers glow in the dark, like a cat's? Would she die, or molt like a spider?

I could have asked these questions, but decided not to. If he answered them, that might make us besties.

"I should check on her," he said, getting up. "Make sure she's still breathing." He climbed the cinder-block steps to his door.

"Have you ever thought of putting a pillow over her face?" I asked. "Whatever she really is, I bet it wouldn't take long. Sick as she is."

He looked at me for a few seconds, then went inside without answering. I sat and looked at the moon and thought about her big red hat with the floppy brim.

Riot Grrrl. *A*

Stephen King is the author, most recently, of Never Flinch. His new novel, Other Worlds Than These, is a collaboration with the late Peter Straub, due out in October.

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- 1 What a violinist uses to play ...
or takes at the end of a
performance
- 4 Touch a touch screen, e.g.
- 7 Ooh and ____
- 8 Card with two potential values
in blackjack
- 9 *Three*, in Italian
- 10 Road-trip stopover
- 11 Some people think they're made
to be broken
- 13 "____ Your Mother Know"
(ABBA hit)
- 15 Two, for one
- 19 Utmost
- 20 Alysa Liu's Olympic team
- 21 Ham it up?
- 23 Pop star who founded Fenty
Beauty, to fans
- 24 Animal depicted on
California's flag
- 25 "Stop squirming!"
- 28 "False" accusation?
- 29 Soft-topped topper
- 30 *High* contrast?
- 31 Ensemble whose members
might don eyeliner and wear
side-swept bangs
- 33 Fish also known as a blue pointer
- 34 Applies
- 37 "Fancy seeing you here!"
- 39 Like a profile picture?
- 41 Evil roots, some say
- 42 No-nonsense
- 43 Youth org. that adopted a more
inclusive name in 2025



44 A capella syllable
45 Nice *one*!
46 Something that wears on you?
47 Square in a sleeve
49 Moved quickly
50 “Okay, okay, I get it now”

- 1 Animal that loves hanging out?
- 2 Implement used to row, row, row your boat
- 3 With 35-Down, idiom about tracing symptoms back to their probable cause
- 4 Part of a cat costume
- 5 Pimple-patch target
- 6 Tools that are mightier than swords only when you're not in an actual sword fight
- 12 Fair ____ (concept in copyright law)
- 13 Prehistoric beast, informally
- 14 Currently airing
- 16 Fighting style whose name comes from the Spanish for "little war"
- 17 Morales who plays a villain in two *Mission: Impossible* movies
- 18 Rodent of the Chinese zodiac
- 22 Rope for *un ranchero*
- 24 Loser of a late-1970s "format war"
- 25 "Buzz off!"
- 26 Pride-march participant?
- 27 Indecent
- 32 *Prince Igor* composer who was also an accomplished organic chemist
- 35 See 3-Down
- 36 Clears up some clogs, perhaps?
- 38 Set up in office
- 39 Venomous swimmer
- 40 Acre inhabitants?
- 41 Composer who wrote music criticism under the pen name "Monsieur Croche"
- 48 Stab



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